Vegan FAQ

Answering common questions about veganism

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Introduction

Welcome to Vegan FAQ

Vegan FAQ has a simple purpose: to list answers to common questions or comments vegans get when people discover they are vegan.

As someone who has had to answer these common questions a lot, I thought it might be useful to pen down some of my reflections on them. For each question, there is a quick, snappy answer, along with a longer, in-depth answer. Read them in order, or just read the ones you are interested in; it's up to you.

Origins

Anyone who has been vegan for a long time will have noticed a lot of positive change in the world. There are more vegan options in restaurants, more vegan products in the shops, and the products are often of a better quality. Vegan cheese, in particular, has come a long way. While veganism has never been more widespread in mainstream consciousness, actual vegans are still a relatively niche part of the general population. A lot more people have now heard of veganism, but they still don’t know much about it, certainly not the philosophical side of it. What this means is that when someone finds out you are a vegan, they will ask you questions, and after a while, you will notice these start to become familiar questions. Having good answers to these questions is important.

As a way to have fun with this reality, someone once sent me a meme called Defensive Omnivore Bingo. In the "game", you would tick off a square when you heard the same old conversational points. Inspired by this, I decided to make an interactive phone application called Vegan Bingo. I must admit, at the time, I didn't have a good idea of how the game of Bingo really worked, but the application was downloaded over a thousand times and got some good reviews. This inspired me to make the website https://veganbingo.net, which works on all devices. After a rewrite of Vegan Bingo, I decided I would turn it into a book as well, and thus Vegan FAQ was let loose on the world.

Being vegan in a non-vegan world

Personally, I’ve been through various stages of dealing with being vegan in a non-vegan world. As a new vegan, I was full of naive hope; I thought that we just needed to tell people about the reality of animal suffering in our farming systems and in nature, and they would start to change their behaviours. This was inevitably followed by disillusionment with the fact that people didn’t have any good argument for eating animals and the cruel treatment involved, but that didn't stop them from stubbornly defending it. I've reached a point in a discussion about eating animals where the person, seemingly out of desperation, finally said, "We are human, and they are not". Being human is a biological classification, not an argument for ignoring the suffering of other beings. There is a point where rational argument fails, and you realise people don't even care that their reasons aren't very good ones. They are conforming with the majority, and that is enough ethical introspection for them.

Many people say they love animals, yet consume animal products. Given the amount of

suffering involved in animal agriculture, with many billions of animals in it every year, you would think people who love animals would be highly concerned about the ethics of the system. Talking to someone who eats meat for a few minutes, however, often shows this not to be the case. They generally don't know the basics of animal agriculture, but in an example of the Dunning-Kruger phenomenon, they don't even know that they don't know. If you ask them a basic question about factory farming, they will give you a poor answer, one which is instantly refutable by a couple of minutes of research. They certainly aren't happy if you inform them or correct them about anything. Instead, they get annoyed at you for bringing to their attention the needless suffering of billions of animals, suffering they directly contribute to. I have a simple proposition for such people: Don't ask me why I'm vegan if you don't care about my answer and are just clumsily trying to justify your own apathy and inaction towards animal suffering.

Now that I've been vegan for a long time, I've come to what I think is a healthier and hopefully a more productive relationship with the non-vegan world. When people ask me questions, even stupid, loaded questions, I see it as an invitation to advocate for the animals. Just because I've heard the same question a hundred times doesn't mean other people have discussed it a hundred times. I don't expect that I am going to change anyone's mind in a single conversation, so I concentrate on opening cracks in people's perception, cracks that will hopefully eventually widen enough that they can properly see the animals and their unnecessary suffering. In learning anything, everyone has to go through various stages of truth. At some point, most ideas are new to everybody, especially ideas that are deliberately hidden or obscured in our culture. Like everyone else, my own conception of truth is also incomplete. I try to listen to people and their stories, and remember there is often something I can learn from them. I also try to remember that I ate animal products for the first 29 years of my life. I probably would have asked the same naive questions and said the same things to justify my own unexamined habits. By imagining my previous self in their place, I try to have realistic expectations for what I am likely to achieve with a single person or conversation.

At the same time, though, we should aim not just at the single person we are in conversation with, but rather at a whole culture. We want to push them more towards a positive conception of veganism, that our stance is not only compassionate but also well thought through. Each conversation is a chance to open minds and, by doing so, to shift the general cultural zeitgeist around veganism. We want to leave people more open to discussing veganism than when we found them. If next time they meet a vegan, see vegan products, or see something about a new documentary exposing animal farming, we want them to be more, not less, likely to engage after having met us.

Keeping the focus

Veganism is about our society's shared moral progress. Hopefully, we can bring more people along on this journey. Part of the right mindset starts with assuming other people are also trying to figure out how to live well and ethically in this world, just like we are. Some people may just argue out of ego and social status, or they like conforming and just don't want to change, or maybe they don't really have any higher ideals beyond selfishness, but it's not really easy to tell what sort of person we are talking to, whether they are open to change or not. Just because someone argues with us quite forcefully doesn't mean they are against veganism. Some argue rigorously and perceptively because they want hard proof of a position before they even consider adopting it. People don't change lightly after all, nor should they. We should accept and even encourage that. Our job is to be part of people's journeys, some of which may

be longer and more winding than others. We want to at least plant seeds of helping people see a truth that they might come to be thankful for.

We can keep making progress towards a vegan world, but it is going to take action, action with the same thoughtfulness, energy and dedication it has taken our society to remove other horrors of our past.

Vegan FAQ is an attempt to positively affect the cultural conversation from which that change can happen. If you'd like to get in touch about veganism or anything else, or just want to read my thoughts, check out my web page at https://camerongreen.org. For an online interactive version of this book, you can also check out the Vegan Bingo website at https://veganbingo.net.

Ahimsa!

Cameron

1. Protein

Question

Where do you get protein?

Alternatives

Where do you get iron? What about some obscure trace element (that they didn’t know about 2 months ago)?

Summary

When you mention you are vegan, many people suddenly become very interested in your nutritional requirements. Unfortunately, common knowledge hasn't caught up with the fact that most nutrients, including protein, originally come from plants. There are no essential nutrients that humans need that can only be derived from animal products, and the peak nutritional bodies affirm that a well-planned plant-based diet is healthy for all life stages. Healthy vegans don’t just remove things from their diet; they add other nutrient-rich foods in their place. By doing this, you can optimise your health while reducing your contribution to animal suffering and environmental destruction.

Discussion

At a party many years ago, a boy of about 10 brought a plate of snacks. I declined the offerings but mentioned I’d be interested if there were any vegan ones. He then promptly asked me where I got my protein from. I'd heard this question many times before, but something about his young age and the speed with which he asked this question took me aback. When an exact repeated statement is so prevalent in culture that it is imprinted in the heads of children, we should wonder how it got there.

As a vegan, my doctor has never asked me about my protein intake, for good reason. Protein deficiency is extremely rare in wealthy countries. People with a diverse and adequate caloric diet, vegan or otherwise, easily obtain the recommended amounts of protein. Protein is in a lot of foods, so we get portions of it all the time. Even if someone ate nothing but potatoes, so long as they ate enough to maintain their overall weight, they would come very close to meeting their daily protein requirements. So why are non-vegans obsessed with protein above the myriad other things that people need to be healthy? B12, for instance, is harder to get on plant-based diets, so vegans need to know about supplementing their B12. Vegans are rarely asked about B12, however, or anything else similarly well-informed; instead, we get asked over and over again about protein.

Plant protein primer

Despite the concern around how much protein vegans are getting, the people who ask about protein rarely know how much we need or how much is actually in different plant foods. There’s no shame in not knowing everything about nutrition; we aren’t born knowing such things, but it would seem reasonable to investigate a little before you criticise a particular diet or dole out nutritional advice.

How much protein you need changes according to a number of factors, such as life stage and your fitness goals. Recommended daily intake ranges from 0.75 grams of protein per kilo of bodyweight to up to 2 grams for elite athletes. Most dietary bodies have public guidelines you can follow, and you should consult a qualified nutritionist. Once you have a daily target for your protein intake, it's worth checking your current diet to see how much you are already eating. A food diary kept over a couple of representative weeks that can be checked against a nutrition database will give you a world of information about your intake of protein and other nutrients. Everyone should probably do this now and then to make sure their diet is consistent with their goals.

Now you can eat too much protein. Protein poisoning is also called "rabbit starvation" as the result of people in arid Arctic areas existing purely on lean rabbit meat. Although these people were eating enough food, their bodies were internally starving on ultra-high-protein diets. In diets of around 35-40% protein, the body starts to build up toxins such as ammonia in the bloodstream that can lead to nausea and even death. Protein poisoning, just like protein deficiency, is rare except in cases of people with medical conditions or extreme diets. People eating more than the recommended amount of protein, however, frequently experience a number of negative symptoms such as kidney stones, chronic dehydration, bloating and digestive distress. Like all nutrients, the magic is in getting the right mix, not any single one.

There is the concept of complete and incomplete proteins. The body produces most of the amino acids we need; however, there are a number we need to get from our diet. An ingredient is considered a complete or perfect protein if it contains all the necessary amino acids. Complete proteins include animal products but also soy, quinoa, amaranth, hemp, chia, and buckwheat. Then there are incomplete proteins, foods which contain a subset of the necessary amino acids, and good sources of these include nuts, legumes and wholegrains. It was once thought that if you were eating incomplete proteins, it was necessary to combine the right ones so that your meal would form a complete protein. The classic examples would be beans and rice, or bread and hummus, which together form a complete protein. Current research says that the body is smart enough to do this on its own, and as long as you eat a variety of whole foods, you will be fine. Eating more quinoa won't hurt, though!

For those who need to increase the protein in their diet, there are also protein powders, of which a variety are plant-based. These are commonly available and similarly priced to other protein powders. Many are based on rice, soy, pea, or hemp protein, though the variety is quite wide. Some of them use blends for those wanting to get a specific protein profile. Again, though, your body is smart enough to combine things, so if you are eating plenty of rice, you will be better off eating a legume-based protein powder.

The proof of the ability to get protein on a vegan diet is in the fact that many high-profile athletes, including Olympians, weightlifters and bodybuilders, follow a vegan diet. Olympic gold medallist Carl Lewis changed to a vegan diet at 30, after which he achieved all of his

personal bests, including setting the world record in the 100 metres at 9.86 seconds. Clearly, many elite athletes are getting what their bodies need for peak performance from a vegan diet. Nearly all of them also regularly consult nutritional professionals to make sure their diets meet their specific needs. We can all emulate these elite athletes and eat healthier diets that match our fitness goals while being kinder to animals and the planet.

Sexual politics

A hint as to where the protein question derives from is the gender of the people who usually ask about it. Many men obsess about their masculinity, which they relate to strength and muscle, and a single nutrient, protein. Protein, though, isn't the only thing required in the complex process of building muscle. We need enough calories to drive the growth process, fats to produce hormones, and carbohydrates to maintain energy levels. Still, few people ask vegans if we are getting the right mix of healthy fats; it is almost always about protein.

The masculine aspects of killing animals and eating meat have a long history in the human psyche. Most forager societies had gendered tendencies around the division of labour, with men taking on more hunting tasks, especially of larger animals. Men tend to be larger, stronger, and more expendable from an evolutionary perspective, so they were more suitable for dangerous tasks. Bringing in a large animal could give one status within the tribe, so while men focused more on this high-status task, it will come as little surprise that studies show that most diets in the Palaeolithic era were heavily plant-based.

The association between masculinity and violent killing, like many of our evolutionary tendencies, has been ripe for exploitation by the marketing industry. There has been a sustained and well-funded marketing effort to tighten the association between masculinity and meat-eating. Typical of this from my own childhood were the high-rotation meat industry advertisements on 1980s Australian television. The ad's focus was on a sports jersey-clad young boy. He runs into his family dining room, where his father reads a newspaper while sitting at the table with the boy's sister. The mother emerges from the kitchen with the burned, severed leg of an animal on a dish. There is no subtlety about the stereotypes or messaging here, or any thought to the diet of the women in the ad; the tagline is "Feed the man meat". These ads are reinforcing a widely held view in society. Studies have shown that even female vegetarians regard men who abstain from meat as more feminine (though they omit to mention whether the women thought that was a good thing). There is inarguably a sexual politics to meat consumption. Masculinity is aligned with killing; the more toxic masculinity, the more it celebrates and reinforces this alignment. Women tend to eat less meat, the majority of vegans are women, and women generally hold more pro-social views. Instead of clinging to their masculine identity like a security blanket, if many men could free themselves of it, we would progress a little faster to a better world. It was those who tended to gather rather than hunt who had things right all along.

Corporate propaganda

Decent people don't want to participate in cruelty. To make them do so, the cruelty must be mostly hidden, or they must be convinced that it is necessary. Meat and dairy industry propaganda reaches far more people than unbiased nutritional advice. The industry has long used its financial and political sway to ensure a dominant voice on government nutritional panels and has been repeatedly successful in watering down attempts to make national eating guidelines healthier. They maintain this propaganda war because nutritional science often

contradicts perceived national and regional financial self-interest. Not only do we not need to eat animals, but some of the most highly profitable forms of animal products that governments help promote are actively unhealthy. The International Agency for Research on Cancer, a part of the World Health Organisation, has listed processed meats like bacon as a known cancer risk, and red meat generally as a probable cancer risk.

National eating guidelines have been very slow to recognise plant-based sources of protein, such as lentils, one of the first crops ever domesticated, or tofu, which has been part of the Asian diet for at least two thousand years. This long-overdue change in guidelines is starting to happen because authorities are increasingly being asked to respond to science and human health rather than to economic interests. That this change has correlated with fewer purely patriarchal governments and more women in positions of power generally is unlikely to be purely coincidental. We can not take this improvement for humans and animals for granted, however, as it is under constant assault from the entrenched interests of the animal product industry.

Science and plant-based diets

The modern scientific understanding of dietitians about plant-based diets has been slow to filter outwards, even in the wider medical community. I've had an elite cardiologist ask me where I get my protein from, and I know many people who have heard similarly poorly informed things from doctors and medical specialists. Unfortunately, most medical professionals only receive elementary nutritional training and are as susceptible to the unquestioned and outdated ideas cluttering up our culture as everyone else. One study found that doctors in the US and UK received about 11 hours of nutritional training during their five-to-eight-year degrees. If we look at the opinions about plant-based diets from professionals who have completed an in-depth study of nutrition in their degrees, dietitians, we usually see a very different story. The public stances of peak nutritional bodies around the world generally state similar things to the following position of the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics:

"Appropriately planned vegetarian diets, including total vegetarian or vegan diets, are healthful, nutritionally adequate, and may provide health benefits in the prevention and treatment of certain diseases. Well-planned vegetarian diets are appropriate for individuals during all stages of the life cycle, including pregnancy, lactation, infancy, childhood, and adolescence, and for athletes."

For vegans, there is an important point here we shouldn't ignore. Vegans need to take note of the words “appropriately planned” in the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics quote above. The idea that vegan diets are innately healthy is almost as ill-informed as the idea that they are innately unhealthy. Vegan diets aren’t a magic bullet. Like all diets, they can be unhealthy if they contain too much sugar, oil, fat and fried food, and don't contain enough fruits, vegetables, pulses and whole grains. Perhaps the easiest test of the healthiness of a vegan diet is how regularly they include whole beans and lentils. A vegan diet is different to the diet most people in our modern world grew up with, so there might be some learning and adjustment needed. This is particularly true for people who grew up in a family that followed a meat-centric diet or one high in highly processed foods. They may need to learn how to cook in a healthier way, or perhaps even learn to cook at all. A healthy vegan diet isn't one in which animal products are simply removed, but one in which they are replaced with plant-derived alternatives. There is a whole world of ingredients vegans and non-vegans should be more familiar with, particularly the incredible variety of beans and legumes that have been staples of

human cultures for so long.

Obsessing over a single nutrient isn't a good idea, especially if it leads to an unbalanced diet. Vegans who eat a whole-foods, plant-based diet don’t need to worry much about things people who eat too much meat and processed foods struggle with, such as fibre, antioxidants, healthy fats, vitamin C and the other goodies that fruits, vegetables and plant protein sources are loaded with. Instead, people on plant-based diets should keep an eye on having adequate sources of things like calcium, vitamin D, and omega-3s, and of course, B12, which they should supplement.

In the end, we should be getting our nutritional advice from qualified dietitians, not friends, family, random people, social media or even what you are reading now. A great investment in improving your health is booking a couple of sessions with a university-qualified nutritionist who understands plant-based diets. They will help you ensure your diet is working towards your long-term life goals. People can become overly obsessed with food, so it's not about purity, but getting the core of your diet right will serve you well for life.

Healthy food is a gift we can give ourselves and others that will help maintain physical and mental health. It will also positively reverberate out into the world. As a quote attributed to Hippocrates says, "Let thy food be thy medicine". Let us follow this advice while also ensuring our food is kinder to animals and the environment.

2. Cheese

Question

I could never give up cheese

Alternatives

I could never go vegan because... but you won't need any other alternative because you'll be hearing about cheese repeatedly.

Summary

Cheese is mostly about two things: fat and cruelty to animals. By giving up cheese, you will reduce both your fat intake and your contribution to suffering. More than other animal products, it is common for people to say they feel better after giving up dairy. This is unsurprising, as, like all other mammals, humans are naturally weaned from their mother's milk after infancy. Only a third of people globally have the genetic mutation necessary to process lactose beyond infancy. The experience of expressing and imbibing milk evolved as part of the intimate relationship between a mother and her child. For humans to interfere in this relationship, to commercialise the pregnancies of other species, is oppressive...and slightly weird and creepy.

Discussion

The statement "I could never give up cheese" implies an unspoken corollary: "I don't care what cruelty or environmental destruction is involved in producing it". Hopefully, most people are better than this, and there is a line of cruelty towards animals that they would not cross. Would many people really continue drinking dairy if they became convinced it was both unnecessary and intolerably cruel? Assuming they can become informed about this, we would hope that people could find enough self-control and compassion for other species to make a positive change.

The problem is that few people who drink dairy know, or wish to know, the truth behind the industry. If they educated themselves about the bereaved mothers, stolen calves, swollen udders, mastitis, castration, confinement, veal production, contribution to antibiotic resistance, human health problems and environmental degradation associated with dairy, it would be easier for them to find the moral courage to make the change from dairy to any of the many alternatives.

Milking them for all they are worth

To turn cows, who are sensitive and caring mothers, into milk machines requires regular cruelty.

Some of the cruellest parts of the dairy industry stem from milk and pregnancy being intertwined. Cows, like humans and other mammals, will produce milk only due to pregnancy. As soon as cows are able to bear calves, they begin a cycle of annual impregnation. This is to keep milk production high, as it would naturally slow ten months after pregnancy. Over their milk-producing life, a cow will be milked continually, except for a two-month "dry period" before each calf is born. The majority of cows will be impregnated artificially, via a device wielded by a farm hand. Traditionally, and still practised in many places, cows will be impregnated on something the industry calls "the rape rack": a device on which cows are restrained to be mounted by a bull. Before modern methods of sexual selection, half of the calves born would be male, creating vast numbers of unwanted, less profitable calves. Today, it is more common to inseminate dairy cows with semen from beef-specific breeds. This keeps milk production high while producing offspring that can be profitably sold for slaughter. Farmers separate calves from their mothers, usually within 12 to 24 hours of birth. This ensures the calves don't drink their mother's valuable milk and tries to minimise the development of a maternal bond between the mother and child. The pain of the separation between cow and calf is well documented in heartbreaking footage accessible online. They show distraught cows running behind vehicles that are taking, probably yet another, calf away from them. One can hear the emotion in both mother and child as they vocalise the pain and grief of their separation. Perhaps it should be legislated that this sound is played when one opens a bottle of milk or a packet of cheese.

Unwanted male dairy calves, sometimes called "Bobby" calves, are often funnelled into the veal trade. Female calves also can be destined for this fate if a farm has more cows than it needs to reproduce their herd, or if market conditions make it especially profitable. As dairy breeds are slowly growing and less muscular than beef breeds, it is unprofitable to raise them to adulthood, so they are slaughtered as calves for veal. Veal calves were once raised in narrow, solitary crates to ensure they got minimal exercise, though to achieve this end, they are now more commonly raised in group sheds. They are given a controlled diet, often low in iron, to ensure their flesh doesn't toughen and become pink. Instead of their mother's milk, they are fed on formulas partly composed of whey protein, a waste product from cheese production. Veal calves are then slaughtered at ages ranging from just days to, more rarely, a few months old. Calves not destined for the veal trade will be slaughtered for uses such as leather or pet food and other low-grade meat.

If not surplus to milk production requirements, female calves will go on to join their unfortunate mothers in the cycle of suffering and death that results from life as a milk and calf production machine. They will endure having their horns removed (debudding) without anaesthetic, mastitis from over-milking, annual pregnancies with calf separation, and lameness from living with oversized udders that are the result of generations of selective breeding to produce ever more milk. This will all end in transport to a slaughterhouse, often itself an ordeal that involves being starved and dehydrated to make slaughter cleaner. It's strange how often people will say, "You don't have to kill cows to get dairy". Yet more evidence of the disconnect with the reality of animal farming systems. Every cow, beef or dairy, is destined, while still relatively young, for the horrors of slaughter. After a life of intensive calf and milk production, cows are killed when their fertility drops and their production becomes less optimal, usually between four and seven years of age. Left alone, these intelligent animals would live three to five times longer, becoming matriarchs and important members of their communities.

Dairy's long shadow

Apart from routine animal cruelty, the dairy industry is also among the most environmentally destructive industries on our planet.

Dairy is a major contributor to deforestation, species extinction, air pollution, water consumption, water pollution, and greenhouse gas emissions. As outlined in the landmark Poore & Nemecek (2018) study, dairy milk production uses ten times as much land, produces three times as many greenhouse gas emissions, and consumes twenty times more fresh water than equivalent plant-based milks. Dairy utilises not only the land on which cows graze, but also massive areas of cropland to produce their feed. The vast quantities of manure and urine produced by the dairy industry globally run into water and soil systems. This triggers eutrophication - with the excess of nutrients causing, among other things, algal blooms that reduce oxygen in water systems and lead to mass fish kills and dead zones. The dairy industry rarely pays the cost for its negative effects on the environment, but it outsources those costs to governments and communities. Just grabbing a different carton from the supermarket shelf can drastically improve not only your ethical but also your environmental footprint.

Many people will have heard of the Antibiotic Resistance Crisis, which is threatening to undermine one of the pillars of our modern health system. What many people don't know is that animal agriculture uses over two-thirds of antibiotics globally, often fed as a precaution to healthy animals. Due to the mastitis caused by over-milking via machines, the dairy industry is a major user of antibiotics globally. Livestock animals do not consume all of the antibiotics they are fed; instead, the excess is washed into the environment along with their urine and manure. This environmental contamination creates a perfect evolutionary breeding ground for antibiotic-resistant 'superbugs', posing a severe, systemic threat to both animal and human health.

Necessary?

Given the negative impacts of dairy corporations on animals and the environment, how vital are they to feeding our global population?

Only about a third of people worldwide have the genetic mutation necessary to process dairy. Strangely, not having this mutation is often called lactose malabsorption, which makes it sound like a condition some people have, when it is actually our natural state. Humans are mammals, and mammals don't drink milk beyond early childhood; they are weaned off it by their mothers onto solid foods. This enables the child to be self-supporting and gives the mother's body a break from the costly biological function of producing milk, a phase of the reproductive cycle that consumes more of the mother's energy resources than even pregnancy. When mammals exit infancy and stop consuming milk, their bodies naturally reduce the production of the enzymes needed to process lactose.

The majority of humans throughout history have also followed the standard mammalian path. Thousands of years ago, however, in cattle-dependent regions of Europe and Africa, genetic mutations occurred that kept lactase, the lactose-digesting enzyme, active after childhood. That mutation, called lactase persistence, is still a minority in all large populations other than those of Northern and Western European descent. Even for people with the genetic mutation, this ability tends to degrade as we age. Due to the prevalence of dairy products in many foods, especially comfort and fast foods, people will often continue consuming dairy even though they

are unable to digest lactose. It is often not until people get a diagnosis or follow an exclusion diet that they figure out the cause of their digestive and other related problems. This is part of why people who give up dairy often report feeling better, even more so than those who give up other animal products.

Dairy is an acquired taste, a taste that will be lost over time. I can personally attest to this. I honestly thought I would not notice if I were accidentally served cow's milk in a coffee or other drink. I even said to friends, "It has probably happened, and I haven't noticed". On the rare occasions I have accidentally been served dairy, I have found I notice immediately, and that it has a very unpleasant taste compared to my regular plant milk. Dairy has a strange sort of musty, sour flavour, something that reminds you that cow's milk has pus in it, the levels of which are more elevated today because of the mastitis that cows' udders frequently get from milking machines. Even most dairy consumers don't seem to like that musty, sour flavour very much, as is evidenced by the highly processed, less flavourful cheeses and sugar-laden yoghurts that dominate markets. A good quality dairy alternative often tastes smoother and cleaner. Try oat milk in your coffee or beverages for a little while, and you won't want to go back.

Compassionate choices

Dairy is neither kind, sustainable, nor necessary. So how do we start moving beyond it?

Butter and cheese can be replaced by anything with some fat in it. Avocado is a common go-to for replacing them in sandwiches, burgers and salads. Depending on the dish you are preparing, there are numerous other options, such as various nut spreads, plant oils, tahini and countless variations of the amazingly versatile hummus. There are also plant-based versions of most dairy products that are getting better and more varied all the time, such as soft cashew cheeses, hard cheeses, cheddar-style slices, and even blue cheeses. Try asking for vegan mozzarella on your next pizza, and you probably won't notice much of a change at all. Milk is perhaps the queen of plant-based options. There are so many types to choose from, it is hard to keep up. Oat, hemp, almond, cashew, soy, rice, coconut and various blends of them are all popular, and they come in many styles such as light, creamy and specialised barista versions. You would have to be pretty determined not to find a plant-based milk that you like. Soy milk is probably the most nutritionally complete; oat milk is generally the people’s favourite for taste and texture; and almond milk is very popular too if you like a slightly nutty taste. Some people also like the richness of coconut milk, which can work well in sweet drinks and smoothies. For yoghurt and ice cream, there are also a vast number of alternatives, with coconut being very common, but try a few and figure out which ones are to your taste.

Are these alternatives all the same as the dairy products you've acquired a taste for? With a few exceptions, the answer is usually no. They are made from different things, so you may need to acquire a taste for them, just as you once did with dairy products. It's worth doing so for all the ethical reasons already outlined, and it is a positive change you can make at a very low cost to yourself.

There is a massive industry trying to keep you invested in dairy. Milk and dairy corporations are often huge, with major government support and subsidies. There is a whole deep dive you can do on the US Government Cheese programme: a vast stockpile which was partially responsible for cheese being so deeply embedded into the modern American diet. The marketing and lobbying power of the dairy industry reaches into our governments and homes

globally. National Dietary guidelines are regularly published by countries, and they affect what is served in prisons, schools, hospitals and the military, and feed into the public understanding of nutrition. Groups of well-funded animal-oppressing corporations and lobbying groups attend reviews on national dietary guidelines, with the dairy industry often being one of the biggest spenders amongst them. The dairy industry is also a major funder of academic research, which is vital to its interests, as studies funded by food corporations have been found to be between four and eight times more likely to have findings that align with their economic interests.

Be the change

Positive life changes can be hard, such as getting to bed earlier, exercising every day, keeping hydrated, being kind, being grateful, and keeping the ultra-wealthy from corrupting our political systems. We often know what we should do, but find it hard to find the motivation to follow through with it. Giving up dairy, though, is very low-hanging fruit with little personal cost. Why not take this quick win for compassion and the environment? When ordering coffee, it is literally as easy as adding one word like “oat” before your order, or maybe just asking your barista which plant-based milk they recommend. When shopping, just reach for a different part of the shelf where the milks all are. Try a pizza with vegan cheese, pine nuts, or just some extra splashes of olive oil. A little exploration, some often small changes in habits, and you won't look back.

Finally, this may be heresy to many vegans, but if cheese really is that much of a sticking point, then don’t make the perfect the enemy of the good. Start somewhere else. Make perhaps the easiest change of swapping to plant milk, or maybe you only order vegan cheese when you find it's pretty decent. Vegan cheese on pizzas is fine, and I have had many people try my vegan pizza, after which they almost always say, "If you didn't tell me, I wouldn't have noticed". Eating less dairy is a good start, especially for the animals, so don't create unnecessary barriers to positive change. Like breaking other habits, sometimes it helps to minimise the habit first, have a transitory phase, so the final break seems less of a change. Millions of other people like you have made this positive change and would never look back, so you can too. Don’t think of it as giving something up, but instead as living more truly to your higher self.

You can give up dairy; you can lean into your compassion; you can be a powerful force in helping to create a kinder world.

3. Cows

Question

Where would all the cows go?

Alternatives

What about all the farmers? What about the open landscapes of the countryside? Isn't soy destroying the Amazon?

Summary

Farm animals are not left to breed among themselves. It should come as no surprise that nothing is left to chance in the big business that is intensive animal farming. Breeding is strictly controlled and responds to the laws of supply and demand rather than the needs of animals or their welfare. If people eat fewer animals, livestock corporations will artificially breed fewer. It may be interesting to think about “what if we all suddenly stopped eating animals?” But, back in reality, the transition will probably continue to be gradual, and our economies will have plenty of time to adjust.

Discussion

When people try to justify why they eat animals, the main thing the conversation generally reveals is how divorced people are from the reality of modern industrial farming.

Animal agriculture today bears little resemblance to the way animals were kept on farms for most of human history. General knowledge appears to have advanced little beyond the children's book images of a cow called Daisy wearing a straw hat, the rooster on the fence greeting the sun, and the anthropomorphised pig, smiling while enjoying a grassy field. Certainly, these are the sort of images the livestock industry adorns its products with, but it is strange that adults would believe an industrial system with billions of animals in it is still anything like Old MacDonald’s farm.

Modern animal farms have thousands or even millions of a single gender and breed of animal, crowded into conditions where the only limit on cruelty is anything that might interfere with profits. Cruel ways of slaughtering animals are sometimes changed, not because they are cruel, but rather because they flood an animal's body with so many stress hormones that they are detectable in the final product. Chopping off tails, horns, beaks, and genitals is all routine and done without anaesthetic. Animals are taken from their families, fed alive into grinders, and experience regular horrors that are considered just part of the business. Except for vegans who don't contribute to the system, only a tiny minority of the public seems to care about any of this. The profits of animal agriculture corporations are heavily increased by the near-total apathy of many animal product consumers towards the lives of animals. Animal exploitation is

big business, run by vast corporations to maximise profits for owners and investors. This is a part of society where slaughtering even more animals is something only to be celebrated. In this chain based on the oppression of other forms of life, extending from corporate executives to end consumers, only a vanishing few people involved will ever spend a moment to bear witness to, or even think about, the lives and deaths of the animals in the system they pay for and profit from.

Genetics, like everything else in an industrial factory farm, is highly controlled. The search for profits is evident in the manipulated bodies of livestock animals. Turkeys, for instance, have had their natural form so warped by selective breeding that not only are they unable to fly, but they are also incapable of breeding naturally and must be inseminated by humans. Many farm animals, after generations of selective breeding, live with bodies that outgrow the ability of their skeleton and internal organs to support them. No animal on these farms gets to live anything like a natural lifespan, but it is perhaps a mercy for many to be slaughtered at such a young age, rather than live with the painful bodily mutations we have bred into them. Animals on factory farms do not breed naturally at their own inclination; they are only brought into existence when we breed them. If breeding these animals were no longer profitable, the majority of them would disappear in less than a generation.

Ethical transitions

From the point of view of social change, it’s also not a well-thought-out question to ask what happens if industrial animal farming ends overnight, just because that’s rarely how improvements in the ethics of society happen. Some of the horrors of the past took decades and centuries of thought and movement building to change. Ideas often spread slowly in society, usually championed by small groups of committed individuals. Often, there comes a sudden change, a moment when a tipping point occurs. Legislation banning unethical practices is finally passed, and the social license of common consent for them is withdrawn. There may be many more vegans today than decades ago, but we are still a small minority. We are far from any position enabling us to widely legislate more humane farming, much less abolish animal farming.

Our animal product-consuming friends needn't worry. Sadly for animals, animal agriculture is not going to end tomorrow. They can give up animal products without the nightmare of factory farms empty of tortured animals, or of the killing floors of the slaughterhouses ceasing to be covered with the blood of innocents. They don't need to worry about the rewilding of nature, or of native animals and plants reclaiming the pastures that for millions of years prior to animal agriculture were their homes. Instead, we should be glad that the real nightmare will end, the horrific system that the eating of animals on an industrial scale has created in our world. We can say a long overdue goodbye to the hooks, cages, brands, barbed wire, whips, electric prods, slaughterhouses and countless other tools of animal oppression. It is not only nothing to fear, but the reduction of much fear caused by humanity in the world.

Crisis or progress?

As for what will happen to the jobs of the animal farmers, butchers, slaughterhouse workers and others in the livestock industry, that change will also happen gradually. People will transition to other work and products, just like so many changes in industries and technologies have happened in the past. New opportunities will be created because people will still need food and will still need to eat the same number of calories and nutrients. Those farmers and

businesses that succeed will be those best able to adapt to more animal-friendly foods. This change will also be better in the long run for the people involved in the cruelty of animal farming. If fewer poor people are living psychologically traumatising lives, spending their days stabbing, slaughtering and dissecting animals in sheds hidden away from the rest of society, then that's a win for animals and humans. People working in animal agriculture, especially in slaughterhouses, cannot do so without damaging some part of their psyche. We see this in higher rates of violence, trauma, intense shock, paranoia, anxiety, guilt and shame. These poor, often immigrant, workers, who are paid to do animal agriculture's dirty work, work that few of us would want to witness, much less do, will only be helped by transitioning to less violent work.

In the past, when society has legislated an end to cruel or outdated practices, transition plans have been put in place, including paying compensation. Nobles and owners were often compensated when serfs or slaves were freed. Although we think it strange and unjust for the state to pay out to people involved in what should always have been a criminal enterprise, it was deemed necessary for society to adapt and move forward at the time. Upton Sinclair once said it was hard to get a person to understand something if their salary depended on them not understanding it. We might expect the same about what they think their food depends on. Most people know on some level that factory farming is cruel, but as with other atrocities of the past, it might take some distance from it for people to comprehend the full horror of what they once tolerated.

As for all the open fields in the countryside, people may have grown accustomed to their current state, but it is cleared land that is more sterile and hostile to species than it has been for millions of years. If we watched the trees being felled in making these cleared spaces, and saw the native animals being killed or dispersed, we might think differently. It was once said about the Roman Empire that it created a desolation and called it peace. Something similar could be said about clearing complex forest ecosystems to create livestock pastures. We should think more deeply about what we are looking at when we pass a deforested pasture populated only by animals enclosed in barbed wire. We rarely think about the story of who and what lived on a land in both city and country before it was cleared for human development, and who the beings were who lived there before being killed, removed or dispossessed. The fields that have now been turned into monocultures of introduced species were once complex ecosystems, bustling with life in forms endless and beautiful. Ecosystems integrate millions of years of evolutionary wisdom in their subtle balance. In beginning the process of restoring them, we must hope that not all that deep wisdom has been irrevocably lost. At least some of the workers freed from animal production industries could find more meaningful and healing work rewilding the places we have so denuded, allowing the native flora and fauna to reclaim their ancient homes.

Rewilding

The benefits of rewilding the pastureland of our world would be many. Livestock farming and the crops grown to feed livestock cover a huge percentage of our globe. Environmental reports from the United Nations and other authorities have long said that livestock farming is one of the primary causes of environmental degradation. It is a leading cause of species extinction, deforestation, water pollution, air pollution and most other environmental problems. The monopolisation of land by the livestock industry is not just a cruelty done to non-humans. Much of the land of dispossessed poor and indigenous people over recent centuries has been usurped to farm high-profit livestock by privileged elites and colonisers. The already large carbon

footprint of livestock farming, quoted by bodies like the UN, usually does not include the carbon reduction we would all share by rewilding millions of acres of pasture and cropland currently dedicated to livestock and their feed. Other than our reliance on fossil fuels, there is no other consumption we engage in that competes with animal agriculture in terms of negative environmental and political impacts.

Amazonian myths

While we touch on the environment, we must deal with something that has been said to vegans as long as I have been vegan: "Soy is destroying the Amazon; therefore, vegans are destroying the Amazon". I first heard it two decades ago when I already knew it was false. A friend just told me someone said it to them recently. Firstly, vegans are a small (but beautiful) percentage of the human population. So while they may eat more soy than average, vegans would have to be eating 50 times more soy than the rest of the population for the problems surrounding soy production to be laid solely at their feet. This, of course, isn't true, and tofu, tempeh, soy sauce, miso, and edamame are popular foods widely eaten around the world. Looking at soy milk as an example, the industry itself says that vegans only consume about 10-15% of their product, with the rest going to people who prefer it, are lactose intolerant, or are trying to improve their environmental or ethical footprint. Soybean oil is used widely in cooking and foods, and is the most widely used oil in the US. Soy in the form of flour, lecithin or textured vegetable protein is also present in about two-thirds of US prepackaged and processed foods. So, vegans and even vegetarians are eating a tiny percentage of the soy that humans collectively eat. Still, before we lay blame for the destruction of the Amazon on the soy humans eat directly, we must pull our view out a little more.

To begin with, 16% of soy globally is used in industrial processes, such as ethanol production, plastics, glues and so on. This is more than double what humans eat directly. The main consumer of Amazonian soy, though, simply dwarfs even that amount. 75 - 80% of soy grown globally, including in the Amazon, is used in livestock feed. People may see the soy milk and tofu in the supermarket and think that is where most soy goes, but it is a minor amount in the scheme of things. Soy for livestock feed is a major problem in the Amazon, but it is still only related to the primary culprit. The motivation behind the heartbreaking destruction and deforestation of one of the world's most complex and species-rich ecosystems is cattle pasture. 80% of land clearing in the Amazon basin is done for the purpose of raising animals for slaughter.

So the very opposite of the point people are trying to make about soy and the Amazon is true. It is not vegans, vegetarians, or soy food, but meat eaters and livestock that are the drivers of deforestation and species extinction. If people spent a few minutes having a basic look into the issue, rather than repeating what they heard some ill-informed person say, they would better understand this globally relevant issue. The first time someone said "vegans are destroying the Amazon" to me, I thought this was going to be an easy enough thing to disabuse them of, and perhaps naively thought they might appreciate the update. I regaled them with some facts, quoted World Bank figures, talked about my experiences working with Greenpeace, protesting Amazonian soy being imported to feed chickens in Australia, but alas, nothing I said seemed to change anything. They certainly didn't say "Oh, I didn't know those facts, maybe I should reconsider eating animals". Instead, they became more and more hostile and finally left in a huff. It's almost as if they weren't that interested in what was destroying the Amazon, but were just trying to argue against veganism. The fact that people are still bringing up soy and the Amazon decades after I first heard it, a point which is not only invalid, but the opposite of the

truth, shows how people will unquestioningly accept any justification for their consumption of animal products.

The anthropocene

What do barbed wire, cages, chains and other tools of confinement and oppression say about the lives of the animals who live there? What do they say about humanity? Some people have said we should call our current ecological age the Anthropocene, to acknowledge the overwhelming effect humans now have on the living systems of the world. This age began with our land clearing, burning, and the commercial exploitation of wild animals, but has gained pace since the Industrial Revolution. Humanity has selfishly used its ever-growing power to diminish the home we share with all other species. Livestock farming is one of the more obvious and exaggerated examples of this selfishness. Factory-farmed chickens, one of the most abused animals on Earth, are now over two-thirds of the mass of all birds. Humans and our livestock comprise over nine-tenths of the combined mass of all terrestrial species. Wild species are crowded into the remaining small portion, with most of them in the process of diminishing or disappearing. We often focus on human-caused extinction, but the massive loss of members of wild species has been even more catastrophic in terms of suffering. Since I was born, it is estimated that we have lost three-quarters of wildlife populations, with the number for large fish in the oceans being over nine-tenths.

There is no doubt humans are intelligent and have advanced organisational abilities, but on an evolutionary time scale, what have we used these traits for? To create a tyranny for all other life seems a petty, wasteful and terrible thing to do with our potential.

Transcending anthropocentrism

We have created ideas to justify our oppression. The religions and philosophies of societies invested in animal agriculture tend to centre around human supremacy, with only the gods of our imagination being higher than humans. In an example of how self-serving human thought can be, we imagined those gods to be obsessed with the lives of humans above all other things. The gods are incredibly concerned about the trivial details of human lives, but have little to say about all other life, except in how it relates to us. Our anthropocentrism flows from our philosophies into the way we live, the things we consume and the technology we create. Our concrete and asphalt-dominated cities are deserts for wild animals, especially the animals that evolved in the places our cities have overrun.

Finding a path beyond anthropocentrism, a way to reintegrate human civilisation into the natural world, seems to be the only path forward for humanity that is not built on the oppression of everything else that lives. The positive emotions most people who spend time in nature feel tell us that if we allow nature to restore itself, we will be rewarded with happier and more beautiful lives as well. A new, more harmonious self and world awaits once we can shake off the habits and ideas of the past to find a more equitable relationship between humanity and the other life that co-evolved with us. The planet does not belong to us, we belong to it. All life has its own evolutionary paths that should not be subservient to human needs and desires. Indeed, we will, in the end, find out we flourish best together. Having the power to dominate other animals does not give us the moral right to do so. Rather, our treatment of other animals makes it evident that we need to spend more time on our collective philosophies. We must summon the collective maturity to responsibly wield our ever-increasing power.

What we do to animals, we in some way do to ourselves. Oppression not only damages the oppressed but also limits the flourishing of the oppressor. The livestock industry is oppression run rampant; it is a symptom of our myopia. The gradual replacement of these cruel, unnecessary industries will reflect a wider ethical and intellectual progression for us all. In the future, animal liberation will be something only to celebrate.

4. Bacon

Question

Mmmm bacon...

Alternatives

"I love steak" is almost as common. Other lines from the toxic masculinity script.

Summary

Saying "steak" or "bacon" to someone vegan is meanness in the guise of humour. We tend to think of humour and laughter as positive human expressions, but they are actually a complex part of communication. Laughter can be joyous and sincere, or fake and hollow. Sometimes people can't help but laugh, sometimes they force out a chuckle, and sometimes people engage in fake performative laughter. The latter sort of laughter can be part of status displays, or of declaring our identity with a person, group or mob. One shouldn't look for much emotional depth in people overly prone to fake laughter. Humour that relies on cruelty or meanness reveals the shallow character of both the instigator and those who laugh along. Such people are to be ignored or avoided, certainly not worried about too much, because being a shallow person is its own karma.

Discussion

There can be good jokes that make light of veganism, even some jokes that vegans will tell among themselves: "I decided to go vegan when I realised I had too many friends". Like any type of joke, these jokes can be clever, surprising, or interesting. Then, however, there are attempts at jokes that have few positive qualities, usually told by people who have few positive qualities. I've attended many protests against animal cruelty where people, almost always young men, will walk past and say, “I like bacon”, “I'm going to have a steak”, etc. They are statements that anyone who has done much animal activism will have heard repeatedly, beyond all tolerance for boredom. The people who say such things will repeat these phrases with the seeming pretence of having thought of them themselves. It is unlikely, however, that such people have added any original thoughts to our culture. Jokes, and just for convenience, we will call these boorish ejaculations jokes, don't get funnier with repetition, in the same way that repetition doesn't make lies become true, or stupid statements intelligent.

Let's also be clear about what is involved in making your average strip of bacon. We start with a breeding sow that has only ever lived confined in a concrete shed and surrounded by steel bars. Given the chance, pigs naturally build nests for their children, but this, along with fulfilling most other natural desires, will not be available to her. She will be artificially impregnated as soon as possible, something that will be repeated over her short life. After a gestation period between three and four months, she will give birth to a litter of piglets. Due to

the immense size of genetically bred pigs, the concrete floors they live on, and the confined nature of factory farms, sows crush their piglets at much higher rates than they would in the wild. This has led to the use of farrowing crates, which confine the mother, in many cases not allowing them to turn around. As soon as the piglets are weaned at three to four weeks, about a third of the time they would spend being weaned with their mother in the wild, her piglets will be taken, and she will be almost immediately impregnated again. The piglets will then have their tails, ears and teeth removed without anaesthetic. They will then be crammed into similar sheds that the mother they will never see again endured, with concrete floors and steel bars. The stress and boredom of this confinement will see common behaviours such as bar biting, attacking each other, and they will exhibit signs of chronic distress such as repetitive swaying, head bobbing and pacing back and forth. They will then be fed on a diet optimised to interact with their genetic breeding to bring them to market weight as soon as possible. After six months of this repetitive confinement, they will then be sent to slaughter. This short life is the product of intensive breeding that has doubled and tripled the rate at which pigs grow. Common methods of slaughtering pigs include suffocating them together in groups in gas chambers utilising carbon dioxide, or stunning them with an electrical current, hoisting them upside down, and "sticking" them with a sharp knife. It takes about 30 seconds of extreme stress for carbon dioxide to kill a pig. Studies have shown that up to a third of pigs are still conscious after electrical stunning, and are conscious while being hoisted and "stuck". This life of confinement and slaughter is experienced by one and a half billion pigs every year.

So that's what people participate in, and the ones higher on the dark triad/tetrad scale like to joke about.

Ugly humour

Human laughter is complicated, and science struggles to understand all the many reasons people laugh. Plenty of animals laugh as well, though seemingly for simpler expressions of joy or to communicate that they are playing. What is clear is that people often laugh at things not because they are spontaneously funny but for performative social reasons. This kind of laughter often sounds fake, like a jarring echo from a hollow, unkind place. Fake laughter often sounds like somebody read in a book about laughter and is trying to replicate it, but failing. You can recognise ugly laughter primarily by the way it seems forced out. It usually happens when someone is trying to assert their superiority, or put someone else down; what we call "laughing at" rather than "laughing with". Laughing at others' misfortunes is correlated with psychopathy and other destructive, including self-destructive, personality traits.

Many words have been spent arguing about what things it is OK to joke about. I personally enjoy a dash of schadenfreude. Humour, and perhaps especially dark humour, can make light of dark times and places. It can help us deal with painful or uncomfortable things without having them overwhelm us. The rich, deep humour of some Holocaust survivors is evidence of this. Sometimes it is life-affirming to laugh when the alternative is to cry, or to laugh when we don’t want to or think we should. We can take all of the world’s ugliness and misfortune and find something to smile about in it. Humour that reinforces or legitimises existing evils must be held to a higher contextual standard.

Humour, or the pretence of it, isn't inherently moral or immoral. In addition to easing our load, humour can be used to bolster oppression and cruelty. A smile can be a leer, a smirk or a sneer; it can be a mask hiding the mob's ugly face. Humour can be used by the angry, irrational part of us to drown out the quiet voice of the intellect, of introspection, empathy and

subtle thoughts. Sartre famously said, "Hell is other people", but hell is only some other people, and a sign of this sort of person is how much of their humour is jeering and ill-intended. Witness how the laughing emoji on social media started out as a positive expression, but has since been used and abused by conspiracy theorists and trolls who need to mock people kinder and more mature than themselves.

Humour and empathy

Psychologically, there is something called a cold joke. It's been witnessed in atrocities towards humans for centuries. Perpetrators of immoral acts, killings, torture and the like, use the pretence of humour to avoid the psychological ramifications of something disturbing they are participating in. They bond using jeers and fake laughter with other damaged souls, exhibiting the same insincerity and toxic emotion that probably defines most of the relationships in their lives. If someone can laugh about atrocities, such as billions of innocent animals suffering in factory farms and slaughterhouses, and if they see a person caring about this suffering as weak or pathetic, we might ponder how capable they are of true, empathetic connection with another sentient being. Would such a person be able to love anyone else fully and selflessly in their lives? We might even pity the shallowness they wear so proudly, because emotional connection, the ability to empathise and care for others, to be able to be vulnerable and trust others at a deep level, is among the things that most give life beauty and meaning.

Pigs, sheep, goats, chickens, cows: We should recognise something of ourselves when we look into the face of another sentient creature. These are thinking and feeling beings we share our evolutionary kinship with, who seek to be happy as we do, and we can witness that when our eyes connect. Each animal in a factory farm or slaughterhouse is a thinking, feeling individual that matters. We can forget that on the inconceivable scale of animal agriculture. More animals suffer and die in our industrial prison systems every week than humans killed in all wars during our entire bloody history. We look away from this reality, and perhaps that helps us keep its existence from our daily awareness. In modern times, we have outsourced our killing to others, usually poor and disadvantaged slaughterhouse workers. We have pushed the sight, sound and stench of killing to the outskirts of cities. For most of history, people lived closely with wild animals and felt a kinship with them. They knew that the animals around them had family and relationships of their own, that they were intelligent, and worthy of respect. They would call other animals brothers and sisters, other species fellow nations. Even when they needed to kill an animal to survive, they would often apologise to them and thank them for their sacrifice. That respect has been replaced by the morality of out of sight, out of mind. We now mock the animals we rely upon by using their names as insults. What have we become?

Wanting to believe

The blood of this terrible industry stains the hands of all who participate in it. We can start repairing our relationship with the non-human world by at least showing higher levels of respect for the lived experience of farmed animals. The beings we force to live in lightless sheds, in cages, taken from their families, whom we line up for their turn in slaughterhouses, are not simply a product of mass consumption. They are each a unique somebody, with their own personality, relationships, desires and purposes. These lives and deaths over which we wield a god-like power can, according to our choices and whims, be either more terrible or bearable, more beautiful or ugly, confined or free. Motherhood, love, friendship, society, we take from them so much, and part of the reason we so easily rob other creatures of these

experiences is that many anthropocentrically think of high emotions as uniquely human. All animals evolved from a single ancestor, but mammals are our especially close evolutionary kin. Much of how they interact and process the world is similar to our own experience. We know this when we interact or play with them. We selectively, however, choose to forget this when we associate them with our food. Studies have been done that ask people about the internal lives of animals. Study participants will tend to rate animal sentience much lower if they are eating an animal product at the time, and higher if they are eating a plant-derived snack. How much animal suffering has occurred because of our subconscious need to deny their ability to suffer?

If humans actually needed to eat animals, if there were nothing else we could survive and thrive on, then ethics would still demand a radical overhaul of our farming system. However, we are omnivores who can eat a wide variety of foods; therefore, eating animals is a choice we can make and unmake. The world will be a better place when animals are no longer the intended victims of our food system. The alternative to a plant-based diet is playing a greater part in oppression. We might even have to join the cold jokers and try to feel better about our involvement in killing animals by saying cruel and offensive things, and pretending that our boorishness and sadism are humorous. Or we could take a more heroic stance.

A kinder path

Hopefully, one day, keeping animals in factory farms, and maybe even killing them, will be illegal. Currently, though, people have the choice to do so and pay for others to do so. To choose to treat other beings as purely a means to our ends, whether for food, entertainment, clothing or other consumer goods, is a barren, life-diminishing choice; a choice many people aren't even making entirely consciously. The less ethical and open-minded people are, the more tightly they will cling to their existing habits and try to hamper anyone on a nobler path ahead of them. Indeed, many people seem to be obsessed with ethical status, and especially the idea that anyone tries to do better by following a more compassionate diet. It is sad to see people trapped in prisons of habitual mediocrity, so unable to imagine a different self that they fear escape from their self-imposed walls. It is a poor use of the possibilities of life, peering out suspiciously at the world, at difference, fearing change and growth, despising anybody who reminds us by word or example that there are kinder and better ways we can live. The simple truth is that when people are mocking others, they feel better because at least they aren't thinking about their own flaws, limitations and failed dreams. There is, however, a better way, one that leads to our greater individual and collective flourishing. In a world full of expansive, beautiful possibilities for our relationship with other life, why wouldn't we want to spend our time pursuing a kinder path? Many great deeds need to be done to heal the world, things that can challenge us to embody our highest selves. The animals and the world need us to be heroes.

The greatest potential a person can try to fulfil is their ethical potential. With respect to animals, most of us have room for improvement. While we confront the darkness and suffering all too present in life, even confronting our own limitations, humour can be a balm that helps keep us motivated and sane. Laughter is a mysterious gift, and life is too short and precious to squander our time with fakery and meanness. Let us all laugh less often at others, and more often at ourselves and our shared predicament.

Finally, a joke I hope carnists can appreciate: How many meat eaters does it take to change a lightbulb? None, they prefer to stay in the dark.

5. Hitler

Question

Wasn't Hitler a vegetarian?

Alternatives

Sometimes it is Pol Pot, Mussolini, Charles Manson, or whoever was a terrible human being.

Summary

Hitler was one of the worst people in history, but associating him with all vegetarians is a stretch, just as it is to associate him with all Germans, people with bad moustaches, or dog lovers. We should be more informed and respectful about historical atrocities than to use their victim's suffering for our own ideological purposes. The phrase for this is "false moral equivalence". It is not only illogical but perversely ironic to try to morally equate those who perpetrated the mass killing of one species with those trying to stop the mass killing of other species. Studies show that people who care about animal rights are more likely, not less, than the rest of the population to be concerned with human rights. It is no shock that it is a general apathy rather than a specific compassion for animals that we must struggle against. Veganism is about compassion and encompasses all animals, even humans.

Discussion

Godwin’s law arose in the early days of Internet discussion. It states that as a discussion or debate goes on, the probability of someone making a comparison involving the Nazis approaches certainty. The original law also said the person who first makes such a comparison is said to lose the debate. So it was inevitable that people would try to equate those who want to be kinder to animals with some of history’s worst monsters. Vegans and vegetarians are seen as choosing to care about animals, and people decide, with zero evidence, that this must not include people. Misanthropes may be slightly overrepresented in the vegan and vegetarian community compared to the rest of society, but they are a minority. Surveys repeatedly show that caring about humans and non-humans is not a dichotomy. Caring about both is a mutually reinforcing expression of deeper compassion.

We should tread extremely carefully in making comparisons between aspects of one historical injustice and another. This is especially true if we don't have a deep understanding of or personal relationship with the injustices we are comparing. Whilst there may be some important ways in which atrocities can be similar, as they involve illegitimate force and inflicting pain, there are always fundamental ways in which they are different and defy easy comparison. If we want to communicate with others, we need to understand their different experiences and worldviews. Even discussing the treatment of animals and humans in the same conversation can be triggering or controversial to people who have a speciesist and

anthropocentric mindset. We might think the comparisons we make between human and non-human injustice help them to understand our point, but might actually be creating an unnecessary barrier to them hearing what we say at all. So, we must try to tread carefully in discussing this issue, as I will try to here as well.

Hitler, Pol Pot, and Mussolini all said a lot of things, far too many things, but none ever said they were vegan. While in his last years, Hitler claimed to be a vegetarian, the evidence is fairly shaky that this was true, as we shall see. Despite this, people repeatedly try to make these claims to denigrate the idea of compassion towards animals, so such myths are something we need to address. We can start by acknowledging that evil people have eaten vegetables, maybe even a lot of vegetables. It is also statistically certain that there will be evil and terrible people over the last few thousand years who have followed a vegetarian or mostly vegetarian diet. The questions we have before us, however, are whether a plant-based diet or philosophy either caused those people to be evil or made them more evil. Perhaps we can discover a scale on which we can equate a person's level of evil with the proportion of vegetables in their diet. At the outset, this seems highly implausible, and indeed we might expect the opposite to be true.

Dietary choices and moral complexity

Tolstoy said vegetarianism was proof that a person's pursuit of moral perfection is sincere. In our modern world of factory farming, this probably needs an update to include “veganism”, but while it sounds nice, not everyone gives up eating meat for the pursuit of ethics. Health, religion, spirituality, culture, digestive issues, allergies and trying to impress an attractive vegetarian or vegan are all common reasons for abstaining from animal products that have nothing to do with ethics. If a person abstains from eating animal products for reasons other than ethics, it probably doesn’t tell us too much about their ethics.

People have often claimed that eating meat changes our nature, saying that the violence we do to animals ferments in our soul, or even that the violence pervades their flesh and inhabits us when we consume it. Stopping eating meat would definitely make us less violent, but mainly because we would stop the violence done during its production. It may be possible that there are hormonal or other chemical transfers going on when we consume animal flesh that might make us more prone to violence, but we'd need better evidence for this. It’s also possible for the opposite to be true, that meat makes us more passive; some of the animals we consume have gentle natures, which is part of the reason they make good targets for oppression, and perhaps we become more docile like them as we consume their hormones and so on. For now, though, we don’t seem to be able to confidently assign good or bad behaviour to what people eat. People are complex, and most of us are ethical in some areas but have moral blind spots in others, so what parts should we blame on their diet? We need to know more about someone to say if they are overall a good person than what they had for dinner. Families in India have abstained from meat for many centuries, but it's doubtful that every single person they produced was some sort of saintly figure. Vegetarians and vegans are flawed, trying to figure out this life and making mistakes as they go along, just like everybody else.

A traitor to humanity

Now, let's add to the millions of words humanity has wasted talking about the wretched and pathetic Adolf Hitler. Hitler definitely ate meat regularly until he was almost 50, by which time he had taken over Germany and was having his political enemies put to death, followed by

Jews, Roma, homosexuals, Seventh Day Adventists, and people with disabilities. Mass killings of non-Aryans started after the invasion of the USSR in 1941. Yet it was 1942, 21 years after Hitler became head of the National Socialists, well into the war and almost 10 years after the first concentration camps were opened, before he ever seemed to say anything remotely vegetarian. So the claim is immediately on shaky ground. If we think his diet was in any way related to his crimes, it is not his late vegetarianism we might look at, but rather his 50 years of meat eating before it.

So why did Hitler experiment with vegetarianism? Hitler had long-term stomach problems, and some say doctors advised him to eat a mostly vegetable diet around 1937, though Herman Hess said Hitler always made exceptions for his favourites like liver dumplings. It seems eating less meat was a common prescription for stomach problems at the time, as it was also given to Mussolini. Even later on, people, apparently unafraid of the consequences of crossing Hitler, snuck meat into his food, and if Hitler noticed, he would complain about it hurting his stomach. Hitler's primary chef claimed she used animal broth in cooking for him, and his dietitian also claims to have snuck bone marrow into his food. So, how much Hitler was ever really vegetarian is hard to tell from these anecdotes. It's also worth noting that the Nazis banned existing vegetarian societies in 1935 and forced them to merge into Nazi-controlled health organisations. Hitler did show some concern for animals, liked dogs, and the Nazis did enact laws against animal cruelty. Of course, if people were just pure evil, history would be a lot simpler, and the Germans would have figured out he wasn't a worthy leader much sooner. The Nazis also had social programmes and helped the poor, so although the Nazis as a collective were incomprehensibly vile, not every single thing they did was. As they say, even a stopped clock can be right twice a day. Hitler may have been mostly vegetarian for a few of his final years, but what can we draw from that?

Pol Pot and the meaning of words

Pol Pot led an insane and murderous regime in Cambodia. The problem for people claiming that Pol Pot was a vegetarian or even a vegan is that this is relatively recent history. The people who cooked for Pol Pot are still alive, and we can ask them about it. People have and they have told us that he ate all sorts of things, fish, cobra, boar, etc. While he was forcing much of the population of Cambodia to starve, Pol Pot and the members of his regime were eating well, consuming their meat with imported wines. An official who knew him seemed to say he was a vegetarian, but who knows what they were basing that on? Certainly, I can't find anywhere that Pol Pot made the claim about himself.

We must understand that many people get confused about what the word vegetarian means, and this was even more true in the past. A relevant passage talking about Hitler’s diet from the New York Times in 1937 says, “It is well known that Hitler is a vegetarian”, which the article then follows with “he occasionally relishes a slice of ham and relieves the tediousness of his diet with such delicacies as caviar”. Studies show that even today, many people, especially older people, get confused when asked to define vegan or vegetarian. They regularly think it is just excluding red meat, or not eating much meat, or eating chicken or fish. Diet surveys have had to be amended because of the poor understanding of the terms vegetarian and vegan. Now, after a survey asks people if they are vegetarian or vegan, they will often then ask, "When was the last time you ate chicken/fish?" etc. This is necessary because of the confusion about what people ascribe to the word. If people today use terms like vegetarian and vegan loosely and incorrectly, when plant-based diets are much more present in the culture, we shouldn't expect people decades ago to be clearer about them. What did someone in 1940s

Germany mean when they said vegetarian, or in 1970s Cambodia? Pol Pot doesn’t seem to have been vegan or vegetarian, so you can't tarnish us with him. Instead, he seems to be another moral blight on the carnists of the world.

One for the haters

Finally, Charles Manson. A lot of slightly unhinged websites gleefully assert he was a vegetarian and a couple of better-hinged ones as well, though none of them provides much evidence, so I had to search for it myself. Manson certainly wasn't a vegetarian when he was younger, and his first stint in prison has no records of him requesting non-standard prison meals. Once he left prison to find the flower power generation in full steam, that's when he started changing his look and diet. From Manson's statements after this time, he says things about killing animals, but they seem as much to point out the hypocrisy of society and its attitudes towards killing as to tell people not to eat meat. Charles "Tex" Watson, in his autobiographical account of his time in The Manson Family, wrote that Manson's vegetarian rhetoric was often selectively applied. Though the group preferred to scavenge vegetarian food, they would accept animal products. Watson also described the Family butchering animals at their Spahn Ranch, and it was said that Manson would frequently visit a hot dog and burger bar. After this, though, the evidence for Manson's vegetarianism becomes clearer. In Manson's murder trial, he asserted, "I don’t even like to eat meat - that is how much I am against killing". Apparently, at least Charles Manson believes that vegetarianism leads to the opposite of murderousness. Manson started requesting vegetarian meals in his later, longer stint in prison, and his cellmates also agree that he consistently ate vegetarian meals. So it is clear that Manson was a vegetarian for most of his later life. We will chalk this one up as a "win" for the naysayers, though again, with the caveat that Manson wasn't a vegetarian until his early to mid-30s. Of course, there was a wave of vegetarianism amongst the hippie culture in 1960s California, but as much as conservatives feared it at the time, there wasn't a wave of Manson Family-style psychopathy.

Linking diet and personality

If anyone wanted serious answers as to whether violent people were more likely to eat or not eat meat, it would seem a reasonably simple area to study. Get prison meal records and see which diet correlated with the most violent offenders. One suspects that if people in the legal and justice system noticed an outsized number of cases linking vegetarianism or veganism to murderousness, someone would have already done this relatively simple study. What has been studied is whether a healthy diet helps people reduce their violent tendencies, and the result is pretty conclusive that it does, so maybe people who are worried about high levels of violence should advocate for healthy eating over stirring up a culture war.

What motivates the repetition of this claim about Hitler et al to people who don't eat meat? There is evidence that some people seem to want to pre-emptively attack people who take a strong ethical stance because they imagine the other person will judge or shame them. It is like there is a defensive conversation already going on in their mind that someone taking an ethical stance unknowingly steps into. People don’t want to be looked down upon; they deeply want status, including moral status, and will do substantial intellectual callisthenics to claim it. Surveys show that many meat eaters are uncomfortable about the treatment of animals in the food system, but they are stuck in the habit of how they eat and don’t want to change. This leaves them in an uncomfortable mental state, which psychology calls cognitive dissonance. To continue eating animal products without it overly troubling their conscience, they need to try

to find strong intellectual justifications for their behaviours. What could be stronger than associating vegans and vegetarians with history's worst monsters like the Nazis? We can imagine a simple subconscious internal dialogue, "It seems more ethical to be vegetarian. I am not a vegetarian and do not wish to become so. To maintain my ethical status, I must undermine vegetarianism". So you get "Hitler was bad. Hitler was a vegetarian. All vegetarians are bad", but more importantly, what follows: "I am not a vegetarian, therefore I am good". Aristotle wouldn't have thought much of this syllogism, but even poor logic will be looked upon favourably by a person desiring an exit from a moral quandary. Judging others negatively is a primary way that people redirect their negative inner voice away from themselves.

Adding to poor logic, we also have poor statistics. You can't make widespread inferences about a group of people from cherry-picked examples. Even if Hitler and Pol Pot actually were ethical vegetarians, what about Mao Tse Tung, Joseph Stalin, Talat Pasha, Suharto, Saddam Hussein, Atilla the Hun, Genghis Khan, Nero, Caligula, King Leopold, Idi Amin, and also the rest of the Nazis? The Nazis may have looked up to Hitler, but very few of them were tempted to follow his diet. But you don’t find vegans saying to carnists, “Oh, you eat meat, well, did you know that most of history's greatest monsters were avid meat eaters?” Although it may be true, it doesn’t tell us much about the character of the meat eater we are talking to. It's actually hard to say whether a vegan diet makes someone anything, because most vegans didn’t start life as vegans; they too ate meat, not because they were bad people, but because they unquestioningly conformed to what they were taught while being raised. Vegans should be able to understand what it is like to be someone who hadn’t really considered the lives of other animals enough, or didn’t have the tools and mindset to do something about it, because they were once there themselves.

Universal compassion

Given the scale of animal suffering at human hands, the billions huddled in factory farms, their bodies altered to be production machines, and the many wild species of the world in retreat or facing extinction, it seems impossible to argue against the fact that the way humans treat animals is a moral blind spot on which some light is urgently needed. People judging those who argue for kinder treatment of animals should think carefully before engaging in knee-jerk reactions against them. Even if you think vegans are wrong, is having compassion, maybe even too much compassion for other species, something more terrible than the problem animal advocates are trying to bring attention to? This is not to say that unempathetic vegans should get a free pass to be rude or inconsiderate. Veganism, when properly understood, is about compassion and consideration for all that can suffer, and this should include humans. Vegans would be advised to try to consistently embody the compassion inherent in their message in the way they present it.

Finally, I will speak for veganism, because that is what I am, and I have no place to speak for vegetarianism. The intellectual and ethical progress of humanity has always been improved by widening our circles of compassion. Any outlook that considers humans but not animals, or animals but not humans, or some subset of humans or animals, is incomplete. All sentient beings deserve consideration of their interests, at the very least, in concordance with their level of sentience. An ethically and intellectually consistent life has at its core compassion for all beings who can suffer, for all earthlings thrown into these evolutionary moments of existence together. Veganism is not purely a diet; it spans far beyond that into a philosophy of universal compassion. Anyone advocating violence towards sentient beings, or even degrading the value of their lives, cannot be a vegan.

6. Plants

Question

Don't plants have feelings?

Alternatives

Carrots scream when you cut them. What about bacteria? Eating plants kills more animals than just eating animals.

Summary

Our moral responsibility towards a sentient being should be proportionate to their ability to suffer. While the science on plant sentience is evolving and often surprising, it does not yet ascribe to plants the high levels of sentience we find in vertebrates and closely related invertebrates. What science has known for over a century, if it wasn't already obvious intuitively, is that cows, sheep, ducks, pigs, chickens, horses, dogs, and many of the other animals people eat have complex senses, emotions, and internal worlds. If we want to cause less suffering in the world, the simplest change we can make is to stop paying for industrial animal agriculture and slaughter. Also, and somewhat obviously, farm animals are fed tremendous amounts of plant material. Given how inefficient this is in producing edible protein, if people are concerned about plants, they should eliminate or reduce their consumption of animal products.

Discussion

Plants are pretty amazing. They appear to have their own versions of many of the senses humans experience, including touch, smell, taste, sight and sound. This makes sense as humans and plants evolved from a common ancestor over a billion years ago. We still share something like 50% of our DNA with trees and bananas. Delving into the science of plant sentience is fascinating and challenging. People who pose questions like “Don't plants have feelings?” Vegans, however, are unlikely to be interested in science for its own sake, much less will they be seeking the next level of compassionate consideration in their lives. Paradoxically, they are less likely to care about plants, forests and ecosystems than the average person. What these people are actually seeking is an intellectual sideshow that helps avoid the more morally urgent question: Is the vast amount of unnecessary suffering we cause in animal agriculture morally acceptable?

Defying logic

Why do some people grab at such flimsy pretexts in conversations around a topic as important and consequential as animal suffering?

Now many people might think this is an absurd question that no one would ask in a serious conversation about the duties humans owe to other species. If you find it hard to believe anyone would bring up such an absurd point, you clearly haven't had enough conversations about veganism. Apparently, intelligent adults will bring carrots up as justification for the killing of highly sentient beings like cows and pigs and think they have made a knock-down argument. Their understanding of the natural world seems to be: there is human-level intelligence, and then everything else is roughly equivalent, including bacteria. Carrots are never raised regarding human slaughter. No one has ever sat in front of the International Criminal Court and used the carrot defence. Yet the human experience of sentience is more similar to that of pigs than of carrots, which are much less closely related to us in evolutionary terms.

Answering questions like the carrot defence is perhaps less productive than pondering the reasons behind someone repeating them. The main reason for such a question seems to be thoughtlessness and conformity. That carrots are always specifically brought up is some evidence for this: that a meme has infected people who are simply repeating it. Why are carrots invariably featured when there are hundreds of other root vegetables whose internal world we might wonder about? What about the doughy potato, humble beetroot or voluptuous turnip? There are many, many thousands of plant foods, but for some reason people always bring up the nefarious carrot. It is hard to comprehend that anyone would think the morality of how we treat carrots is relevant to how we treat, for example, a pig. One reason for the lack of critical thinking here is that because people believe the underlying premise - that the eating of animals requires no more moral justification than the eating of plants - they fail to inspect any statements that align with their bias. Because people consider the carrot and the pig to be food, the illogical nature of the moral comparison eludes them.

Another reason people might bring up the carrot defence is a lack of moral seriousness. This can have many causes; people could simply be unempathetic, or they could have dark tetrad personality traits - psychopathy, Machiavellianism, narcissism and sadism. Such people probably can't see or care about the difference between low and high sentient beings. If you don't care about animals for whatever reason, it is consistent to group them in with another group of beings you don't care about, such as plants, or even other groups of people.

Something else that could be warping people's logic here is our need for status. As a part of our evolution as communal social beings, we can be incredibly attuned to our place in the social hierarchy. Many people seek social status of almost every kind. It doesn't really matter what the status pyramid is constructed of, some people want to place themselves at the top of it. Included within this is ethical status, which people can seek even if they aren't very concerned about living ethically. Perhaps the defining statement of such people, and how they interact with others, is "They think they are better than me". Ethical status is just another of the myriad facets of comparison that can be incorporated within that statement. There are broadly two strategies we can use to enhance our ethical status: one is to work on ourselves and live a more considered, compassionate and selfless life; the other is not to change, but instead use our intellectual resources to justify our existing attitudes and behaviours. Humans can, after all, justify almost any ridiculous thing if they are stubborn and don't care too much about objective truth. Questioning whether plants have feelings is part of this strategy.

Ethical status is inconvenient for people who have spent their lives living in a society that habituated them to unethical behaviours. People raised in the segregated American South virtually rioted when a 6-year-old African-American girl, Ruby Bridges, was enrolled in an all-

white school. After a relatively short time, people saw sense, calmed down, and integration in those same schools is now commonplace and unremarkable. People feel compelled to defend a wasteful, materialist, destructive culture at least partly because they are intellectually immersed within it and can't imagine a world beyond. Defining people by how much money they have and spend has terrible ethical consequences for our world. We have been taught to judge the "good life" in material rather than ethical terms. Most people have not been raised to ask about what goes on in the world before products are brought to us, or what happens once we are done with them. The profits of the global market are highly dependent on sweatshops, forced labour, inequality, factory farms, slaughterhouses, political manipulation, global conflict, and countless forms of environmental destruction and pollution. Becoming ethically conscious of such things forces the realisation that, if we are to even begin to minimise our contribution to the negative aspects of our consumerism, we must put more care into our lifestyle and choices, especially our consumption choices. The system and society we are in, however, do not encourage or reward such care, and they certainly don't always make it easy. Billions of dollars are spent every year on marketing and normalising profligate consumerism to us, while also lobbying and funding political leaders to keep the system going. Trying to live more ethically can even feel like constantly pushing against the flow of the consumerist culture we are embedded within.

Why should we take on this ethical burden? Why not just be selfish and go with the flow? There are few compelling social or economic reasons to rail against the global beast of consumerism. A much easier path is conformity to it, to continue to follow whatever way of consuming and eating our upbringing happened to churn out. There is, however, the minor, nagging problem that the consumerist lifestyle is inconsistent with an ethical, considered and compassionate life. The human mind, in all its subtlety and creativity, can help us navigate around the problem of ethics if we want or allow it to. Self-interest and ego play a powerful, warping role in the logic and ethics even of the best of us. Allowed to run rampant, our ego can become a vampire squid on the integrity of our intellect.

Confirmation bias

Our minds can find plausible justifications and loopholes for almost anything we want. We do this without even being conscious of it, through a process called confirmation bias. Confirmation bias is the human tendency not to properly evaluate truth claims if they align with our existing beliefs. The way the religious zealot thinks is a clear example of this. For them, truth starts not in doubt, in epistemology or philosophy, but rather it emerges from the starting point of their religious texts and beliefs. Whatever fact or piece of knowledge about the world they encounter must be reconciled with their religious beliefs. If a piece of knowledge cannot be reconciled with their religious beliefs, it becomes a threat to them. Again, they do not do this deliberately. Their brain is just much more receptive to things that fit in with their existing worldview than things that disagree with it. This logical bias is the reason that apparently normally intelligent people will seriously claim the Earth is only a few thousand years old, or that plants and animals were clearly designed by an invisible being. No one would reach these positions starting from first principles. Instead, you must have a certain, in this case religious, worldview implanted in you before you can accept them. Bias is not limited to religion. Many people place their faith in knowledge that confirms their existing habits and prejudices, the beliefs they were raised with, and so on. This is a form of personal and philosophical hubris, but we must understand that it is rarely deliberate or intended as such. It is problematic for our world though.

Scientific studies have often provided evidence of this sort of ethical displacement, sometimes called do-gooder derogation. The basics of this common trait are that when someone else acts more ethically than others in their own lives, it forces others into potentially uncomfortable ethical introspection. Faced with this discomfort, people tend to dislike the person who caused it, the do-gooder. This is a point where what are called "Ad hominem" attacks can occur, which is where someone doesn't try to counter a person's argument but instead focuses on attacking their character. When someone makes you feel bad about yourself, regardless of their intention, people will instinctively respond by trying to deflect their feelings somewhere else. As those fond of gossip have always, at least subconsciously, known, conversations pointing out other people's ethical or intellectual shortcomings feel much better than sincerely pondering or acknowledging your own.

What about plants? What are your shoes made of? What about people? What about bacteria? What about a fairytale farm where the animals have great lives? Such questions are fairly transparent displacements from much more important and obvious questions about our reality and the consequences of our choices in it. This is at least partly understandable. We all fear judgment and self-judgment. We fear self-doubt, painful thoughts, being uncertain about our choices in life, and changes we don't understand fully. Ultimately, though, if we wish to live more ethically, we must confront some personal discomfort and be willing to imagine and create a slightly different self.

Motivated reasoning

Utilising edge cases to brush away the immense scale of suffering in animal agriculture is a misuse of our intellectual potential. The ancient Greek philosophers had a word for bad-faith intellectualising: “sophistry”. We might contrast it with the word "philosophy". Both come from the Greek sophia, meaning wisdom, but the philosopher is a friend or lover of knowledge, while the sophist is just someone skillful in using it. Socrates particularly disliked the Sophists, and felt they engaged with important and serious questions at a trite and superficial level. A Sophist's main priority is to win the argument, not to uncover flaws in logic, grow through mutual discourse, or search for deeper truths. When confronted with humanity’s often brutal treatment of billions of animals, responding with questions like “What about plants?” is something of a Sophist tactic. It is possible that someone might ask this question from a sincere place, but odds are it is a form of evasion. No one of moral seriousness would wave away the unnecessary suffering of billions of highly sentient beings with a trite comment or a clever quip.

Suspiciously, many people’s political and ethical opinions align with what they want to do, what they have always done and what they perceive to be in their self-interest. This tendency to bend reason to the shape of our habits and desires is called motivated reasoning, something closely related to the confirmation bias we discussed earlier. It is another deep cognitive bias we all share, one that shapes reason around our desires as surely as gravity bends light around a celestial body. None of us is above this bias, and it can only be partially mitigated by sustained effort. Millions of mugs with World's Best Dad, or the tendency for people to think they live in the best country in the world, are good examples of this. People often don't question ideas that serve their identity. People want to believe they already have ethical status, even if it's something they haven't put much thought into. The easiest way to gain ethical status without significant personal effort is to simply decide that, by convenient coincidence, they are already living the most practically ethical life. Such people can be highly intelligent, but the opposite of what they would like is to live what Socrates called the examined life.

Introspection, after all, raises the possibility of casting a critical eye over one's own beliefs or behaviour. The status many desire is not achieved by raising uncomfortable questions about themselves, questions they fear the answers to. Worse still are ethical questions that might require significant change. So some people create intellectual barriers to ethical questions. Asking if plants have feelings is such a barrier, creating a smokescreen that helps divert an uncomfortable conversation about our personal contribution to suffering.

People would like to think that animals don't suffer terribly in factory farming, because it serves their ethical purposes to do so. We can't entirely blame them for this, however, as things like confirmation bias and motivated reasoning are working against our ability to see our ethical failings clearly. People raised with an anthropocentric, carnist worldview have something obscured from them that should be obvious: the way we treat animals is one of history's great moral failures.

Pushback

It's not just that people raised with a carnist worldview will find it hard to imagine themselves eating fewer animal products, but they will often object to anyone even raising the idea. Add to this the entrenched economic, cultural and political interests in animal agriculture, and we see there is a huge amount of inertia we must overcome in making a kinder world.

In changing society, even to make it better, we must expect pushback from the status quo. We can expect resistance from individuals, even if for no other reason than that people are often lazy, fear new things, and don't like change. Every time humans have tried to evolve beyond some ethical horror, those most powerfully agitating for the change have faced resistance, including violence. Opposition has come not just from elites profiting from the status quo but also from large sections of the population, often seemingly invested in little more than habit and conformity. The wider social narrative around social change, pushed by politics, the media and many people, has often been that the current levels of injustice were not only tolerable, but ethically superior to any alternatives. They will posit that the real problem is the people trying to foment change and upset the order of things. In our current societies, living ethically is unfortunately rarely as simple as lazy conformity. Instead, the interwoven complexity of our societies requires an ethical journey of constant re-evaluation, most importantly of our shared cultural frames of reference. Moral character requires us to follow the truth wherever it leads, to defy social norms where necessary, and sometimes to raise a lonely defiant fist in the face of an irrational mob. Living ethically requires embarking on an open, honest and introspective dialogue that fearlessly seeks out our moral oversights and failings. This is especially true in relation to freeing ourselves from the corruptions of our own power. Above all, moral character requires the strength to look unblinking into the ethical mirror.

There is an often cruel world that farm animals inhabit beyond our sight that we are part of creating, and therefore, we must bear our part of the moral responsibility for. Justifying the suffering and slaughter of sentient beings for luxury food items must be held to an exceptionally high ethical and philosophical bar. Using our intelligence to displace our uneasiness about the treatment of animals is a sign that we fear a true reckoning with ourselves; that we fear questioning our part in the sentient lives we affect, lives that have unjustly had power and agency taken from them. In our current culture of distraction and mindless consumerism, it has become a heroic stance to fearlessly question our own integrity and ethical status.

Moral seriousness

People will seem to argue about things vigorously, but it then becomes apparent that they aren't really invested in the conversation. They see an argument about the suffering of billions of animals as little different from an argument about which is the best sports team, or which local restaurant has the best pizza. Conversing with such people is like having a conversation with an ego rather than a deep inner self. Many questions vegans are asked stem from this kind of discussion, where someone seems to lack moral seriousness. Let us, however, give these people's level of compassion the benefit of the doubt, and try to answer these questions directly.

Does eating a plant-based diet cause more suffering? Perhaps paradoxically, when humans eat more plants, fewer plants overall are eaten. The land-based animals that humans most often eat are herbivores. Over the course of their lives, they must be fed a large amount of plant material to help them grow. Around a third of the grain we grow globally, and a higher percentage of grain grown in many countries such as my own, is used to feed livestock. Animals, especially larger animals, are inefficient converters of plant foods into protein. For a bovine to produce 1kg of meat, it needs to be fed 25 kg of soybeans. 25kg of soybeans contain 9.5kg of protein, whereas 1kg of beef contains about 260 grams of protein. If soybeans were eaten directly by humans, we would remove all of the inefficiency and environmental concerns of feeding them through the intestines of animals, while getting some much needed fibre in our diets as well. Eating animals fed on plants requires dramatically more plants to be used to feed humans than if they just ate plants.

Related to this is the question of animals being killed during the harvesting of grain and other farming practices, and a similar logic applies. For a start, people who eat meat also don't only eat meat, whatever death or suffering is in a plant based diet is also in the part of any diet that includes plants. When someone eats an animal product, they don't sidestep the deaths of field mice, insects and other animals with that part of their diet, but increase them. A vegan diet is not deathless, but it kills fewer of these collateral-damaged animals than any other common diet, because eating plant foods avoids the waste of inefficiently cycling nutrients through other animals. Whether you want to see fewer plants or animals killed, the solution is always to eat more plants.

So we've treated their questions seriously, but it is revealing that carnists only begin caring about the death or suffering of these plants and animals when they think it might be a useful tool with which to undermine people arguing for greater compassion. Vegans are sincere in caring about these animals. We argue for the sake of the animals not because they are defending our egos. It is probably only a farming system underpinned by the ethics that vegans espouse that will start to look more seriously at how to minimise these unfortunate collateral deaths. Vegans must, unfortunately, exist in a largely non-vegan world, which includes non-vegan farming practices.

Especially in our current world, a vegan diet cannot be perfect, cannot be entirely without animal death or 100% cruelty-free as a t-shirt I once had said. We can, however, eat a diet that involves far fewer deaths, far less suffering. Every person living a vegan life is another vote for moving the world in the direction of a more compassionate farming system.

Weighing sentience

To take another question with more sincerity than it is usually asked, what about plants? Like all life on this planet, plants have their own evolutionary journey that deserves respect. It is an interesting and evolving question of what our duty is to these beings we share our very distant evolutionary origins with. Plants don't have a central nervous system like ours because it's not evolutionarily useful to spend energy creating receptors for pain that you can't do very much about. They do react to stimuli in their environment, even resisting attack, but this is done via a biochemical system very different to animals. Plant biology is many and varied, and there is a lot more nuance than we can cover here. What species belong to the lineages of plants and animals is not always intuitively obvious. For centuries corals were classified as plants, until science recognised them as colonies of tiny animals in the 18th century. There have been similar errors going the other way, where microscopic life were thought to be animals but were finally identified as plants. In the web of evolution, the distinction between lineages and species is often subtle and very much part of a continuum of different evolutionary strategies, a web of interrelated life stretching out over time and space. Amid this complexity and given the consequences of human power on all other life, we should continually question where our ethical duties lie and on what basis we make our judgments.

Some people take animal suffering as seriously as any vegan, but they think it is ethically justifiable to eat very simple creatures, bivalves like oysters and mussels, or to eat insect products like honey. Vegans may not agree with this, but we generally have greater respect for people who have thought through things and followed through with ethically motivated changes than those who blindly conform to whatever ideas they grew up with. Someone may not get the official vegan stamp if they eat honey, or the occasional oyster, but if the rest of their diet is predominantly plant-based, they will be causing a fraction of the suffering of the average person around them.

Darwin and most eminent biologists since him have understood that the common evolutionary heritage we share with other creatures expresses itself through us. This includes the fact that we share the core of our sentience with other beings. Humans are not a wholly different kind of being; instead, we are similar beings with differences and additions. Most of our conscious awareness is actually probably quite similar to other animals, concerned as it is with the requirements of our body, having and dealing with emotions, perceiving and navigating the physical world and so on. We do not experience existence completely differently from them and thus do not exist in a separate moral universe. What overlap there is between humans and other animals may always be up for debate and questioning, but we should not question that there is significant overlap, certainly far more than we have hitherto acknowledged with our magical ideas of ourselves.

Many vegans follow a philosophy called sentientism, which holds that sentience is the important thing that we should consider in our treatment of others. Most importantly, we should consider what Jeremy Bentham called "their ability to suffer". This way of thinking is opposed to the dominant paradigm of speciesism, a way of looking at non-human life as of lesser worth. Often this is held not because of any rationally justified innate capabilities or sensations that other animals lack, but purely because they are not human. Other aspects of speciesism relate to how differently humans treat different animal species. The question of why animals on factory farms are treated so inhumanely when they are just as sentient and able to suffer as cats and dogs is a confusing one. Many people who have pets lavish affection on them and generally consider them members of their family. If someone agrees it is cruel not to walk

a dog regularly, but then unquestioningly eats a pig whose life has been one of confinement in the factory farm, then that person clearly lacks ethical consistency and is guilty of speciesism.

Duty of care

Other life exists on Earth with us, not for us. Humanity is failing in the duty of care our higher sentience and power give us over other beings on this planet. All life has its own story and place in evolution that should not be considered automatically subservient to human desire. As our science and understanding of sentience evolve, we will have to re-evaluate our behaviour and positions to ensure our ethics align with the evolving world. In today's world, however, a deep, obvious and uncontroversial question is staring back at us from behind barbed wire and metal bars, from within cages and fishing nets, from the confines of the factory farm and the slaughterhouse. They wait huddled, waiting for an answer from us, an answer on which their experience of this life and world, and their very lives themselves depend. We know without question that these beings think and feel deeply, share many of our emotions and have similar senses of pleasure and pain. We know that if we ate fewer of these animals, it would bring a dramatic change to their lives, and also that if we collectively ate fewer animals, it would be of major benefit to our natural ecosystems. We can not let discussions of philosophical edge cases from people who are morally unserious distract us from stating these obvious truths.

It is the lot of a finite mind in this infinite universe to have to think and act with incomplete knowledge and information. We will inevitably make mistakes, practically and ethically. It is not making mistakes we should fear, but the mindset that refuses to grow, to learn and then change when confronted with deeper thoughts and better information. We can never have complete certainty about the intellectual and emotional lives of others, whether they be plants, other animals, or even other people. History teaches us, however, that when limited knowledge confronts expansive ethical questions, it is safest to err on the side of compassion.

7. Teeth

Question

What about our canine teeth?

Alternatives

Meat-eating caused human brains to evolve. Our forward-looking eyes mean we are predators

Summary

The fact that we call two of our teeth “canine” is of little more scientific relevance than the fact that we have an Achilles heel or an Adam’s apple. Justifying killing should not be done lightly, and it should require an understanding of comparative biology more informed than we had thousands of years ago, when these teeth were named. The argument that our canine teeth mean we have to eat animals is a clear case of "believe me, not your own eyes". Look at the teeth of a carnivore, then of a herbivore, and then compare both to our teeth. Humans are opportunistic omnivores, with teeth more reminiscent of herbivores than obligate carnivores. Being omnivores means we can make choices about the makeup of our diet and whether it contributes to a kinder world.

Discussion

Science usually finds out that those who profess things they would like to be true but don't fully understand. The Ancient Greeks gave canine teeth their name. As awe-inspiring as the golden age of Greek philosophy was, it had some fundamental oversights in the way it approached things. The Greek philosopher Aristotle was the father of the biological sciences and one of history's greatest minds. In parts of Europe, he was so respected that for centuries they simply called him “the philosopher”. Still, he thought women had fewer teeth than men. We know he thought this because he considered it important enough to write it down so other people could learn from his knowledge. If he had taken the time to look in the mouths of more than a couple of women, he would have realised the error of his ways. It seems similar errors in thinking persist in our modern world with canine teeth.

Dog teeth

Spend a moment looking at the teeth of various carnivores and herbivores. Human teeth are so obviously more similar to herbivores that it is hard to understand anyone bringing this up as an argument for human meat-eating; if anything, it should lead to precisely the opposite conclusion. Still, there is that word canine, which apparently people can’t think very far beyond.

”Canine” is one name given to these teeth, but they are also called eye teeth because of where

they sit in our skull, or cuspids by the people who are paid to maintain them. You never hear anyone saying, "What about our cuspids?" Many animals that eat very different diets have canine teeth. We can include in this list antelopes, deer, camels, horses, boars, seals and walruses. Human canine teeth look rather inoffensive compared to those of some of our completely herbivorous relatives. Highland gorillas have fierce canines, but aside from the occasional insect, they live on plants.

Teeth can be used for many things; they are both tools and weapons. Canine teeth, more specifically, are used for dominance displays, fighting, gripping and tearing all kinds of foods. In some herbivorous species, only the males have large canine teeth, not because their diet is different from that of females, but because they use them to fight and show dominance. Even the dogs that live with humans, after whom canine teeth are named, are no longer carnivores. Dogs have lived with us for so long that they, too, have become omnivorous. Some studies even show that domesticated dogs live longer lives if fed a plant-based diet. Unlike our teeth, though, the teeth of domestic dogs clearly show their recent meat-eating origins. Dogs can still kill relatively large animals using their teeth, something humans would find almost impossible. Can you imagine a human trying to hack away at a buffalo's neck with their teeth and getting very far?

That human teeth resemble herbivorous teeth might tell us something about the role of meat in our evolutionary diet. Like our closest evolutionary relatives, we lived primarily on plants. There is incredible variation in the diets of humans who lived in often extreme environments, but anywhere that edible plants were plentiful, the human diet mostly consisted of them. Some of our closest relatives, such as chimpanzees, whose teeth are remarkably similar to human teeth, also eat some meat, but it is an incidental part of their diet. In the most meat-heavy chimpanzee troops, animals might make up 5-10% of their calories, but the percentage for most troops is much less. Our teeth and much of our biology tell us that humans, also with some regional variation, were similar.

Our now extinct but even closer relatives, the Neanderthals, had larger canine teeth than modern humans. Neanderthals ate much more meat as a percentage of their diet than we Homo Sapiens did, perhaps up to 80% in some regions. Scientists conjecture that our ability to thrive on a much wider array of foods was one of the things that may have contributed to us outcompeting and then entirely replacing the Neanderthals.

If we are comparing the anatomy of canines and humans, we can see that dogs also have claws, something that all land-based carnivores have. Look at the human hand with our short, soft nails. Our hands are perfectly designed for doing the sort of things tree-dwelling animals do, like swinging from trees and picking fruit. Until our ancestors figured out how to use tools, their meat-eating was probably confined to scavenging and opportunistically catching smaller animals, just as with our closest genetic relatives like chimpanzees.

Fire, not murder

The idea that meat-eating was entirely responsible for developing larger brains is predominantly wishful carnism. This is an idea some people want to be true to help suppress their ethical qualms about our treatment of animals. It wouldn't absolve the cruelty inherent in killing animals, in any case, but there is no really solid evidence for this hypothesis.

For a start, if we lined up animals by brain size, we wouldn't find all the carnivorous animals

listed first, then followed by the herbivorous ones. Carnivorous animals tend to have larger brains for their body size, but so do animals that eat mostly fruit. If we go down a list of the smartest land animals, we find that many, such as elephants, primates, and pigs, predominantly eat plants.

The idea that people eating a lot of meat led to our brain size increasing involves a bit of circular reasoning. Regularly eating a lot of meat, especially of larger animals, wasn't really possible until humans figured out how to make and use relatively advanced tools, ones we don't see elsewhere in the animal world. They used these tools in a uniquely human way, not only to kill prey, but to process their carcasses. Given that advanced tool-making is often given as one of the defining points of homo sapien intelligence, the fact that it was necessary before we ate larger amounts of meat should make us question the underlying hypothesis.

Having an additional source of nutrients, especially fat and protein, is always helpful, especially in times of scarcity. During periods of extended drought or other difficult climatic conditions when plant foods might be scarce, eating animals might be the only way to stay alive. That is different, however, to claiming eating meat is necessary for our survival. Even today, when we look at communities with poor diets, it is common for people to advocate eating more meat as a way to improve their nutrition. While this might be true as an isolated point, the reason these communities' existing diet is poor is a consequence of poverty. Especially with extreme poverty, diets can lack both calories and nutritional variety. In either our evolutionary ancestors or communities in poverty today, a mostly plant-based diet would be a healthier and certainly kinder way to provide basic nutritional requirements.

Science suggests that our harnessing of fire was highly consequential in aiding our brain development by unlocking additional food sources and nutrients. Our brains consume a huge amount of our total energy for their size. They are mostly fed on glucose, so this would have included plant starches and natural sugars. Human digestive tracts are much longer than those of true carnivores. Our digestive tracts were even longer before the harnessing of fire and the easier nutrition cooking provided to us. The ability to get nutrients from plants more easily enabled our guts to become smaller, allowing for more physiological resources to be put towards brain development.

Again though, we go back to the circular reasoning, as we needed to be pretty smart to handle and utilise fire as well. Many researchers point to our ancestors who lived in forests eating diets heavy in fruits and the occasional honey as the time when our brain size increased. Like every primate, the lives of our arboreal ancestors are written in our anatomy.

Looking back on prehistoric times is rarely easy; maybe we'll have more knowledge in the future, but for now, the hopeful claims of people saying meat "made us human" are unwarranted. Justifying modern humanity's terrible treatment of animals cannot be laid at the feet of our prehistoric ancestors.

Tree dwellers

Forward-facing eyes are a strange one, but it comes up. Like most animals, humans have two separate eyes that enable depth perception. There is a theory that prey species' eyes are wider apart to allow better peripheral vision to see attackers, and that predator species' eyes are closer together for more accurate, close depth perception. So far, so good, and this tracks with general trends in the evolutionary world. Where it gets muddled is in thinking that if you don't

have eyes on the sides of your head, that makes you a predator, or vice versa. Again, we return to Aristotle's oversight: theory without looking at the actual world. Starting with our ape cousins, we could list many species that have forward-facing eyes and are primarily or solely herbivores, or ones that have eyes on the sides of their heads and are carnivores. Depth perception is advantageous for many things, such as swinging through branches, leaping over the landscape, and snatching a lovely fruit before someone else does. Eye placement is clearly not a clear evolutionary sign of any single trait. Humans, like nearly all primates, have forward-facing eyes primarily because they or their ancestors lived among the trees.

Evolution

Overall, the science is pretty clear that we have to go a long way back to a time when our ancestors ate herbivorous diets like those of the mountain gorillas. As for human anatomy and our evolutionary diet, we have been omnivores for millennia. Our anatomy is predominantly that of a herbivore, but with adaptations to better enable meat-eating. Before our advanced tool usage, we used sporadic and costly hunting techniques such as persistence running and cliff driving. From our biology, apparently over the longer term, we opportunistically supplemented our diet by scavenging. Humans were eating meat well before they harnessed fire, and therefore had to deal with a higher parasitic load from decomposing meat. Our stomach acids are quite strong and are similar to those of animals who survive almost exclusively on carrion, or what is called "risky meat", like hyenas and vultures. This makes sense when we look at human anatomy; we simply don't look like predators. We are unlikely to have been able to have animal products as a large portion of our diet until we started to use weapons, especially projectile weapons, and advanced group hunting techniques. There is clearly an evolutionary reason that qualified dietitians tell us to limit how much meat we eat, and make sure our diet is mostly composed of fruits, vegetables, legumes and whole grains to be healthy.

There is the question of how much we must be limited by what our ancestors ate. Around the globe, people's average daily meals usually contain at least one of the amazing variety of foods that only became available to the rest of the world after the European invasion of the Americas in 1492: corn, potatoes, pumpkins, tomatoes, peppers, peanuts, beans, and, of course, chocolate. Should we avoid these foods because our ancestors had never seen a potato or pumpkin, or just simply enjoy having access to them? Humans living in developed societies have an environment where a wide variety of food is superabundant. This is fairly unique in human history. It gives us the ability to make choices about what we eat, and this includes ethical choices. Nutritional science tells us we can live healthily on many different diets, including entirely plant-based diets free from animal products. Indeed, most nutritionists and nutritional bodies say that the majority of people would benefit from moving towards a more whole-food, plant-based diet. Using biology to justify our treatment of animals in our food systems is not consistent with modern biological or dietary science.

Once you strip away what people would like to believe out of habit, you are left with a simple truth of profound ethical importance to the world. We have the freedom to use our conscience in deciding what, or whom, we eat. We can contribute to making a kinder world…if we want it.

8. Humane

Question

What about backyard chickens?

Alternatives

What if animals were farmed humanely? My aunt and uncle have a farm…

Summary

Chickens, perhaps even more than any other farmed animal, have been intensively bred to be production machines. This is a form of interspecies abuse. The breeds of hens in our farming systems have been selectively manipulated to lay hundreds of eggs yearly, many times more eggs and larger ones than their wild forebears. This is only one facet of a torturous regime they endure that is inconsistent with their health and quality of life. Life in a backyard would almost always be better than a factory farm, but modern hens can never escape the fact that their bodies have been bred to suffer. If you care at all about the pain of these friendly, inquisitive creatures, the best policy is to eat plants instead.

Discussion

The industrial factory farm is one of the cruellest creations of humankind. They are the inevitable product of the sheer quantity of meat people consume and the relentless push to make it profitable. They are part of a perverse cycle of intensification: creating a more industrial system that sacrifices animal welfare leads to cheaper animal products, and creating cheaper animal products leads to people consuming more of them. There is much talk about historical human progress, and while there are many rising indicators of human ethics and well-being, for animals, a different story has unfolded. There have never been more animals living in factory farms, and the conditions of these lives seem to be on a downwards trajectory. This industrial system has pushed animals towards ever more confinement, more intensive genetic meddling, earlier slaughter, and less autonomy to pursue their natural desires.

Economics over ethics

A widely viewed debate about the ethics of eating animals was held some years ago. The side arguing against the interests of animals starting out with a statement something like this, "We don't support or want to defend the factory farm, but". This turned the debate from their side largely into irrelevancy. To avoid talking about factory farming while discussing the real-world ethics and consequences of eating animals is to avoid the elephant in the room in order to discuss its shadow. In the United States, the percentage of animals raised on "humane" farms is below 1%. For pigs, chickens, turkeys, ducks, and increasingly cattle, shrimp and fish, the percentage of individuals that lead anything like a decent, natural life is minimal. The reality of

animal farming is increasingly and overwhelmingly factory farming.

It is profit, not ethics, that governs the way we treat farm animals. People have voted with their wallets for the cruel factory farm. The inescapable result of each person wanting cheap animal products is that a community of animals has to endure life in factory farms before their, literally, premature slaughter. For every person who eats an animal product heavy diet, it has been calculated that at least 26 land and hundreds of aquatic animals are bred and confined in farms for them. Multiply this by billions of humans and you start to comprehend the collosal scale of animal farming. Industrialised animal agriculture and the universal meat-heavy diet are modern creations wholly dependent upon each other. To abolish the worst aspects of factory farming, to meaningfully reduce the suffering and vast environmental footprint these farms cause, animal product consumption would probably need to be scaled back to pre-industrial levels.

This is not to say that people support the factory farm intellectually. Some interesting but hard to understand surveys in developed nations have shown wide support, often around half of the population, for banning slaughterhouses and factory farms. People will often say they want farm animals to have better treatment and also that they would like to eat fewer animal products. This doesn't seem to correlate to action, however. The old political contradiction seems to come into play: people want things to be better, but they also don’t like having to change or paying more for things. In place of consequential action, people, almost whimsically, talk about more humane farms. They place their hope and conscience in the hands of impractical fixes that they aren't morally serious enough about to think through fully. They idea is that humane farms could be a “drop-in” alternative for factory farms, that these humane farms could provide a win-win outcome by having more compassionately raised animals providing products in similar quantities and at similar prices. Neither part of this win-win dream scenario is true. The best that any of the "more humane" farms currently operating can provide is slightly less cruel meat at prices much higher than standard factory-farmed products. The economic practicalities of providing anaesthetic for the many surgeries done in factory farming, or for raising animals in ways consistent with their natural desires just don't add up. Huge corporations have, for many decades now, been optimising and refining a factory farming system built on the subjugation of every animal interest to profit. Anything resembling a traditional farming approach will never compete with the scale and efficiency of these huge international conglomerates built to churn out animal body parts and secretions at the lowest cost.

Hypocrisy

Even among the rare animal product-consuming people who think much about humane farming, very few of them are even loosely consistent in what they buy. It is actually a strange thing to be vegan and have so many people ask you questions like "What about if we treated animals better?", but when you ask how often they buy more humane alternatives, the answer is usually a blank stare. There has been some improvement for some animals, such as laying hens, in some countries. Free-range eggs and "certified" products have become more common, but in many countries the definition of what is free range has also been watered down in the interests of greater profit making. What are called "true" free range egg consumption in the US has been in the low single digits for decades, though this number is much higher in Australia and the United Kingdom. The more moderate move from battery cage to barn raised hens has been more successful, accounting for between a fifth to two thirds of eggs sales in most developed nations. Interestingly when asked why they prefer barn laid or free range eggs

the majority of consumers cite not hen welfare, but taste or health concerns as the main reason they buy them. While these medium intensity methods do offer significant improvements in welfare over caged alternatives, they are ultimately limited in their scope purely by economics. Other forms of animal products, however, have not seen anywhere near the level of uptake of humane alternatives. Why people who eat meat regularly bring up the discussion of humane farming, which they don't seem to want to pay very much for or go to any effort to make happen, remains a mystery. It's like their fantasies about the potential for humane animal farming in the future creep into the existing world just enough to absolve their conscience about what is actually going on. There are many pleasing fantasies we can have, but surely it is what we do and pay for to happen in the real world that defines our ethical self.

Backyard farming has an emotional appeal, as it tries to replicate the stories children enjoy reading about animals and farms. In our storybooks there are mother hens clucking happily with their chicks under their wings, a rooster on a fence crowing to greet the sunrise, a happy piglet on some grass, and a smiling cow with a flower in its mouth and her calf by her side. These fairy tales are often replicated on the outside of animal product packaging. Inside those packets, however, is the reality of animals that experienced many cruelties and had an unnaturally short life before they were transported to face the horrors of a slaughterhouse. Many of them have never known a consistent family or relationships, have never been allowed to express their natural behaviours, and may have never seen the sun except perhaps when crammed together in trucks while being transported to their death. Pigs, cows, roosters, large fish- there are very few animals that conveniently fit into the backyard farmer ideal, but then backyard farming is more about bucolic fantasies than any serious solution to the widespread suffering of farm animals.

Out of sight, out of mind

Let us return to consider the poor chicken, perhaps the most widely abused animal in the world. If you ever wonder about the scale of factory farming, think about the fact that there are more individual chickens in Europe than the top 100 wild bird species combined. Some kind people try to adopt egg laying hens at the end of their productive life cycle, when the industry would usually send them for slaughter. As there are around 8 million laying hens in the world at any given time, the ability of adoption to make anything more than a tiny dent in these numbers. Rehoming an animal from a factory farm that would otherwise be slaughtered, whilst a noble idea, also comes with various health and often mental issues for the birds. Corporations with profit, not hen welfare, in mind, have intensively selectively bred the modern factory-farmed hen. Wild chickens lay two clutches of eggs each year, comprised of around one to two dozen eggs. The modern factory-farmed chicken has been bred to lay 10-15 times this amount, producing an egg almost every day. The eggs they lay are also significantly larger. This intense production regime takes a terrible toll on the hens' small bodies, leaching calcium and other vital nutrients. Animal sanctuaries that take in hens from factory farms often give the hens hormones to slow down their egg production and give their bodies a chance to heal, though this isn't a healthy long-term solution either. Chickens can live for up to 20 years, but egg-laying factory-farmed chickens are killed at less than two years old because, in industry jargon, "their production falls rapidly". In other words, these poor hen's reproductive systems and bodies are spent, and they are slaughtered to be replaced in the cycle of suffering by some unfortunate younger hen.

The brothers of these egg-laying hens don't escape a cruel fate either. Male chickens are worthless to the egg industry. They haven't been bread to grow unnaturally fast and large like

broiler chickens in the meat industry, so they are immediately killed and disposed of. Male chicks are killed en masse, generally by being fed through a grinder (called maceration or shredding) while still alive. Another common alternative is by suffocating/gassing. Note: these horrific methods are considered the “more humane” ways of killing male chicks and are recommended in Australia by the The Royal Society for the Protection of Animals. The RSPCA is the primary body certifying welfare standards for animal agriculture in Australia. They certify 90% of chicken products sold under the brands of the major Australian supermarkets. Allowing fast-growing breeds and grinding male chicks alive are just two of the cruelties that happen in products bearing the RSPCA stamp of approval. The Royal at the start of their name is perhaps the first hint as to how progressive the RSCPA are with respect to farmed animals, but more revealing is that their certification logo has a dog/cat paw in the middle of it. They perpetuate the older standard of animal welfare societies, which were mainly concerned with the treatment of cats, dogs and other pets we share our daily lives with. They will advocate for dogs to be walked at least once a day, while stamping their approval on products made from pigs who have lived their lives indoors in concrete and steel pens. This is arbitrary speciesism. Footage of the conditions inside some RSPCA-certified piggeries is confronting, and if anyone were to keep their dog or cat in such conditions, the RSPCA would no doubt call for their prosecution. Animal welfare standards even have specific exceptions for farm animals, because apparently, cruelty is fine when it keeps meat cheap and corporate profits flowing. No matter how cruel farming practise are, they can not be prosecuted if they are considered standard practise for the industry. Consumers enjoy the cheap animal products these corporations sell and ask few of any questions about the animals, the answers to which they don't want to hear anyway.

In backyard farming, the problem of too many male birds is on a different scale, but it doesn't go away. Roosters can also live up to twenty years, and with even a small flock of hens producing chicks, this will result in large numbers of roosters. Roosters aren't as placid or useful to human purposes as hens; they are often noisy, fight and of course don’t lay eggs. So they are mostly slaughtered in backyard farming at 3 to 4 months, before they start to mature. The hens are also generally slaughtered by any serious backyard farmers as their reproductive systems start to slow down and they become a waste of feed. Backyard farming may alleviate some of the intense confinement and cages of intensive systems, but for the hens it still involves slaughter and much physical suffering.

Factory farms and slaughterhouses are terrible places, and that is even with some oversight by the government. They have been made better in some countries primarily by the occasional activist breaking in and publicising conditions in them for a generally unaware public. We might expect backyard farming to be, on average, better for hens but the unregulated, unseen, unprofessional nature of it can also go awry. Amateur farmers keeping chickens purely for economic and production reasons may result in chickens suffering more painful deaths, untreated diseases, lower standards of care, less protection from predators, and even direct abuse. Spending a significant amount of money paying a vet to visit an individual sick chicken makes little sense if you have the animal for economic reasons. Suffering does exist on a scale, however, so despite possible wider variations, raising backyard chickens should mean an average improvement in hen welfare, but better does not necessarily mean positive.

Bucolic fantasies

As a solution to the vast industrial system of factory farming, how scalable is backyard farming? In Australia, the average consumer pays for twenty-five to thirty broiler chickens a

year to be raised and slaughtered on their behalf. For chicken meat, a small family of four or five people might need to keep a flock of around 120 chickens, and engage in regular slaughter to maintain the average diet. This might even mean a larger flock than this to maintain breeding numbers, and then they would need more for eggs. Chicken flesh is less than half the meat Australians eat, so we would need to add a variety of other beings to this hypothetical suburban backyard as well, ponds for fish, stables, milking facilities and so on. A nuclear family would need to maintain a reasonably sized farm to sustain anything like current levels of animal product consumption. How could this even be done in the small suburban yards and apartments that today's increasingly urbanised and concentrated populations live in? This is all part of the reason most humans historically didn't eat as much meat as we do now: it simply wasn't possible before factory farms. If you want to argue for maintaining the modern animal-product-heavy diet, then you are arguing for maintaining factory farms.

Perhaps technology can provide a way out of this ethical dilemma and enable us to go on eating as we do without having to change? Cell-cultured meat, precision fermentation, and molecular farming: there are currently a handful of technologies that hypothetically promise to remove animals from factory farms and allow people to continue eating animals at current levels. None of these are yet proven at any scale, and until this happens, we will not know if they can compete on price and consumer demand with the industrialised animal agriculture system. We have little knowledge of whether the products they will produce will be comparable to current animal products in their texture, or whether they will be considered acceptable to consumers. The resistance many people and countries had to genetically modified foods is perhaps an example of the resistance that animal proteins produced by unfamiliar technologies could, and probably will, create. There will also be a very large animal product industry, profiting from the status quo, who will no doubt pay skillful marketers to push narratives creating suspicion and doubt about any alternatives.

Ethical simplicity

People who aren't vegan often get the idea in their head that being vegan is hard or complex, but this is just unfamiliarity and habit speaking. As a long-term vegan, I generally find it simple: Did the food come from a plant? No, don't eat it. Yes, then om nom nom! To be an ethical animal-product consumer, though, seems harder. The primary thing you need to know is not what to eat but the details of how the thing you are eating was produced. If you eat packaged food which contain animal products, go to restaurants and cafes, or eat food prepare by friends, family and colleagues, it seems there would need to be a lot of research and questions raised about how the animals were treated in whatever products were used. I can imagine long discussions with waiters and other people who serve or provide food. If you are engaged in backyard farming, it still won't change much of what happens when you purchase animal products outside of your house. For people who want to live in a more ethically consistent manner, the simpler and more effective path might be to follow a vegan diet. Of course if we are talking about ethics, practicalities of convenience and hassle are relevant but not the core of the story. Taking a sentient being's freedom away, using its body for profit and production, taking away family life from them, and killing them while still essentially children, will always be a form of oppression.

Habit can blind us to our agency for positive change. Whether we think about them or not, every day we are making powerful choices about other sentient lives. Through our daily consumption choices, at restaurants and supermarkets, we directly affect animals. We have some control over whether other beings experience more or less pain, or even exist. We affect

the lives of others for better or worse, even if we aren't aware of it, or never see or interact with them. Veganism is part of taking responsibility for this wider ethical reality, of engaging in the hope that humans can transcend being a narcissistic and oppressive species.

Paying to outsource oppression and slaughter, however, as most people currently do, is ethically unacceptable. But, we can do better than to turn our backyards into more places to oppress and slaughter animals, even if it is a better sort of oppression. Luckily, we have a simple choice we can make to escape this ethical quandary. We can join the growing millions of people who are choosing to embrace veganism, for the animals. We can be part of a movement showing the way to a brighter shared future on our Earth between human beings and other life.

9. Food

Question

Why do you eat things that look like meat?

Alternatives

Thinking that every plant-derived alternative is made of soy or tofu. Thinking all plant-derived alternatives have unnatural ingredients.

Summary

If you are offended by someone happily eating a veggie burger or sausage, and not by billions of animals suffering in slaughterhouses and factory farms, perhaps you need to reconsider your ethical framework. Vegans are generally more concerned with the ethics, not the aesthetics, of what we eat. Plant milks and meat alternatives have been widely eaten by many cultures for many centuries. If people are bothered by food that hasn't involved an animal in a factory farm or going through a slaughterhouse, then it is those people, not the vegans, who need to change.

Discussion

If carnists are so offended by vegans making food that looks like animal products, this begs the question: why aren't meat eaters eating things that look like parts of animals? A rissole, a burger pattie, a sausage, a bolognese, and even a steak, many of the things you find in a restaurant don't look much like their natural form. If animal products were so naturally delicious and appealing, why wouldn't aren't there restaurants everywhere just serving carnists the straight raw flesh torn from the bone? Freshly severed and still bleeding pig's leg, anyone? Why aren't live creatures simply brought to the table for the diners to kill and process themselves, without any tools? Instead, animal flesh is eaten after lots of processing and alteration. The fur, skin, feathers, scales, bones, intestines, organs, head, tail, and hooves will be removed, the blood will be drained, mostly, and then what is left will be shaped, spiced, marinated, sauced, textured, burnt and served with things derived from plants. Again, why don't carnists eat things that resemble animals?

Peace foods

We should start with some history of human food. There have been vegetarian sausages for a long time, certainly since the 19th century. During the First World War, "peace" sausages that were wholly or largely derived from plants were eaten in many countries as part of rationing. Though primarily made from things like soy or lentils, they would sometimes contain traces of meat. Vegetarian burgers have a much longer history. An Arabic recipe for an eggplant-based patty dates back to 1226. In Europe, a 14th-century recipe book included a recipe to make

broad bean patties, which sound much like the veggie burgers commonly eaten today. Tofu is at least 2000 years old, with a legend that it was created by a prince who mixed soy with calcium sulphate while attempting to create an elixir of immortality. Seitan, one of the most popular meat substitutes, is made of wheat gluten and was mentioned in China in the 6th century. In the early 18th century, seitan featured in an Italian cookbook. Seitan became commercially available in the USA in the late 19th century. Tempeh was invented in Indonesia around 1700, though it wasn't commercially produced in the West until the 1940s. Buddhist practises have always contained a strong vegetarian strain, and contributed to China being the originator of many of the mock products which are still being improved upon and widely eaten today.

Milks made from plants have a long history in the human diet. In English, the word milk has been used with respect to plant-based milks for at least eight hundred years. Almond milk was popular in Europe in the Middle Ages, especially useful for Christians who abstained from all animal products on their many religious days. In the Middle East, plant milks were popular, and an Arabic recipe for Almond Milk dates back to 1226 CE. Although something resembling soy milk is made in order to produce tofu, the first record of it specifically as a drink dates from China in 1365. The first commercial soy milk production in Europe started in 1910 in France. Native Americans had been making plant-based milks from hickory nuts, walnuts, and pecans before Europeans arrived in North America. Coconut milk has long been a popular ingredient in cooking around Asia for thousands of years, with the first reference to it, specifically using the word milk, in English in 1698.

Mock meats and plant milks are certainly nothing new, but some people have become very worked up about them in recent times, as they started becoming more popular. It is not their existence that these people seemingly object to, but the threat that they represent to existing commercial interests. Conservative politicians aligning themselves with animal product producers have been hysterically alarmed at the rise in consumption of plant foods. They have tried to fight back at this in many ways, with a main strategy being the legislation of bans for terms like milk, sausage, burger, yoghurt and so on. In some cases, even though these terms have been used without issue, sometimes, for centuries, they have been successful. In Turkey, vegan cheese was seen as such a threat that it is now illegal to produce it. Why this is so triggering, and why a movement against these products emerged only in the early 21st century, is an interesting question involving commercial interests, conformity, and resistance to change and modernity. The culture wars have spilled out into what gets cultured.

Reclaiming words

Interestingly, the word meat wasn’t originally defined as animal flesh; meat just meant food, and then, more specifically, substantial, hearty food. It wasn't until the 19th century that the idea of it representing animal flesh completely replaced the older usage of the term, coincident with an increase in the consumption of animal products. Before refrigeration and factory farming, consuming animal products in the quantities now common was unrealisable for the average person, especially those living in cities. This is evident in most cultural cuisines, which were historically plant-based and often used animal products in more sparing ways. The diets of most countries only became animal product-heavy relatively recently.

Back to animal products looking like animal products, carnists seem unreasonably precious about terms here. We don't want to spoil any delusions, but most fish don't have fingers, and buffalo don’t have wings, though we don't see anyone get upset about these terms. Cheese,

butter, sausages, milk and burgers, all of these products go through production processes that alter them significantly from their natural look, state, and taste. What humans seem to like is the process of cooking itself, which means combining, mixing, shaping, flavouring, and texturing, in order to create different culinary experiences. These processes are largely the same as those used when cooking with plants. Tofu is an excellent example of this: some people unwisely try tofu raw and find it unpalatable. You could say the same thing, though, about many foods, such as starchy root vegetables like potatoes, a foundational part of the global diet. You need to do some preparation for the deliciousness of tofu and potatoes to reveal itself. I know a few hardcore people who like to eat raw tofu, but then I once knew someone who would bite into a raw onion like an apple, so there's no accounting for taste. Everyone else I know who enjoys tofu adds some salt and pepper, or a marinade, cooks it in various ways, adds maybe a dash of chilli or soy sauce, some veggies and carbs on the side, and suddenly you have a dish that provides plenty of nutrition and flavour. Tofu does come in a wide variety of textures and styles, so it takes a little experimentation to understand which one is right for a particular recipe. My tip would be to start with the firmer varieties, pan-fried in a bit of soy sauce, and go from there.

Decentering meat

People often mentally focus on animal products when that is only a part of what they eat. I read a news story about a group of men who went on a camping trip together, and they said it had been a meat fest. They had collectively consumed something like 50kg of meat on the trip. Later in the story, it listed their full list of supplies for the trip, and I noted that they had also eaten more than 50kg of vegetables, along with plenty of bread and other plant-derived foods. It is probably for cultural and identity reasons that they didn't describe their male bonding session as a vegetable fest, which would have been more accurate. Take your standard burger, that carnists with nothing better to do complain vegans should come up with a new name for. Like many other meals, the animal flesh in most burgers is only part of the total nutrition and calories. Take one of the most commonly eaten burgers in the world, the Big Mac, once called the communion wafer of modern consumerism. Three-fifths of a Big Mac by weight is non-animal ingredients, comprised of bread, sesame seeds, oils, sauces, lettuce, onion, pickles, and so on. The bread, sauce, sesame seeds, and onion are as fundamental to the taste and texture of a Big Mac as the other ingredients. Generally, if people are just eating a plain burger, called a rissole where I grew up, the meat patty is combined with herbs and spices, vegetables such as onions and capsicum, and then it is finished with flour or breadcrumbs. The burgers will then be seasoned and grilled in oil, which further changes the texture and flavour. With most fast food, the meat is only a part of the final product, or has been so heavily processed and flavoured that it barely resembles or tastes like animal flesh does naturally. If vegans replace the meat in any of these dishes with some plant-based protein source, given that we still do all the other things to it, we can get a pretty similar end experience. Why people get offended by this, and how they can find it something more worthy of getting upset about than slaughterhouses and factory farms, is hard to fathom.

What people who go vegan often realise is that it wasn't the taste of meat that added much to food, it was their practical use as an ingredient in a meal, especially their texture, fat content and protein. I find texture particularly important; a burger without a dense patty is a little too easy to chew through. A large part of making the perfect veggie patty or sausage is getting a firm texture. Humanity has spent centuries coming up with different cuisines and recipes, and vegans see no need to discard this culinary history when we can continue adapting it and mining it for sensual pleasure. Everything an animal product brings to a meal can be replaced

with other things that have similar properties. If we swap a few ingredients and then add the same spices and flavours and cook it in a similar way, we end up with something that ticks most of the same boxes for our palate.

How well do plant-based alternatives mimic animal products? How much a product resembles any animal-based product depends partly on the intent behind the recipe. While some veggie burgers try to mimic a meat style, others proudly display their plant origins. Some commercial products are almost uncomfortably similar, but most of the time, when cooking at home, we aim to make things that are pleasurable in a related but different way. How much that difference bothers you is subjective. If you've ever met people who argued passionately about which of two products is better, say Coke or Pepsi, Android or Apple, Vegemite or Marmite, when they are actually pretty similar, you realise some of our preferences are quite arbitrary and often inconsequential. After you've had a sufficient break from animal products, your tastes and expectations will adjust; personally, I don't compare things anymore because it's been decades since I ate animal products. You couldn't look into a busy vegan restaurant and know it was any different to any other restaurant. You will see people ordering and enjoying food, talking happily with friends, full of the same joy of food and life.

Beyond meat

When it comes to replacing animal protein, we have a wide array beyond the mighty tofu and slightly more niche tempeh. Beans and lentils are the easiest, cheapest and often healthiest drop-in replacements, but there are also nuts, seeds, grains, mushrooms, seitan, soy derivatives and other alternatives from the wide and diverse plant kingdom. There is a range of commercially made products that are increasing in quantity and quality. These are designed to be like-for-like replacements for animal products in a meal and are especially helpful for people making the transition. If someone wants to start having plant-based meals a few times a week without much fuss, what could be easier than swapping in some plant-based chicken strips into their usual stir fry or tacos, or some veggie mince into their bolognese, chilli or shepherd's pie? These vegan alternatives get better and more varied all the time as veganism grows and becomes more commercially profitable. People often prejudge plant-based food as boring, but blind studies show that people like the taste of plant-based alternatives, especially if you don't tell them that they are plant-based. Eating food without animal products at the centre is more of a mental shift for many people than any other aspect of the change. We all learned about our current diet unconsciously at our family kitchen table, and to change that requires learning a slightly different way of eating. To eat a diet that follows vegan principles, we need a little adapting, experimenting to find what foods we like and don’t like from the ever-increasing number of vegan choices out there. We need to experiment with different plant-based recipes and options. This is often a short transition, with much of the work being done once we can figure out a handful of staple dishes that will form the core of our regular meals.

Above all, people getting upset about vegans enjoying a veggie sausage are missing the point. Nobody goes vegan because they object to the texture, shape or flavour of animal products. People mostly go vegan because they object to the violence and oppression inherent in animal products; they want to boycott a system they see as cruel, environmentally damaging and unnecessary. A lot of vegans do avoid products resembling animal foods because they have uncomfortable connotations for them, and that is fine. Other vegans are happy eating anything so long as it isn't contributing to factory farming, which is also fine. Personally, I enjoy these products occasionally and see them as clear evidence of how little we need to give up to end factory farming and live more compassionately.

There are many things we could get offended by in the world, but sometimes that is a choice, and we need to have some sense of proportion about what actually matters. To reiterate the point I made above, if a person is offended by someone happily eating a veggie sausage, but they pay little attention to billions of animals suffering in slaughterhouses and factory farms, they are the ones who need to evolve.

10. Natural

Question

Eating meat is natural

Alternatives

Killing and death are part of nature. What about the food chain? Lions eat meat.

Summary

Whether something has been done for a long time doesn't mean it is necessary, just or compassionate. Consider the many horrible practices humanity has engaged in throughout the centuries. We might be able to justify many of these practices as natural, but that is another question as to whether they should be perpetuated. Ethical progress requires us to question our natural instincts and sometimes nature itself. Life in a state of nature is complex and does not express itself only through violence, as some seem to believe. Empathy and kindness are quieter but still powerful forces in evolution, especially the evolution of social species like humans. Each of us contains many possibilities from our evolutionary inheritance and we can choose which parts we wish to perpetuate. In thinking about a better future for our species a reverence for the natural world is vital, but so too is a reverence for our highest inner selves, as expressed through our philosophies and ethics.

Discussion

How much can we look to the natural world as our ethical guide?

As much as humans have long wished for an ordered, moral universe, one that makes sense, the laws that govern the universe are mathematical and amoral. Good things happen to bad people; bad things happen to good people. Our fate is in some part governed by the elegant but soulless laws of physics. Humanity made up things like karma, heaven and hell to give us the impression of a just universe. We wanted to shield ourselves from the uncomfortable truth that the control we have over our lives is limited. Hard work, intelligence and diligence are all potent factors in deciding what sort of life we will have, but fate often comes in and overrules them all. It would be nice if the universe had some sort of innate justice, but it does not.

The naturalistic fallacy

Science and philosophy have long known that what happens in nature is not necessarily right or just, and hence philosophy has a concept called the “naturalistic fallacy”. To say something is natural and consider this a moral or intellectual defence of it is not enough. Massive outbreaks of deadly diseases used to be common; to intervene with modern medicine is not necessarily natural, but it is surely the most moral action available. Cannibalism, slavery,

warfare, patriarchy, oppression and all manner of atrocities have long and fairly universal histories in all larger human societies. Studies on human cannibalism show we have been eating each other almost as long as we have been eating other species. Our ancestors were practising cannibalism over a million years ago, well before we evolved into homo sapiens. Is claiming cannibalism as natural a valid ethical defence of it? What about murder? Should a murderer be able to use the fact that people have always murdered each other as a defence in a court of law? If the "natural" defence doesn't apply to murdering humans, then we shouldn't apply it to murdering other species. As vegans, we don't think our part in causing suffering is absolved by the fact that other people do it, whether now or in the past. Causing unnecessary suffering requires a higher ethical justification than appealing to conformity or habit.

What about lions?

A common refrain here might be, "But lions eat meat!" Confusing the ethical nature of human and non-human animals has a long history. For hundreds of years, various regions in Europe put animals on trial for crimes ranging from murder to property damage. Most trials involved farm animals, and cases involved pigs, bulls, cows, horses, donkeys and mules. The trials took the same course as they would for human defendants, even to the extent of the animals being given legal representation. If found guilty, the animal would be publicly executed. In one alleged case depicted in 1457, a mother sow and her piglets were put on trial for killing a child. While the piglets were acquitted, the mother was found guilty and executed. For some reason wild animals were never put on trial, but insects and rats were for damaging crops. If found guilty, they would be exiled, or the church would be asked to intervene through exorcisms or incantations. Though not the subject of a trial, in the US case from 1916, an elephant lashed out at her trainer after he hit her with a hook, and crushed the man. A crowd of two thousand people turned out shortly afterwards to watch Mary the elephant be hanged from chains suspended on a crane. To assert dominance an deter future rebellion, the keepers ensured the other elephants in the circus watched as well.

The reason we no longer put animals on trial in the modern world is that we have a greater understanding of the fact that animals lack moral agency. As complex as the inner worlds of many animals are, often displaying empathy and compassion, they lack the higher abstract reasoning, rationality and communication that underpins a human-style moral framework. Of course, as acknowledged by our courts of law, not all humans have the capacity for full moral agency either, such as young children and the legally insane.

Returning to the fact that people often bring up lions among the countless predatory animals they have to choose from, early nature documentaries have a lot to answer for their focus on lions, or more usually groups of lionesses, hunting. Lions, unlike humans, have evolved to be obligate carnivores. Even if lions did have the moral agency to question their diet, they would be unable to make the same sorts of choices omnivores like humans can about where to get nutrients. Another behaviour that lions have evolved is infanticide. When a lion defeats another lion and takes over a pride, they will often immediately kill all of the unweaned cubs. This forces the lionesses in the pride to become more fertil, so that the lion can start propagating his own genetic material immediately. If someone believes that lions eating meat provides justification for the same behaviour by humans, how would they feel about someone justifying infanticide using the same logic? Human moral agency is key to why that makes little sense. The complex morality humans are capable of is one of the aspects of the human species that is to be most celebrated.

Modernity and nature

If there is a higher meaning in the story of our species, it probably lies somewhere in our collective ethical and intellectual progress. Humanity has made significant, though patchy, progress in many areas, including law, justice, democracy, medicine and philosophy. We did not guide this progress by appeals to what is natural, but by questioning what is good and just. The ethics of our relationship with non-human animals should be a fundamental part of our conversation about human progress. Continuing to participate in the oppression of animals, especially farmed animals, is not an unchangeable part of our nature, but rather a choice we make.

A respect for nature is obviously important, especially given the limits of our knowledge and our poor history of intervening in natural systems. Even if eating animals is natural, to call the modern diet "natural" or the factory farming system "natural" is to render the word meaningless. It is almost a cold joke to use the word natural when one of the primary drivers of the destruction of the natural world is the modern animal farming system. People who hunt wild animals with their own hands or with tools they made themselves might be able to make the claim that they are doing something natural, but that sort of system is no longer universalisable. Hunting in natural ecosystems is never going to feed billions of people meat multiple times a day or week. How we eat meat requires an unnatural system. We have long ago turned our backs on the wild, breaking the natural food chain and jettisoning our place in any sort of cycle consistent with the evolutionary system. The unnatural, oppressive animal confinement system of barbed wire, cages, and slaughterhouses; the controlled breeding of species; the pasture, which is the primary cause of deforestation; and the third of crops grown for animal feed- these are unnecessary and primary things we need to transcend if our species wants to reclaim any sort of positive, compatible relationship with the natural world. Well over nine-tenths of land-based animal mass is composed of humanity and the livestock we have bred. The majority of birds by mass in the world are composed of industrially farmed chickens. Again, to appeal to nature in justifying this system is to render the term "nature" meaningless.

Beyond the food chain

The food chain, two simple words that lead people so deeply astray. People imagine this simple structure with humans at the top, and everything else in a chain beneath it. If we think this is a natural order of things, what do we do with the knowledge that, before humans started using spears, tigers probably ate more humans than the other way around? Tigers, lions and other big cats may eat hundreds of people each year. Sharks, crocodiles, bears, wolves, leopards, komodo dragons, anacondas, hyenas, and even our canine best friends nibble and gnaw their way through many more. Again, the long history of human cannibalism also makes things more complicated. Then we have the mites, mosquitoes, ticks, fleas, lice, leeches and flies that regularly prey on humans. After we die, our corpses would naturally be picked apart by scavengers, microbes, bugs and so on. We probably started burning and burying our bodies because we were uncomfortable with this process, and maybe we didn't want animals getting a taste for our flesh. There are also tiny beings that live in places like our eyebrows, and bacteria that inhabit our bodies. Indeed, there are so many microscopic organisms living in and on our bodies that it is believed that anywhere up to half of our total cell count is microbial cells. Where does all this place humans in the mythical food chain? A food web might be more accurate, but this probably also undersells the full complexity of how countless species interact with each other. The fact that an idea like there being a food chain, bigger fish eating smaller fish, has persisted for so long in our consciousness is a pointer to how much people prefer

simple ideas over comprehending the complexity of reality.

We can reimagine the human role in the natural world and the meaning of our individual lives in relation to it. Human higher consciousness hands us unearned power and, therefore, potential responsibility. Killing, death, disease, whatever evils there are in nature, as human beings, we are able to reflect on them and even potentially intervene in them. Imagine humanity becoming the great caretaker species of our world. There are so many positive ways humans could interact with the non-human world. We could bring healing to other species, lessen the impacts of disease and disaster, and make this planet a kinder place for more beings to exist. For other animals, we could try to be like the benevolent gods we have always imagined, so long as we remember that we do not possess the omnipotence of our imagined gods. Our philosophies should be built on a reverence for the evolutionary systems of life, instead of using nature as an excuse for limiting our circle of compassion.

Nature

Nature is incredibly complex and there are no simply answers as to when we should use it as a guide or otherwise. There are times when it is appropriate to appeal to nature, and other times when it makes little sense. We might, for example, say we prefer to buy products, particulary ones we put in or on our body, that are "natural". Natural in this sense means something akin to harmony with evolution; it is shorthand for the fact that these products have a long lineage of interacting within ourselves or our ecosystems. Because they have been widely used, we would assume them to be less likely to have undiscovered properties and side effects. Appealing to what is natural in this respect is a practical claim. The things humans create interact with the natural systems that are vital to the health of all life; systems that are vulnerable to disruption and generally beyond our complete understanding.

Appealing to what is natural with respect to ethics is a very different claim. Ethics are an emergent property of consciousness, rather than an inherent structural element within nature. They are grounded in and enabled by nature and the evolved properties of sentience: the ability for sentient beings to have positive and negative physical and emotional experiences of existence. However, they then transcend the purely physical universe, extending into the immaterial realm of ideas. They dwell and take their final form in our intellectual and philosophical selves. An example of the relationship between nature and our intellectual selves is the concept that a human being should not be subjected to cruel and unusual punishment. Although rooted in evolved mechanisms like pain, this claim extends into the concepts partly in thought, such as human dignity.

It takes levels of intellectual abstraction to draw a line from the workings of the natural world to concepts like animal or human rights. Utilitarian calculations of pleasure and pain can get us some part of the way, but eventually such calculations lead us to places that feel morally repugnant. Take the Ursula K. Le Guin story, in which a single child's suffering is required for the rest of the society to enjoy a high standard of living. Adding up the pleasure and pain of this society and deciding that this was a positive outcome is a conclusion that only psychopaths and perhaps some economists would agree with. The concept of slavery is another area where an economist might make a utilitarian calculation that weighs costs and benefits, and find that some people would be better off as slaves. People who have experienced slavery, even in its less harsh forms, would generally come to a different conclusion. The partly intangible concept of freedom, of personal autonomy, are behind the the words spoken before the American War of Independence: "Give me liberty, or give me death". Before advanced human information

processing, the concept of liberty was an instinct that most animals shared. We have taken that natural impulse and added many layers and nuances to it.

Interestingly, what we now call human rights were previously called natural rights or natural laws. The use of the word natural here was meant to embody the idea that the universe had divinely embedded ethical laws that could not be overridden by humans. Starting from an almost universal belief in a divinely created universe, thinkers mistook evolved human traits like sociability, fairness, mirror neurons and empathy as the fingerprints of an ethical creator. The very need for the concept of human rights, however, comes about because our ethics are neither clearly apparent in nor enforced by nature; if there are fingerprints, they are faint and obscure indeed. Even our theologies must in some ways reckon with the world as it is, for there are limits on our ability to imagine our existence from outside of its walls. Neither the atheist nor the theist can ignore the philosophical ramifications of the fact that pain, bad, and evil are highly correlated words. We cannot get lost in a realm of pure thought disconnected from reality. The world, that which exists outside of ourselves, is the focal point that anchors our ideas, around which our ability to communicate coherently depends. Nature is a guide, not, as previous thinkers believed, either god's creation or god itself.

Conclusion

To say something is natural is not the end of a discussion; though it is often an important fact within that discussion. Many of us have positive connotations of the word nature, but in its amoral totality, it is not something to be universally celebrated. The brutality in nature has no inherent meaning or positivity, even if that brutality might lead to what seem like positive outcomes. The majesty and beauty of a carnivore in full flight, the structural niche they have made for themselves in productive ecosystems, cannot be easily disentangled from the horror and pain they cause. Instead of being something we should accept and model ourselves on, brutality in nature is in some ways our greatest intellectual and ethical challenge. We have both the ability to perceive the injustices and cruelties in nature and the power to intervene to make nature less brutal. We should recognise ourselves as powerful actors. The choice we have before us in using that power is what will the parts of reality that our actions can and do touch be like. What will the legacy of our passing through time and space be on the ocean of sentient experience? To act, to do nothing, to be or not to be, every choice and non-choice has ethical consequences, some of them profound. The universe can be kinder and more just, including for other animals, if we make positive choices.

Living an ethical life asks more of us intellectually than conformity to nature and an unquestioning obedience to the world we were born into. Progress happens when we rethink the way things are, as far as we can from first principles, and imagine better ways things can be. A more ethical universe is a lofty goal, a heroic challenge for humanity that requires the flourishing of the best within us. To transcend our limitations, to outgrow our myopic selfishness and embrace the complexity of the interconnected reality of life, is a worthy challenge of our higher consciousness. Such lofty goals begin by taking pragmatic, powerful actions in our daily lives. By changing how we consume, especially what we eat, we can vote to balance and heal the natural world.

Our full individual and collective ethical potential shall only start to be realised when we acknowledge our interdependence on, and our place within, the grand family of life. Veganism is part of a new conception of humanity’s potential within our complex evolutionary world.

11. Eat

Question

But what can vegans eat?

Alternatives

Being vegan is hard. Being vegan is expensive.

Summary

Anyone who believes that millions of vegans are wasting away trying to find food hasn't met enough vegans. Vegans come in all shapes and sizes, from slim to voluptuous, athletic to wiry, couch potato to powerlifter. Vegans do have lower rates of obesity than meat-eaters, but we aren't all calorie-deprived. Veganism is about compassion, not self-denial or purity. Most of us have access to an unprecedented variety of foods, so it has never been easier to make more compassionate choices. Most people already eat a variety of plant foods, which make up the majority of the calories they consume; so they've already got a great starting point for embarking on a plant-derived diet.

Discussion

When you tell someone you are vegan, they picture their own diet with animal products removed and get confused. Animal products seem to form the psychological centre of people’s meals, especially for males. Of course, most people already get around half their protein and the majority of their calories from plant foods, but for some reason, they don't see it that way. For most people, moving to a plant-based diet would only require changing a handful of ingredients. For animal flesh, for instance, most products come, almost exclusively, from four sources: chickens, cows, pigs and fish. So you could become a vegetarian, largely by removing 4 ingredients. If you then remove eggs and products made from cow’s milk, you have cut out the vast majority of animal products in the average diet. By cutting out 6 ingredients, you could be following a predominantly plant-derived diet. So what would you replace them with?

A world of choice

A quick Google search tells me there are 20,000 plant species that people eat. Well, the first search result said that. Another result said it was 300,000 species, then one said 80,000. The exact number of edible plant species is unimportant; we can just say there are a lot. There are thousands of fruits, vegetables, grains, nuts and pulses that we have never heard of. Many foods unfamiliar to us are staples and delicacies in other cultures. Most people eat a limited subset of the wide variety of plant foods available and mistakenly assume that is all there is, but there is a world of plant foods out there we have yet to explore.

Ask any healthy, long-term vegan, and they will tell you they eat a greater variety of foods since going vegan than they did before. Unfortunately, some people who try a vegan diet just remove animal products from the picture of what people eat, in line with the picture of the standard diet they unconsciously inherited from their environment. A plant-based diet then unnecessarily feels like a diet of self-denial, of less variety, that is far less healthy and interesting than it should be. It is probably fine, in the early stages of transitioning our diet, to just remove some ingredients from our kitchens and plates, but to set ourselves up for success, we should soon embrace a healthier way of eating. For all the problems surrounding eating animal products, if we spent our lives learning and eating a diet based on them, they would play a role in our diet's nutritional profile. By reimagining what a healthy plate of food looks like, we can maintain or improve the nutritional power and sensual delight of what we eat. People who thrive on a vegan diet are those who have educated themselves on what healthy plant foods they can add to their plate to make it nutritionally complete and delicious. The Vegan Society website is a great place to consult for recipes and nutritional guidance. Some vegans may take more time in making this educational transition than others, but given our diet's important role in our physical and mental well-being, it is always a worthwhile long-term investment to make in ourselves.

Repairing the food pyramid

Most of us will be familiar with the concept of the food pyramid that governments often release. Few people, though, know or suspect how much the business of animal agriculture has been influential in creating our government's nutritional guidelines. Luckily, though, the advancing science of nutrition cannot be completely denied by corporate interests. For decades now, we have seen foods like tofu, beans, nuts, and other alternative proteins start to appear alongside their animal product counterparts in nutritional guidelines.

Veganism does not upend the food pyramid but adjusts it in a way that will be largely familiar. Whole grains, vegetables and fruits continue to create the foundation and majority of calories. We replace other parts of the pyramid with some of the wide variety of plant-based foods high in proteins, healthy fats, calcium, iron and omega-3s, etc. We are not intent on overturning the food pyramid, but repairing it. Anyone eating a diet recommended by the world’s peak nutritional organisations will already be eating in a way that resembles a plant-based food pyramid. They can then start to replace any animal products in their diets with nuts, seeds, beans, legumes, grains, fungi, tofu, tempeh, mushrooms, soy, seitan, fruits and vegetables. Ingredients play a role in a given dish, and we can quickly learn to replace the textures and flavours we desire. It is similar to nutrients, we adjust the sources of them, the protein, fats, iron and so on, making sure we are eating foods optimal for our personal goals.

Milk is a good example of the variety of vegan foods that we can enjoy when substituting animal products. Instead of a single type of milk taken from the mouths of calves, vegans can choose from oat, soy, almond, macadamia, cashew, rice, hemp, quinoa, coconut, and many more, including blends. In my local supermarket, there are also plant milks that are high-protein, barista, organic, high-calcium, flavoured and other versions, so you can try as many as you need to in finding one that is right for you. Almost every common animal product has a plant-based version for those who want them, from plant-based cheeses, marshmallows, milk chocolate (much dark chocolate was always vegan-friendly), condensed milk, mayonnaise, yoghurt, haggis, black pudding, bacon, jerky, salami…you get the idea. A diet reliant on these “mock” products isn't as cheap as eating more beans and lentils, but eating too many of these products, vegan versions or otherwise, isn’t nutritionally optimal anyway. They are out there if

you need them, though, and can be found online, in health food shops, and increasingly in regular supermarkets.

Some vegans identify as “junk-food vegans”. They would roll their eyes at all of the pontification about healthy eating here and say that veganism is not a diet, and they are correct. Veganism is a philosophy about the human relationship with other sentient beings, one that aims to reduce our contribution to their suffering. How healthy our diet is doesn't really change those equations. Junk food vegans will happily centre their diet on animal-free convenience products, such as plant-based meats and dairy products, sweets and snacks. There are also many "accidentally vegan" convenience products, which you will find in your supermarket. A diet where we swap animal products for plant-derived analogues can make the transition to veganism easier, as we don't have to change the practical shape of our diet after going vegan. Of course, this option wasn't as available to older vegans, and still might be difficult for people living in vegan-alternative deserts. If you have the opportunity and can pay the premium, though, this type of diet is still a huge win for the planet and animals.

Back to the future

Vegans and vegetarians have a saying, "Eat beans, not beings". Eating a diet comprised of a large number of alternative products can get expensive, as well as lead to missing out on health benefits. Rice, beans, lentils, whole grains and starchy roots have been the basis of healthy human diets for millennia. They are still the foundation of many traditional cultural diets because they are the cheapest, most versatile and healthiest foods you can find. They aren’t always the quickest or most convenient to prepare compared to modern processed foods, but whatever our diet, that is something we should be moving away from. By embracing cooking and considering the time spent in nurturing ourselves and our loved ones as a good investment, we can reclaim our personal sovereignty from food corporations that don't care about animals or us. These, often multinational, corporations are happy to perpetuate cruelty to animals and manipulate consumers in search of profit. People buying their products adds to their share price, and they don't care about the other effects on the world. Ultimately, food is an incredibly personal journey. It’s up to each of us if and how we integrate convenience products into our diet. The animals you spare from factory farms don't care if you want to be a junk food vegan, a whole foods plant-based vegan, or somewhere in between.

One of the healthiest diets ever studied is the Whole-Foods Plant-Based Diet. Many of its recipes are based on traditional world cuisines. Before ultra-processed foods reliant on oil, sugar, salt and deep frying, people put flavour into foods with herbs, spices, skilful cooking and quality ingredients. Whatever amount of time you are willing to invest in learning how to cook a WFPB diet will be a win for your pocket, the animals, your health and that of your loved ones. Creating and sharing tasty, healthy plant meals is a personal skill that will reverberate positively in your relationships and the world.

Habits and routines

We forget about how much of our diet is routine and habit. Habit can be our enemy in making positive change, but it can quickly become our friend in maintaining it. Adopting a positive lifestyle change, like following a vegan diet, will often seem more daunting than it is, partly because people fear change itself. This is despite the fact that most of us will have experienced how new habits, once acquired, quickly become as automatic and easy as old habits. Once we take a positive or negative direction in our lives, it soon starts to build its own momentum, so

much so that we can't recognise the old self.

As you embrace a vegan diet, there will be a short period of adjustment. In this phase, you'll be learning and trying new things, scanning ingredients to look for what is animal-derived, and checking out the local vegan-friendly restaurants, often by using the Happy Cow website or phone application. Very soon, the core knowledge you need will start to coalesce, and the vegan diet will move from the unfamiliar to the familiar. The scale of changing your diet is also not as large as we might think. People generally cook a rotation of regular dishes, frequent the same restaurants, and buy more or less the same list of items when they go grocery shopping. Once you get the hang of these core changes, you will have achieved most of the necessary progress. This might be very quick if you are motivated to learn and research new things, but you can also take a more relaxed approach.

For people who like to cook, the perfect place to start is putting together a good roster of regular dishes, often veganised variations on the ones you already make. I like to eat from a variety of cuisines; my staple dishes involve pasta, wraps, veggie burgers, stir fries, salads, curries and soups. Now and then, I will cook something new from the Internet or a recipe book. Whether you are just starting to cook or are a foodie, there is an infinite world of vegan blogs, video tutorials, meal plans, shopping tips and recipe suggestions out there. As with learning most things, a good, free place to begin is by consulting the oracle of the Internet. To find restaurants, type in "vegan food near me". To find ingredients, try "vegan alternative to". To find recipes, try "vegan" followed by the name of your favourite dish, and start experimenting. There are also free vegan meal kits, websites that help you go vegan, online communities you can consult for advice, vegan social groups you can go along to, the awesome Happy Cow to find food wherever you are in the world, and hopefully a vegan or two in your life you can consult with.

There is a meme about eating vegan that makes light of our tendency to overcomplicate things. At the top, it has a box that says, "Is it from an animal?" Beneath the box, there are two arrows, one that says "Yes, then don't eat it", and the other that says "No, then eat it". Obviously, there's a little more knowledge required, but the meme makes a good point. People often overcomplicate a change, and this becomes a barrier to the change or an excuse not to make the change. Millions of people across vastly different cultures, at all stages of life, have gone vegan, so I'm pretty sure you can too. Most vegans hope and believe that one day this will be the norm, and it will be a better world for us all.

A new hope

Veganism is about an ethical evolution for the whole human race. We believe that one day our age will be seen as a strange and dark place with respect to our treatment of animals. People in the future will scarcely believe that the cruelty and oppression inherent in animal agriculture were not only legal but commonplace. They will not believe that so many tried to justify, or gave little thought to, the suffering of billions in factory farms and their murder in slaughterhouses. Our cruel treatment of animals is also unnecessary, which only adds to its immorality. We can eat beautifully and healthfully without participating in this oppressive, destructive system. Through our diet, we can play a part in bringing about a better shared future for all animals in this world, human and non-human.

12. Not much

Question

I don't eat much meat

Short Question

Alternatives

I am mostly vegan. Someone telling you they recently ate a vegetarian or vegan meal.

Summary

Whether you think you eat a lot of meat is partly related to who you compare yourself to. Americans and Australians consume 2 to 3 times the amount of animal products in comparison to the global average. An American who "doesn't eat much meat" might be considered an avid meat consumer in Japan, or even in America before the factory farm changed things so drastically. Someone who eats meat less than once or twice a week can probably claim they aren't eating much meat. Everyone else should say something more like "I don't eat as much meat as my red-faced uncle who drives a massive car". Most vegans appreciate the positive aspiration to eat less meat, but we can't forget that meat implies victims. Fewer animals in factory farms mean a better world with less suffering, but every animal unnecessarily slaughtered for food is an individual tragedy.

Discussion

People who say things like "I don't eat much meat" or "I just made a great lentil soup" to a vegan are often trying to connect in some way. So let's start by saying that this is generally positive, and we should encourage such statements. If someone is reducing their meat consumption or is switching to plant-based milk, this will have favourable ramifications for their health, environmental footprint and, usually, animal suffering. Not eating much meat, however, is a relative term. People often base their idea of what is a "normal" level of animal product consumption on the culture around them and the generation they are in. In some countries, average meat consumption is up to 20 times higher than in others. If we are in a culture that eats globally and historically high levels of animal products, when someone says "I don't eat much meat", they might still be eating quite a lot. It is also a vague statement, nothing as specific as "I only eat meat when I am at special events" or "I only eat animal products one day a week", so we are left to guess at what it means. Perhaps it means people have reduced their consumption, such as by eating smaller portions. Perhaps they have swapped red meat for chicken and fish. Perhaps they feel they eat less meat than some of their family members. From a vegan point of view that sees all animal product consumption as

unnecessary and unethical, this reduction often still looks like eating a lot of animal products.

The small animal replacement problem

Perhaps unintuitively, eating less meat doesn’t mean eating fewer animals. How many animals suffer as a result of your diet depends on what species of animals you eat, and at what life stage you eat them. When people consume the body of a veal calf, lamb, kid or piglet, many more must endure the cruelties of our animal farming system because, obviously, infants and children are so much smaller than adults. The average consumer might only eat the whole body of a pig in six months, and the whole body of a cow every four years. Chickens, some of the most abused animals in the farming system, are very small relative to pigs or cows. Each person regularly eating chicken flesh and eggs requires a sizeable flock to be kept on their behalf, like a shadow self that suffers on their behalf in factory farms and slaughterhouses. Multiplying this-sized flock by the number of people who want to eat chickens results in seventy-five to eighty billion broiler hens being confined over any given year. Fish are another common substitute for other animal products for people concerned about the health of their diet. Fish species vary in size, but many that humans eat are quite tiny, especially sardines, anchovies, shellfish and many crustaceans. As human overfishing assaults our marine ecosystems and the breeding cycles of every target fish species, the average captured fish becomes ever smaller, meaning more fish must be killed in a destructive downward cycle. People who eat less meat by swapping large animals for smaller animals will eat more animals, and thus potentially cause more suffering.

Collateral damage

Land-based animal farming doesn't just involve the oppression and slaughter of target species, but requires the exclusion and killing of non-target, native species. This begins with the deforestation involved, to remove imagined predators, to remove competitor species for animal fodder or water, for often preemptive, poorly researched disease control, to stop animals digging burrows and holes, to prevent them from damaging fences, and the list goes on. While the number of non-target species killed to exclude them from farms is in the hundreds of millions each year, the scale of this killing is dwarfed by the killing of non-target species in our oceans. When you eat any animal from the sea, the animal you actually eat might be a minority of the ones killed to get that sea creature to your plate. All industrial wild-fishing methods are functionally indiscriminate. Longline fishing involves trailing hooks on 10 to 100-kilometre-long lines through the sea; bottom trawling involves heavy cages being dragged across the ocean floor, destroying everything living or otherwise in their path; drift nets or "purses" are huge nets thrown onto target-rich areas to suffocate and crush whatever is in the area. Killing non-target species is called bycatch: wild sentient creatures who suffer and die just to be tossed away as refuse. In drift net and bottom trawling, bycatch often exceeds ninety per cent of all killed animals in industrial wild-fishing.

The death by bycatch is often for no purpose at all. The period during which industrial fishing gear is being actively used is often just the start of the death and carnage it will cause in our oceans. Drift nets and long lines often escape or are cut off their moorings and boats to spend decades drifting our oceans as "ghost nets" and "ghost lines", indiscriminately attracting and killing ocean life for no purpose. Discarded or lost fishing gear will finally break into smaller pieces, becoming a leading cause of plastic pollution in our oceans, including microplastics. It's not just to feed humans that this assault on our oceans takes place, but to feed our pets, farm animals, plants, and, horrifically but almost absurdly, our land-based fish farms.

So if meat reduction means someone switching their diet from pigs and cattle to chickens and fish, or even from a wild fish to farmed fish, it can mean more animals in factory farms, crushed in nets, harried and herded into slaughterhouses, impaled with hooks or suffocated. Not eating much meat can end up killing more animals. Vegans hear this a lot from well-intentioned people, but it isn't something we can necessarily celebrate.

Diet and rationality

I have often spent time with numerous people who tell me they don't eat much meat. This might be when travelling together, at work, at conferences and so on. I can't help noticing that they seem to eat a lot of animal products, every day, at both lunch and dinner, sometimes even breakfast, regardless of whether there are readily available good alternatives. Even if such people gave meat a break for a meal, which is usually only breakfast, the animals certainly don't get a break, as the meal seemingly has to feature eggs or dairy. There is something more than taste and logic going on here. I've met meat eaters who refuse to eat vegetarian meals, and vegetarians who refuse to eat vegan meals, though both groups probably happily eat such meals accidentally reasonably often, so long as they don't know. I have, on a few occasions, been out with people who don't know me well, and I've offered to buy a round of snacks for the table. I then ordered finger food like fries, chips, spring rolls, pakoras, cocktail samosas, nuts, and so on. On none of these occasions did people question the food, and they just ate it happily and thanked me. I think if I had declared, "I will get some vegan snacks for the table", it would have gone differently, probably with people feeling the need to go and buy their own snacks. A bowl of cereal for breakfast is a vegetarian meal, and if you use soy milk, it is vegan. A bowl of channa masala, daal, roti and rice is often vegan, but if you labelled them as such, many people with an animal product-centric idea of their meals would avoid them. If you ask people whether they are emotionally attached to having animal products at every meal, they would probably say no, yet their actions belie this. If people really do "not eat much meat", it might help break their emotional attachment to animal products; however, if they are just reducing portions or swapping species, it probably won't.

Vegetarian myths

The focus is often on not eating much "meat" because people consider dairy or eggs to be “deathless” industries. This is another sign of how divorced people are from the industries and practises they have paid for via their consumption over their whole life. Even people who claim some connection to these industries, "I grew up on a dairy farm" or "my uncle raises chickens", can often, with a few basic questions, be shown to be largely unaware of the cruelties which take place as standard practise in these industries. If people from rural environments are largely unaware of what goes on, we shouldn't expect a better understanding from people who grew up in urban environments. Even more so, they equate animal body parts and products more with their packaging than with the sentient, emotional beings they came from.

A short list of some of the cruelties of "vegetarian" foods must be made here, though people should take the time to confirm these things for themselves. Male chickens are killed immediately after their gender is detected, often fed alive and en masse into grinders. Their sister hens go on to spend a life of suffering before being killed after their reproductive systems are spent at a young age. Dairy cows are repeatedly impregnated to keep milk production high, which means the regular production of male calves that must be taken and killed. This is usually within a few days of them being separated from their mothers, but “humane” veal farms might let the male calves live a few months before slaughtering them. A

minority of males will instead be castrated and dehorned without anaesthetic, allowed to grow for a year or two before being slaughtered for low-grade meat production. This is changing, but only in that dairy cows are being impregnated with semen from meat-producing breeds, which will be kept alive to grow longer before being killed. Females in the dairy industry are also, if needed, dehorned without anaesthetic, and kept alive only while their reproductive systems enable peak profitability. After milk production slows at a relatively young age, they are destined to be herded onto crammed trucks for a journey during which they are neither fed nor given water, and that ends with the trials of the slaughterhouse. The dairy industry is a vast environmental and animal welfare disaster. These are just some of the cruelties and injustices that are an integral part of eating animal products, even beyond meat, in our society. If you are serious about contributing to a better world with your diet, swapping meat for eggs or cheese might mean fewer animals suffering, but many of those animals will suffer more.

The ethical and environmental case for dramatically reducing our global dependence on animal products is unassailable, despite people, out of habit and self-interest, wanting to believe otherwise. Moving from an animal product-centred diet will also benefit human health. According to our peak dietary bodies, average meat consumption in many developed countries has become too high. Health authorities consistently encourage populations to reduce meat consumption, particularly of processed meats, in favour of more fruits, vegetables, whole grains, beans, etc. Many developed countries would see significant environmental and animal welfare improvements by people simply following their peak nutritional authorities' dietary recommendations, not to mention human health improvements. Agriculture is a world-dominating industry, and animal agriculture is the most unnecessary and destructive part of it, whether we talk about deforestation, species extinction, pollution or climate change. We can do a lot of good for ourselves and the world by eating a healthier diet of more plant-based, whole foods. The world's peak dietary bodies also confirm that a well-planned vegan diet is a healthy choice at all stages of life. There is no physiological necessity to eat animal products; if people are mostly doing this out of habit, then it is a habit we must collectively replace to tread more lightly on the earth.

Inculturation

If one had to guess what somebody eats without knowing anything about them, a decent approximation would be to look at what their parents eat. Our inculturation into a specific form of eating starts when we are toddlers. We don’t put much thought into how we came to eat what, or who, we do, but over our lives, we have been taught a specific cultural diet. We have learned a taste for particular things, become accustomed to a certain level of salt, sugar and fat in our foods, certain types of spices, and learned what foods are appropriate at certain times of the day. Cultures put their own largely arbitrary constructions around the very basic need to get certain nutrients into our bodies. We can see all the cultures around the world happily eating very different diets, which they have become attached to. Many picky people would be very upset if they had to swap diets with a similarly picky person from another culture. No doubt, if we had been raised in a different culture, we would have very different tastes and preferences. Diets are, after all, beyond the nutrients, reasonably arbitrary. Yet if many people were forced to eat as a different culture does, they would be uncomfortable, resist, and possibly even angrily resist. It's irrational, but then most people live largely irrational lives that they have no desire to question. Vegans are asking people to change their diets for compassionate reasons rather than arbitrary cultural or aesthetic reasons, but we will still often face the same resistance. Diet is a pretty deep thing to change, so when people say they don't eat much meat, that might be as far as they can go without severing the links of the

shared, arbitrary identity they mistake for their individual, consciously chosen self. If we wish to change this, it may not be through the rational mind we need to go, but doing things like exposure therapy to vegan food and thought, to slowly shift cultural perceptions and open up a crack to a different self, one that has the courage to look unblinking into an uncomfortable ethical reality that their consumption makes them complicit in.

Comparison is a large and not always productive part of our identity. When people say they don’t eat much meat, they aren't comparing themselves to their great-great-grandparents' generation, which might have eaten quite differently. While the world population has more than doubled since the 1960s, livestock production and consumption have more than quadrupled. Academics call the changes in diet that have happened in almost every country post-World War II the modern nutritional transition. This has been enabled largely by factory farms, fertilisers, pesticides and intensive breeding. People don't have a good understanding of this change and how much it altered our world and our diets. Many people mistakenly think that meat has always been as central to their national cuisines as it is today. I have had conversations with people of varying nationalities who believe that not only is their national diet currently meat-heavy, but that it has traditionally always been so.

People from Spain, Japan and South Korea have all told me some version of, "My country is traditionally a heavy meat-eating culture", and on each occasion, I looked them up:

- Spain - Transitioned away from a Mediterranean diet, with one of the lowest per capita levels of meat consumption in Europe, to one of the heaviest via a 400% rise in average meat consumption since the 1940s.

- Japan - Transitioned away from a rice, vegetable and marine animal diet via a 700% rise in average meat consumption since the 1940s. For centuries, various types of animal products, including beef, chicken and eggs, were banned from consumption across Japan. These bans were only entirely lifted with the Meiji restoration and modernisation reforms in the 1850s.

- South Korea - Transitioned away from a heavily rice, vegetable and marine animal diet via a 600% rise in average meat consumption since 1970. In Korea, a country that has an ancient proverb meaning "Living through the power of rice", meat has now overtaken rice as the most consumed product.

These countries are just from people I happened to meet, but they provide examples of a global trend. Current levels of meat consumption around the world have increased dramatically alongside the spread of the factory farm, often replacing healthier, traditional plant-rich diets. Modern farming techniques and intensive breeding pioneered by heroic individuals like Norman Borlaug, along with a vast new range of pesticides and fertilisers, have increased production to the point that a global majority can now get more calories than they need. Obesity is now as much of a health problem in the world as hunger has been since time immemorial. While this increase in the quantity of food and calorific availability is rightly celebrated, the quality and variety of diets, such as the traditionally healthy diets of places like Spain, Japan, and Korea, have declined in many ways. By being so much more dependent on animal products, there has certainly been a sharp increase in their ethical ramifications

towards animals, for which there is yet to be a proper reckoning.

Evolving together

Moving to a better relationship with the earth requires large structural changes, but these can only be constructed on billions of individual changes. We live in a culture that has not adapted our individual behaviours to ever-evolving environmental and ethical realities, including those that modern technology and a surge in human population have created. This means that when we look at obvious facts, like that most of us are living lives far beyond the environmental tolerances of the earth, or that the way we eat requires immense cruelty and oppression of other species, we cannot necessarily look to the people and culture around us for positive role models for change. Often, the opposite is true; instead of helping us to be our best ethical selves, we live in a culture that makes it easier to continue living in an unethical way. This means it will take an effort of will, and our character will constantly be tested if we try to make the significant changes needed to live in a more compassionate way. For many of us, these positive choices and changes might need to be gradual, as we reorient lives that are out of sync with our ethical ideals. Taking time is understandable whilst new habits are acquired and new ways of eating and thinking become embodied in our lives. Not making those changes, however, would be to turn aside from our authentic self, to lend our support to a culture constructed on the tyranny of all other life.

In the end, we should be kind to people who hold out a hand towards us. "I don't eat much meat" is a statement of positive intention, and if properly followed through with, it will mean less suffering in the non-human world. Ideally, it would be a stepping stone. We should have higher ideals for ourselves and our contribution to the world than less bad; we should be heading towards flourishing and a higher good. A better collective future awaits humans and animals beyond the factory farms, cages, barbed wire enclosures, slaughterhouses, and other tools of animal oppression that humans have created. Not eating much meat leaves these things that should never have existed in place. A collective evolution to a global vegan culture is too important for us to linger in the ethical purgatory of transitional phases. Be part of leading the ethical evolution of our species and its relationship to the non-human world.

13. What about humans?

Question

What about human suffering?

Alternatives

You care more about animals than people. We should worry about humans first.

Summary

To think that people can only care about a single issue is false. Humans are complex; most of us can and do care about many things. Studies consistently find that caring about animals makes people more likely to care about other issues, such as human rights and the environment. The idea that we need to ration our compassion or love is a basic misunderstanding - widening our circle of empathy does not diminish, but strengthens it. People are animals too, which is why there is significant overlap between the compassion due towards humans and other animals. Being vegan does not reduce our compassion, but extends it to its necessary and logical conclusion of all that can suffer.

Discussion

What about human suffering? The premise of this statement is that some beings matter and others don't; that some suffering is legitimate to care about and some isn't. Humans apparently sit alone at the top of this hierarchy, so high above all other life in every way that too much consideration for other beings is immoral, even ridiculous. To say that we should care about humans before other animals is to say that so long as any human suffers in any way, we should not consider other suffering, no matter how egregious, widespread, or easily mitigated. Should we, for example, turn a blind eye to the suffering of the many billions that huddle in factory farms and slaughterhouses, suffering we could relatively easily eliminate? To some, the suffering of non-humans is a low priority because they see it as the suffering of far lesser beings, even morally irrelevant beings. Few positions outline human supremacy and speciesism more succinctly.

Speciesism is part of the morality underpinning animal agriculture. The treatment of animals in our farming system embodies the belief that even trivial human desires, like the preference for some ingredients over others, outweigh almost any rights a non-human being should have. The factory farming system takes everything from the animals within it, including the right to freedom, to life, to health, to family, to friendships, and to live according to their nature. The usually unstated philosophy called anthropocentrism that underlies animal product consumption is at the root of our oppressive relationship with all other life. Vegans want to bring this selfish, submerged philosophy into the light to provoke a discussion about whether our current human treatment of animals is consistent with our morality.

The idea that we cannot care about humans and other species should be rejected not only on moral grounds, but increasingly based on scientific evidence. Social science has studied whether people who care deeply about animal suffering consequently care less about other ethical issues, such as human suffering. The results of these studies show the opposite to be true, that the more people care about non-human animals, the more likely they are to care about humans as well. Kindness or its opposite appears to be a general product of our character, which applies regardless of the type of animal we interact with. Criminal science, too, backs up a wider view of compassion. Animal abuse is highly correlated, and often predictive, of abusive behaviour towards humans. Abusing one's power over another, whether human or non-human, is more of a reflection of a person's character than evidence that they have a thought-through hierarchy of a species' sentience governing their violence. Biological science has also, since at least Darwin, rejected the idea of humans as a completely separate kind of being. Evolutionary science has superseded religious notions that we have yet to completely jettison from our culture, such as the idea that humans alone have souls and that other animals were created for our use or dominion. The common evolutionary patterns we share with other animals in our bodies are so obvious that it is hard to believe that we failed to acknowledge them for so long. Only a religious story that we wanted to believe could stop us from seeing the common biological patterns between animals. Modern DNA evidence has even more comprehensively confirmed that animals are our kin, and some of our very close kin. We share 98.8% of our DNA with chimpanzees, compared to the 99.7% we share with Neanderthals, with whom humans were able to interbreed. The call for greater compassion towards non-human animals is based not purely on moral intuition and common feeling, but on our ever-deepening scientific understanding of humanity's place within the web of life.

Focusing on difference

We have a noticeable tendency to focus on the difference between non-human animals and us. It is so common that we might call it a cognitive bias. For many years, I worked at a university and would attend public lectures on a wide variety of fields. The number of times eminent academics from a variety of disciplines would start a sentence with "The difference between humans and other animals is" was quite startling. I found it particularly noticeable because usually the words were followed by statements that were some combination of wrong, tenuous, incomplete or unknowable. Still, the audience would always seem to nod along in agreement. One has to wonder if our critical thinking skills go to sleep when we are being complimented by being told of our superiority to other animals. It's not even always a positive superiority either; it can be something quite damning of us, like "Humans are the only animals that hunt for pleasure". Still, people seem predisposed to want to nod along to it, regardless of whether it is true. Groupthink seems to be especially strong when the group is a whole species.

There is something special about humans, but putting our finger on it is a little harder. For centuries, humans were called "The tool users", and it was assumed our tool use was what made us unique, until it was shown just how many animals use, and sometimes make, tools: birds, mammals and invertebrates have all been documented making and using tools. The key difference between humans and other animals has been assigned to various aspects of thinking, rationality, emotion, culture and so on, which one after the other have been shot down by behavioural biology. Many academics and writers would have saved themselves an intellectual dead end if they had listened to Darwin, who in the nineteenth century pointed out that the difference between humans and other animals was one of degree and not kind.

When you tell people something they want to hear, that they are superior to others, you can

expect a very sympathetic hearing. There is no doubt the human mind has unique aspects in the realm of abstraction and information processing, but the inaccuracy of almost all attempts to nail down the difference more specifically than this tells us more about the limitations and self-serving nature of our minds than it reveals about non-human animals. We have an incomplete understanding of our own consciousness and that of other animals; we try to clumsily point to the differences between them and us, but this is not knowledge, but theories that are a substitute for accurate knowledge.

Moral consistency

If we focused on the commonalities between humans and other beings, we would find far more fertile ground for humanity's intellectual and ethical progress. Again, Darwin pointed to how similar our internal emotional worlds were to those of other animals. We have a window into much of the lived experience of other animals because we are animals. Human suffering is animal suffering, human emotions are animal emotions: these things evolved long before humans, and we inherited these capacities, as did all of our mammalian kin. The species in our factory farms and slaughterhouses experience the feelings that we recognise in ourselves. Most animals are capable of experiencing pleasure, pain, fear, hope, hunger, thirst, anxiety, depression, affection, friendship, curiosity, parental bonding, and a full gamut of emotions. That their experience is different to ours, even if in some ways it might be less complex, does not make them unworthy of consideration and care. Like us, other animals are sentient beings thrown into existence, and seek safety, security and happiness. The violence inherent in eating and using other animals seems to have blinded us from seeing this clearly. In reclaiming our relationship with the animal world, we can look back to the origin of the word animal, rooted in the ancient Greek word anima, or soul. The commonality that this word represents should be the centre of our morality and philosophy towards all sentient life.

Martin Luther King said, "Injustice anywhere is a threat to justice everywhere.” This is not just an ethical statement, but a pragmatic one: the simplest morality to teach and internalise is one based on consistent logical principles. We can look at the techniques used in enabling wide-scale atrocities. One common strategy is to justify different ethical principles being applied to the desired victims from the normal ethics held in the society. A phrase pertinent and revealing to this and our wider discussion is "dehumanisation". Dehumanisation is a way to overcome our natural human empathy towards others by leaning into our speciesism. Perpetrators will try to dehumanise their victims by calling them names like snakes, rats, fleas, lice, cockroaches, sheep, pigs, cattle, or simply animals. Once you have associated the victim group with animals, they no longer need to be treated with empathy. Even victims often enter this framing. A common refrain is "They treated us like animals", as people describe being treated in ways that would be horrific regardless of the species on which it was inflicted. It is terrible that seemingly normal people can allow themselves to go along with the dehumanisation of others. We can find some hope in the fact that for most people it requires propaganda and lies to do so. The percentage of people who score highly on the dark triad of personality traits, psychopathy, Machiavellianism, and narcissism, is significant and overrepresented in those who seek leadership and power, but they are still a minority in society. To get most people in a society to behave badly requires a story that hides that behaviour under a cloak of ethics. Even some of the worst actors want to believe this kind of story and will go into elaborate justifications as to why their cruel behaviours were actually in the service of a higher morality.

It is because most people are mostly decent and fair that justifications for violence are necessary. These justifications are evident not only in how we act towards each other, but also

towards all other life. The same process of deliberate removal of empathy plays out in our societal violence towards animals. The main justifications used to enable violence towards animals have been summarised by Melanie Joy as "Normal, natural, necessary and nice".

The ideology of oppression

It has been said that there was a large change in human thinking towards animals when we moved from the hunter-gatherer paradigm to grazing and farming. The hunter-gatherer paradigm tended to respect nature and other creatures, whereas the grazier/farmer paradigm tended to subjugate other creatures beneath humans. When you are slaughtering an animal, beating an ox, or taking a cow's children and milk away, it wouldn't be psychologically comfortable for you to think of them as kin, to think of their cries as similar to the ones you yourself might make in the same situation. To feel better about our oppression of others, we must emphasise that they are different and lower than us, and that their demeaned state means our poor treatment of them is therefore morally acceptable. We see this lack of respect in many of the words we use to demean other people while also demeaning the animals themselves. Whether it be to insult someone's intelligence, common sense, or their body shape, we often use the names of species that we breed and use in farming: cow, turkey, goose, chicken, pig, ass, dog, bitch, and so on. This disrespect serves a purpose, helping us to ignore our empathy to feel better about our participation in the oppressions of thinking, feeling beings.

A study had people watch films of traditionally farmed animals playing, and so on. The researchers gave each study participant a bowl of animal or plant-based snacks to eat while watching the films. After the film, the researchers asked the study participants to rate the animals on aspects like intelligence and moral worth. Those who watched the films while eating the animal-derived snacks rated the animals lower on all morally relevant measures than those given the plant-derived snacks. Eating animals leads people to rate those animals lower in intelligence. People know that there is significant cruelty in animal farming and need to justify their participation in this mistreatment by demeaning the sentience of the animals. One interesting aspect of this is that they don't appear to do this consciously. The intellectual mechanism behind this is called cognitive dissonance, a state where a person has two conflicting beliefs, especially ethical beliefs, that must be reconciled. The ethical conflict of carnism is fairly transparent: eating animals requires cruelty, but it is morally unacceptable to be cruel to animals. There are two paths towards escaping this dilemma: the first is to change our treatment of animals so it is less cruel, and the second is to create an internal narrative that justifies our cruelty towards animals. Our society has largely taken the second, lazier and more selfish path, one that requires us to demean the sentience of the animals we abuse. This is another example of how powerfully our perceived self-interest can pervert our thinking, something that often happens at a semi-conscious or subconscious level. Our brains are actively enabling unethical behaviour and resisting ideas and changes necessary to live more ethical lives. Being a more ethical person for many people will take a sustained effort of conscious will, self-questioning and introspection.

We return here to the revealing phrase that one hears when a person or group is being described as unjustly or violently treated: "They were treated like animals". This phrase falls very differently on the ears of someone who rejects speciesism. It seems to reflect an underlying conception that violence and injustice are acceptable when they target the appropriate victims. To look into the fearful eyes of a sentient being or to hear their cries, and to decide that you don't care about them, does not seem a wholly morally different action when

directed towards one species or another. The human ability to feel positive and negative emotions, pleasure and pain, safety or fear, is inherited from our animal origins, not a product of our more recent higher consciousness. This speciesism, which has such terrible ramifications for animals, is also a short step away from deciding that some subclass or group of our own species requires less ethical consideration. Indeed, we don't have to hypothesise about this. The history of inter-human atrocities shows many that involved equating the targeted group of victims with animals. If we were more morally consistent in teaching compassion towards animals, it seems certain to have a positive effect on our compassion towards each other. There is much to be said for promoting moral consistency. Aristotle said: our morals are like a muscle that grows stronger through regular exercise. We will all benefit from widening our moral circle and rejecting speciesism.

Part of a whole

When we choose to care about an issue, we act as part of a wider system. This means that we should adapt how we work on an issue to its overall context. If everyone is working on some aspect of a cause, such as reducing suffering, then it might make sense for us to focus our attention on the more neglected aspects of that cause.

Philanthropy is an important way in which people who have spare economic resources can use them to make the world a better place. Personally, my own donations mostly go towards helping animals, particularly around the issue of factory farming. Although I donate to human rights and environmental causes, I consciously choose to weight more heavily towards animal issues. Someone might look at this and say that I think animals are more important than humans, but that would be an error.

Each person who donates to good causes is just one of many individuals and corporations worldwide who also do so. Looking at statistics from a Giving USA report, over six hundred billion dollars was donated in the most recent year. The main charitable sectors this was donated to are, in order, religion, human services, education, foundations, public-society benefit, health, international affairs, and to arts, culture and humanities. The total given to the grouping of the environment and animals, is less than 25 billion, or about 3.8%. The Giving USA report unfortunately doesn't break down how much of that is for animals or the environment, but we would assume environmental issues such as climate change would receive a larger percentage of this figure. Statistics from Charity Navigator then break down the total donations to animals, and find the vast majority go towards companion animals, generally dog and cat shelters. Of the relatively small amount of money that is donating to help animals, less than 1% of those donations target farmed animal welfare.

When many vegans donate, they take this context into consideration. Farm animals, and to a lesser extent wild animals and the environment, are relatively neglected areas of the charity sector. By targeted donations towards neglected areas, your money can be used more effectively. Charities will focus initially on what we call the low hanging fruit, the areas where the least amount of resources will have the biggest impact.

So it's not because we don't care about human rights or other worthy causes that we choose to funnel most of our charitable giving towards animals. We weight our donations towards farmed animals because most people do the opposite.

Holistic healing

A plant-based diet reverberates positively out into the world in many ways beyond the lives of farmed animals. Livestock's inconvenient long shadow is involved in almost every environmental problem, from a local to a global scale. The way we farm animals is one of the primary drivers of the destructive Anthropocene, contributing to air pollution, water contamination, land degradation, species extinction, deforestation, invasive species and climate change. The scale of the livestock industry is almost unimaginable, with pasture covering over half the arable land of the Earth. Only a few per cent of the remaining mass of land animals are wild creatures, with the vast majority being either humans or their livestock. Two-thirds of the mass of all birds in the world is now farmed chickens. The land on which grain is grown to feed billions of livestock animals can be repurposed to provide for people in the remaining food-poor regions of the world. Most of the communicable diseases that have plagued humanity throughout history have been a result of our contact with animals, including colds and flu, COVID, the black death, smallpox, Ebola, and AIDS. Somewhere between two-thirds and three-quarters of global antibiotic production is fed to healthy livestock, a reality that threatens to undermine one of the great human health breakthroughs. A better world awaits humans, not just non-humans, if we can turn aside from eating and using others for our own purposes.

Whether we look into the eyes of a dog, a cow, or a child, we see something of ourselves mirrored back to us, eyes that are windows into a fellow mind that wonders. Many animals share with us deep parts of the magic that is consciousness; to justify diminishing or extinguishing that spark because they do not share our exact identity or capabilities is an injustice. We are all evolved earthlings, fellow strands in a web of life and consciousness who are sharing this experience of existence, together. The great power we hold collectively over the lives of other beings means that our moral choices require deep consideration.

Trying to live an ethical life can be difficult in a society that profits more from us living as consumerist automatons. Ethics asks much of us: to question the society around us, to change our habits and learn new ways of thinking, even though it might be more convenient for us to ignore them. The separation from our conformist selves can even cause friction in our lives among friends and family who would prefer that we validate their ethical position by perpetuating our conformity. There is a higher realm of being, though, one that calls to us beyond the small world of consumerism, human society and selfish desire. It is a life in which our goal is to continually widen our circles of thought and compassion and help others to do so. Our collective intellectual and moral progression is bound up in the liberation of those whom we oppress. The first ethical duty we owe to the world is to look at those whose oppression we contribute to. We do not need to make a choice between being ethical towards humans or animals; indeed, the highest ethics are achieved when we choose them both.

Thinkers throughout the ages have understood this, and I will leave you with some of their thoughts.

Whilst there are slaughterhouses, there will still be battlefields - Tolstoy

Until we stop harming all other living beings, we are still savages - Thomas Edison

We can judge the heart of a man by his treatment of animals - Immanuel Kant

If you have men who will exclude any of god's creatures from the shelter of compassion and pity, you will have men who will deal likewise with their fellow men - St Francis of Assisi

By killing, man suppresses in himself, unnecessarily, the highest spiritual capacity, that of sympathy and pity towards living creatures like himself - Tolstoy

While we ourselves are the living graves of murdered beasts, how can we expect any ideal conditions on this earth? - George Bernard Shaw

For as long as men massacre animals, they will kill each other - Pythagoras

The greatness of a nation and its moral progress can be judged by the way its animals are treated - Mahatma Gandhi

Until he extends the circle of his compassion to all living things, man will not himself find peace - Albert Schweitzer

14. Can't

Question

But you can't eat that!

Alternatives

It's not vegan, but it is gluten-free. Can you eat bread?

Summary

Non-vegans and new vegans focus on what vegans don't eat, whereas established vegans focus on the things they do eat. After being vegan for a time, your consciousness shifts as to what is and isn't food. Veganism is not about self-denial, though because it excludes some things, it can seem that way from the outside perspective of an animal-product-centred diet. Veganism is about aligning our consumption with our compassion, which is the opposite of self-denial, as it is about living in a way that expresses our best selves. Replacing a handful of ingredients is a small price to pay to be part of healing humanity's relationship with the non-human world. Given the almost infinite variety of the world's cuisines and plant foods, thinking that a vegan diet is inevitably uninteresting or limited is a failure of the imagination.

Discussion

Few people become vegans because they are looking for an identity or a belief system. For my own part, I didn't set out to become vegan. My journey started with learning about how veal was produced and deciding it was too cruel to eat. After this, I stopped eating animal products, mostly one at a time as I found out about the cruelty inherent in producing them. Refraining from eating each animal product was the result of educating myself and a deliberative process, not some attempt to become "vegan". Nothing stops me or other vegans from eating animal products, as embodied by the word "can't", except our concern for the animals involved. Perhaps this seems like nitpicking; after all, "can't" is only a word, but the fact that it is so often chosen over alternatives suggests that people are missing the salient point. Veganism is not like an allergy or a religious duty, but an ethical stance. This may seem like quibbling about the choice of words, but it's important to frame veganism as what it is: an active and powerful set of compassionate choices.

Something in the phrasing of the statement "You can't eat this" is revealing. After you have heard this phrase enough times, you start to wonder why people so commonly frame vegan dietary choices with the word "can't", rather than "won't" or "don't". The use of "can't" makes the phrase sound like something that is involuntary or not thought-through. There are people who "can't" eat things, such as people with allergies, intolerances, or taste aversions, but vegans are none of these. There are those who "can't" eat something because of the belief that doing so would cause them to lose favour with some higher power, or at least their religious

community. Performative renunciation, or aestheticism, too, is not what veganism is about.

Compassionate choices

Veganism is a boycott of unnecessary cruelty. Veganism is about our relationship with animals. It is not a club or an identity; not about purity or blind adherence to an arbitrary set of rules; it is not about vegans or even veganism. It isn't about vegans making "personal" choices, but rather the opposite. Veganism is about starting to take responsibility for the world beyond our person, and our contribution to suffering in it. What we “can’t” do is separate our lives and actions from all other life, for we are locked in an interdependent relation with it, one in which, as humans, we have inordinate power. In making choices about what to eat, we regularly and powerfully affect the world and the lives of others. If we could trace the origins of all the ingredients on our plates over months or years, they would reach out into a vast area of the earth, involving thousands of individuals and complex processes to bring them to you. The sheer scale of agricultural corporations that feed billions of people every day means that there are many potential ethical concerns involved. The ethics of how we eat is a complex intersection of corporations, governments, billions of consumers, millions of producers, countless wild and farmed animals, and our global environment. The decision to follow a vegan diet is a potent way to claim our power and responsibility within this complex system.

Defining veganism

What exactly is a vegan diet? What do and don't vegans eat?

The original Vegan Society, based in England, has a statement that most vegans take as the de facto definition:

"Veganism is a philosophy and way of living which seeks to exclude—as far as is possible and practicable—all forms of exploitation of, and cruelty to, animals for food, clothing or any other purpose; and by extension, promotes the development and use of animal-free alternatives for the benefit of animals, humans and the environment. In dietary terms, it denotes the practice of dispensing with all products derived wholly or partly from animals."

This makes a good start, but ethics is something that also needs to be thought through by each person. The Vegan Society, in its early days, didn't consider honey to be vegan, because it involved killing bees, cruelty such as sometimes wing clipping of queens, and stealing the products of their labour intended for their children. In 1948, the Vegan Society changed this stance. They went back and forth between considering honey vegan, not considering honey vegan, and declaring it a matter of individual conscience over the ensuing decades. In 1988, they returned to not considering honey a vegan product. This may even change again as more humane techniques for farming bees are created in the future, or as comparative psychology evolves. Veganism exists within a changing world, with cell-cultured meats, precision fermentation, new farming techniques, scientific understanding, and even the accuracy of many “mock” products creating an ever-evolving discussion about what should and shouldn’t be called vegan. Veganism must evolve as the world evolves, and not make the same mistake that many religions have, of fixing their morality at a point in time or on a set of ideas that lose relevance as the world around them changes.

As corporations that profit from factory farming begin to diversify into the growing vegan market, this diversification continues to complicate the ethics of food choices. Some vegans

won't buy products from companies that get most of their income from animal products, while others see this as a way of incentivising those companies towards more ethical production. Palm oil production, or other products that cause major species loss and deforestation, is not considered by many to be consistent with veganism. Others see environmental concerns, or concern about a relatively small number of wild animals compared to the lives of billions in factory farms, as being of lesser ethical importance. This is one of many ongoing debates about competing truths within the vegan community, with compassionate and sensible people on all sides. People who are unfamiliar with the diverse intellectual landscape of veganism often speak quite clumsily about it in black-and-white terms, such as "can" and "can't", but there are few sharp ethical lines in our dynamic and complex world.

To delve into this complexity, it's worth discussing Freeganism. Some people intellectually agree with all the arguments for the ethical necessity of veganism, but think that a moratorium on eating animal products doesn't always achieve the best outcome for animals or the planet. These people call themselves "freegans", people who combine vegan ethics with the vital issue of food waste. While a freegan will only purchase vegan products, they will eat animal products that would otherwise be discarded. This is often the motivation behind dumpster diving: rescuing and repurposing the vast amounts of food and other goods thrown away by businesses. Businesses regularly throw away food when it passes or nears its "best before" date. There is no environmental or ethical benefit in discarding something when all the misery and resource expenditure involved in its production has already happened. So long as you are not helping create a market for it, consuming products that would otherwise go to waste reduces your environmental and ethical footprint. Many vegans admire and understand freegans, but they no longer consider animal products to be food, and the idea of eating them provokes a disgust response.

Delving deeper

To complicate our ethical considerations further, there are people called ostro-vegans. Ostro-vegans consider only sentience - the level of conscious awareness and ability to experience things like pleasure and pain that a being has - as a factor in the ethics of their consumption.

The terms plant and animal seem pretty clear in our minds, but evolution is more subtle than such black-and-white terms can encompass. Evolutionary science points towards a vast, complex web of interrelated life. As far as we know, there is only one family of life on Earth; microbes appeared first, and plants and animals evolved from them. There are endless forms of life at each stage in this progression, both in terms of physical and mental attributes. Ostro-vegans are people who delve into these blurry lines between species, between plants and animals, sentient and non-sentient. They draw the line of compassionate duty in a related, but different place than vegans do.

There are creatures called bivalves, such as clams and mussels, that lack a centralised brain. They can make simple movements such as opening and closing their shells, but don't appear to have any of the internal wiring needed for consciousness. Do these seemingly simple creatures require the same moral consideration as clearly sentient beings such as pigs, chickens, cows, and tuna? Ostro-vegans consider it ethically acceptable to eat bivalves, and perhaps find it an easier diet to follow than veganism. In terms of social conformity, it is probably useful to be able to eat at least a small portion of the animal products people are so attached to. Although they don't see the need to eat these animals, many vegans are sympathetic to the ostro-vegan approach as more ethical and considered than that of most others.

Given the complexity of the world, the journey towards an ethical life sometimes seems like climbing an unfamiliar mountain. You see a peak above you and climb towards it. Only once you reach the summit of the first peak are you able to see another previously obscured, even higher, peak rising behind and above it. Veganism is not about ticking a list that offers ethical absolution, but rather a path we take, hoping that each step gets us closer to living ethically. Veganism is about trying to make the world kinder for all life, to be better than we were before, not about self-denial, moral purity or superiority.

When people start the vegan journey, they will often accidentally eat an animal product. A phrase one commonly hears from incredulous new vegans is some variation of "Why does this have milk solids/fish sauce/gelatine in it?" Many products that you wouldn't expect, such as flavoured potato crisps, might have dairy in the form of milk solids added to their flavouring. Even when one has been vegan for a long time, through accident or complacency, eating some animal products unfortunately happens. Some vegans get more upset about this than others, but from the point of view of the universe, the ethics of these small errors are less relevant. Ethics is about focusing on what we do and consume 99% of the time, rather than expending too much energy on the last 1%. It is the totality of our life and actions that is important, not the occasional, inevitable errant step. We learn, we move on.

Something that might seem strange to the uninitiated is that there are people who deliberately eat specific animal products and refer to themselves as vegans. It seems they would like to be vegan, but just can't quite be consistent with it. Some see this as harmless, or even a positive aspiration. Although ethically I think people who are mostly vegan are doing a lot of good, I'd prefer they didn't call themselves vegan. The word "Vegan" should mean something clear in the world. When someone goes into a restaurant or other setting and tells the cooks and chefs that they are vegan, there should be a clear idea of what that means. If the last person who came in said they were vegan but asked for cheese or fish, that is very confusing to food service professionals. The definition of veganism is simple: nothing from an animal. Busy cooks shouldn't have to have a conversation with each consumer to find out what the word vegan means to them. Though we should try to avoid dogmatism, veganism should also not be allowed to become a vague or meaningless term.

Veganism is a clear political statement to others about our ethical stance towards animals. It is important to display an ethically consistent message, a clear narrative light, for people to follow. Hypocrisy is often the easiest and most damning way that claims to morality can be undermined. What we say about ourselves, what we ask of others, should be consistent and clear. Whatever label someone attaches to themselves, vegan, vegetarian, pescetarian, freegan, ostro-vegan, or some other, they become a representative for that idea in the world. We all have a duty to represent the ethical labels we claim in a way that serves wider and higher purposes than ourselves. If we call ourselves vegan, we should be careful to be so, or just use a different term.

Is it vegan?

Only something capable of having a philosophy can really be vegan. So an ingredient can't be vegan, but "Is it vegan?" is a reasonable shorthand way to ask whether something is suitable for vegans. For some reason, what vegans eat is complicated or confusing in many people's minds. And it's not even just vegans who come across this. When you ask if something is suitable for vegans, incredibly often the answer will come back, "Is it gluten-free?" This shows not only that people have little idea about plant-derived diets, but also about gluten as well.

Given that people eating a standard Western diet will have gluten in nearly every meal, it's revealing how little they know about it. Gluten is part of grains, so it has no bearing on whether something is vegan or not. Indeed, seitan, a popular chewy ingredient in plant-based cooking, is made almost entirely from wheat gluten.

Some of the things that people regularly eat, and therefore assume they mustn't be vegan, can be amusing. I've heard all manner of odd things be questioned when someone sees me order or eat them. My personal list includes bread, pasta, beer, avocado, oat cream and peanut butter. I saw a video of someone the other day, after saying they wouldn't eat vegan food, trying to argue that chips/french fries weren't vegan. Again, it is revealing how little people understand their food, especially its ethical aspects. People conform to the food their culture and family serve up, and don't question it. They generally don't know in much detail what nutrients, or even ingredients, are in the foods they eat, much less the repercussions of their diet on the world. Of course, no one is born with an in-depth knowledge of nutrients. Most vitamins and minerals in the human diet weren't isolated until the 20th century. Given how consequential the ingredients and nutrients of our diets are, knowledge about them is essential for our health, as well as our ethics. If we find people with relatively open minds, starting discussions about food and ethics will not only be good for them, but also for animals and the environment.

We can start to demystify what vegans eat by pointing out that most people, especially those following a relatively healthy diet, will already be deriving the majority of their nutrients and calories from plant foods. By starting to make the unfamiliar familiar, we can help begin the process of people eating more consciously. For people who have grown up only knowing one way of thinking about their food, we need to lay the groundwork for another possible conception of their diets and themselves.

Focusing on what vegans can and can't eat mistakes the forest for the trees. Veganism is not a diet; it is a philosophy of compassion. People who mistake veganism for a diet display how little they understand its vital message for our world. Veganism is not about ticking some arbitrary boxes; it is about having a thought-through personal response to deep ethical questions about the way humans currently treat other life. Focusing on the "can't" in how vegans eat ignores the deep philosophy that the active choice to eat a plant-derived diet represents. What we "can't" do collectively is continue living in a way that depletes the shared living systems of this world. What we "can't" do is continue sending animals into slaughterhouses and factory farms and think our ethics towards animals shouldn't be questioned. What everyone "can" do is make more compassionate and thought-through choices about how what they consume affects the living beings and systems of this world.

15. Aspirational

Question

I am an animal lover

Alternatives

I'd love to be vegan but... I was vegan/vegetarian but...

Summary

Noble aspirations are fine, but it is putting them into practice that defines us. When our lives are reflected upon, including by ourselves, we will be judged more by what we have done than what we wish we had done. The most important step in the process of self-actualisation is to make our lives consistent with our ethical aspirations. We may love animals or wish there was less suffering in the world, but if we don't believe these things strongly enough to alter our behaviour, our good intentions are largely meaningless. Kind thoughts, prayers, virtue signalling, and policing language become problematic when they are the extent of your activism. Love, compassion and kindness must be active. It is the realm of sentient experience that ultimately matters, not the construction of your internal world.

Discussion

Veganism is an idea that has become more embedded in the mainstream in recent decades. Our society has become more conscious, often uncomfortably so, of the ethical conversation around the treatment of animals, and by extension veganism. Our world was very different only recently, when few people knew what the word vegan meant. Elder vegans will recount having to constantly explain their veganism at the most basic level; regularly even having to spell the unfamiliar word for people. This was a time when most people thought being vegetarian was about abstaining only from red meat. "What about fish?" was the most common question vegetarians were asked. Veganism was a whole other level. Personally, I had to explain what being vegan meant, and how it was spelled, almost every time I went out to eat with new people. In developed societies now, we have progressed; most people are at least vaguely familiar with and can even spell the term. It is now even common to see vegan options on restaurant menus, products marked vegan-friendly, and even to bump into vegans in social situations. It may not always feel like a sign of progress, but we also now often bump into people who have considered veganism or even tried it. All these are positive signs that veganism and the ideas it represents are on an upward historical trend.

We seem to be heading, all too slowly, towards a vision of the future many vegans believe in: that the moral arc of history will bend towards justice for animals. We assume that the widespread embrace of vegan philosophy is inevitable; that humanity's collective ethical progress will take us beyond the commonplace disregard, oppression and slaughter of other

animals. We believe in a society where one day people will be mystified that so many people unquestioningly participated in this vast atrocity against animals.

Many things once considered commonplace we now consider barbaric. A common question often asked of eminent ethical thinkers is: "What do we currently think of as normal behaviour that future generations will look upon as barbaric?" I have seen this question asked to people like Noam Chomsky, Steven Pinker, Martha Nussbaum, and Richard Dawkins. They all replied that our treatment of animals was a likely candidate. Sadly, few of these eminent thinkers have followed through with this belief and gone on to become vegan or even vegetarian themselves. When I met Peter Singer, I asked him how he felt about his conversation on the topic of animal rights with Richard Dawkins. Singer told me how hard it was for him, given his high regard for Dawkins as a thinker, to understand his cognitive dissonance in knowing what we do to animals is wrong, but being unable to change his behaviour towards them.

Ethical Consistency

It would be very inefficient to think through everything we do in our lives. Instead, we live mostly through habit and conformity. Most people do this with respect to eating animals; it is something they have always done but have never questioned. Here we get to a moral question: is it worse to do something you know is wrong than to do the same thing without knowing it is wrong? For the animals, their suffering is the same regardless of the intentions or knowledge in the mind of the person committing or paying for their abuse. We might say someone who worries about the lives of animals in factory farms has a kinder personality. Still, if they do not change their behaviour towards those animals, then their effect upon the world is no different to a less kind person. If our ethical framework allows us to contribute to animals spending nasty, brutish and short lives in factory farms and slaughterhouses, partly because we can't be bothered learning how to eat or cook something else, then it is a very narrow ethical outlook. People may look to the ethical norms of the culture around them for support in their own behaviours, and find justification in the fact that they are only doing what their family, friends, co-workers and much of society do, but ethics is not a popularity contest. Indeed, the opposite is probably more often true. The most powerful and noble expressions of ethics are when people reject conformity to the society around them, and claim their most meaningful individuality, their ethical individuality.

Moral imperatives

The fact that so many people know about veganism is a good thing. We should celebrate the positives that this change in social narrative represents. We must remember, however, that we want the focus to be on the animals and not on vegans. Many people will be happier shooting the vegan messenger instead of engaging with the issue that we represent. Those who argue against veganism are not necessarily our most powerful adversaries, however. The opposite of engagement is often not argument, but indifference. Those who are willing to discuss animal rights or veganism, even if they defend a counter position, are in some way our allies in ensuring the topic is in people's consciousness. It is mindlessness that underlies animal oppression. We push animal industries beyond the edges of our urban environments, out of sight, out of mind. Truth dies in darkness, and the darkness of factory farms and slaughterhouses is very deep indeed. By encouraging ethical discussion about the status of animals, we are moving society forwards. So long as the discussion about our moral duties towards animals remains a rational discussion, it is one that vegans must ultimately win.

We must remember in making our case that not everyone is in the same place in their thoughts about this topic. There are many people in the world whose minds are closed to change, or happily dwell in selfishness and egocentrism, and they will actively resist our calls for kinder treatment of animals. That is not everyone, however. There are many decent people who eat animal products because they just haven't yet given it the moral attention it deserves. There are many reasons for this, life situations and so on, but one is that we take our cues from the people around us. A relevant psychology experiment showed our tendency towards conformity. Researchers had a research subject sit in a room along with some confederates of the researchers, who pretended they were also research subjects. The researchers set a smoke machine outside of a door to the room, and blew smoke in under the door. Whether or not the research subject worried about the smoke was highly correlated with whether the confederates of the researchers displayed any worry about it. If the researchers asked their confederates to pretend to be worried that the smoke meant there was a fire, the research subject was more likely to be worried. If the researchers told their confederates to all act like the smoke was nothing, the research subject was more likely to act that way as well. This is relevant to the subject of animal rights, because much of our society acts like it is nothing to be concerned about, and this makes it harder for individuals to escape that framing and see that it is something we should be concerned about. There are many reasons that, due to social conditioning, decent people might be resistant to our message on behalf of animals. On some deeper level, it is good people's self-interest to be open to a positive change, but we need to make a positive and consistent case to help them see it.

Engaging people

Hope can be a double-edged sword when you are trying to help animals. If someone starts explaining why they might consider or have considered a vegan diet, and says there is some hurdle in the way, most vegans will instinctively want to help the person overcome their hurdle. This is the natural and logical thing to do, but then you get into the complexity that often people are more interested in justifying why they can't be vegan than they are in seriously looking to change. Coming up with an easy fix to their stated problem isn't helping them; it just makes them have to come up with another reason. If this cycle repeats a bit, you might even start annoying the person, because you are backing them into a corner. They are being a little disingenuous, but maybe not consciously, and they certainly don't want it revealed to them. The fact that you tried to help the animals and the person here, but ended up annoying the person, doesn't mean you did anything wrong. Even when we start to suspect someone is just making excuses, the best policy is usually to treat what they say at face value. We should avoid making negative assumptions about why someone is resisting positive change, and try to give them the benefit of the doubt. It's easy to misjudge others' intentions or viewpoints; we all fall into stereotypes and assumptions. Just because someone is asking a lot of questions and being sceptical doesn't mean they aren't open to change. In a society where people are a mark for others, where people are always trying to convince others to buy their product, follow their religion, or to believe or do some other thing they want, we should expect people to be a bit defensive. We should make a good case, and we should make it clear what our motivations are: the animals.

Perhaps the first thing to remember is that, no matter how well thought-through and expressed all your points are, it is rare that at the end of a single conversation you will have converted someone to veganism. Sometimes being too good at arguing, and having all the points on hand to every question, can even overwhelm people. We might be better off listening more and focusing on one or two main points that are most important to the person we are talking to.

Having a detailed, conversation-ending answer for every justification you have heard a hundred times before, drowning a person in facts rather than empathy, and ignoring their unique, complex emotional reality can all be counterproductive. We need to have the conversation the person needs and is open to, which helps them change their frame of reference. We definitely don't want to repeat the standard conversation we have rehearsed in our minds. We also often embark upon conversations we think would have resonated with us before we were vegan, without recognising that we all have different levels of openness to change in different contexts in our lives. There is not one conversation, but perhaps a different one for each person, at each different moment in their lives. Perhaps the most helpful thing to remember in talking to random people is: "We are not our audience".

Effective conversation

What will make people change? When people are asked why they became vegan, they will often give a very specific answer. For instance, they read a pamphlet, watched a video or were positively influenced by a person. No doubt these were pivotal moments, but there is usually a long process that leads to people being receptive to the right information at that moment. Why did someone decide to read that pamphlet, talk to that person, or watch that video? A foundation needs to be laid in each of us, a crack in the conformity of our minds opened so that a little light can seep in. A different world/self might need to be made conceptually possible before there is a chance for greater change. Does someone even know about factory farms, or do they assume animals probably have reasonable lives in them, or do they think the way we treat animals might be wrong but don’t know what to do about it, or are they vegetarian because they instinctively think killing animals is wrong but don’t properly understand the death and suffering in the egg and dairy industries, or are they attracted to the idea of veganism but just need to know what steps to take, or something else unique to them. Chances to sincerely discuss our relationship with the non-human world are precious; we should not squander them with the discussion we want to have, engage in circling debate, or give people information overload. We have to focus on the person in front of us and how we can help them on the next step of their ethical journey, even if they don’t know they are on one yet.

Communication is hard because people are complex and unique; they are often so very different from us as to be almost unrelatable. Drawing broad lines here, some people will judge a discussion by its rationality; they are best reached via a clear, coherent argument, and too much emotion will make them feel they are being manipulated. Others are more sensitive to the interpersonal aspects of a conversation. Too little emotion might come off as cold. Facts aren’t inconsequential to the latter sort of person, but an emotional connection with them, and the animals are more likely to resonate. People have different life experiences, cultures, sensitivities, and levels of tolerance for difficult topics. People also have psychological defence mechanisms, and many will instinctively turn away from discussions or depictions of suffering, perhaps as echoes or reminders of their own pain or trauma. Some people might be willing to hear the full horrors of animal farming, and others might need more of a focus on the positive alternatives to animal farming. People are also at different stages of knowledge about issues and varying openness to change; in short, some need to know why, but others need to know how. Blundering into a system as complex as the human mind without understanding it is usually a mistake. If someone says "I can’t be vegan", we have to start by listening carefully to what follows next.

Vegans and ex-vegans

One place where many passionate vegans can be short-sighted is in their attitude towards people who used to be vegan. “They were never really vegan” is almost a cliché in such situations. This mindset ignores many realities and circumstances in people’s lives. The most obvious is that sometimes people need a few attempts at making life changes, even ones they want and believe in. Perhaps people were undergoing something emotionally challenging while they were trying to become vegan, and might just need some healing and re-energising before they will be ready to try again. People’s motivations for going vegan also vary. Not everyone becomes vegan for animal rights or from a reverence for the non-human world. Some come to it for health, or because they were in a relationship or social circle that made it easy for them to be vegan. They might not see stopping being vegan as betraying the animals, because for them, it was never really about the animals in the first place. The attrition rate of vegans, especially those who aren’t motivated by ethical considerations, is high. When someone is vegan, many in the movement kind of think of that as a "tick", and if we focus on them at all, it might be about how we get them to become activists. Our movement focuses too much on getting people to become vegan and doesn’t do enough work on helping already existing vegans to be happy, healthy, socially connected and well-informed.

I've known people who went from being quite radical vegans to not being. Almost always though, they eat a lot fewer animal products than most people in society. They also are much more likely, in the initial stages at least, to choose less cruel options such as free-range eggs. They are also much more likely to adopt a vegan diet in the future than others I know. I've had people who returned to long-term veganism thank me for not ostracising them for the time when they couldn't sustain it. Social connections to vegans are perhaps the greatest predictor of people eating vegan meals and adopting veganism. Cutting our connections with people who are vegan adjacent is a bad idea if we want to help animals over the longer term.

Speaking about social connection, not all social circles are as tolerant of veganism as they should be. If someone is the only, or one of the only, vegans in their family, social circle, relationship, workplace or community, it is going to be harder for them to stay vegan than for others. We need to think about how we can help people foster a community that makes it easier for them to make ethical choices without negative social ramifications. Just being around a group of kind, committed vegans every now and then can be a balm for many people; it can help them feel less alone and different in the world.

Over promising

With health, many vegans can promote unrealistic claims for the vegan diet. Literally, people will say vegans never get sick. When I posted on social media that I was getting the COVID vaccine, an acquaintance commented that I was automatically immune to the virus because I was vegan. Some people who are vegan don't even advocate taking a regular B12 supplement or making sure to get regular calcium or omega-3-rich plant foods. Not only are these positions dangerous and empirically untrue, but promoting veganism as a miracle cure can lead to disappointment and disillusionment. The highest nutritional bodies in the world reaffirm that a well-planned vegan diet is consistent with good health at all life stages, and may bring some benefits, but the evidence for veganism as a panacea simply isn’t there. It should be enough to know, given all the environmental and animal suffering benefits, that we can live more ethically while still fulfilling our health needs, and can maybe be even healthier if we plan our diet well. Selling people a miracle cure might gain some temporary vegans, but they might also

become vocal proponents against veganism when the magic fails to happen, or signs of some nutrient deficiency start to kick in. They might also leave veganism when the next fad diet comes by, because it was never about the animals. We want a movement for the long haul, and that means preferring to make long-term vegans over short-term victories.

Conclusion

The main regret of people who go vegan is that they didn't do it sooner. So if someone is thinking about getting on the vegan train, it's in their best interest to get on board as soon as possible. Of course, there are many things people should be doing: most people should also exercise more, sleep better, create less waste, ride a bicycle, meditate and practise an instrument. The fact that most people aren’t living their best lives is not always purely a moral failing, but a reflection of the fact that people have many competing priorities for their physical and mental energy. Our social circles and even our culture generally don’t always make positive change easy. As vegans, we might need to be patient and consistent with people. We should concentrate on setting a positive example, being kind, giving people space, and in all ways make clear from our words and actions that we are trying to help rather than convince or manipulate them. If you have a choice between dominating an argument or making someone feel heard and giving a positive impression of veganism, you might think about leaning towards the latter.

As much as we personally identify with veganism, it is not about us or our egos. We are speaking for the others who are voiceless, and we have a responsibility to do it effectively. Some of the most vociferous, hardline vegans I have met seemed to put more people off veganism than draw them to it. They are the sort of people who say: "All activism is good activism". Being right, coming from the moral high ground, is not enough; ego is often the main barrier between us and our connection with others. Almost any conversation about veganism is a chance for change, but sometimes the most change we can make is to plant seeds that might bear fruit later. By exhibiting a consistent compassion in our conversations, we can try to be the personal embodiment of our message. We should try to be the person the animals need us to be.

16. Preachy

Question

Why are vegans so preachy?

Alternatives

Live and let live. Each to their own. What I eat is a personal choice.

Summary

People are preachy about many things, and maybe compassion for animals is one of the less objectionable things to be preachy about. How someone preaches is important, however. Regardless of how important someone feels that their particular cause is, they should be respectful in the way they advocate for it, even if only for pragmatic reasons. Like any large group of people, we will find vegans with varying social and communication skills. Some vegans may argue in an unempathetic way, but how well someone presents an argument or idea does not tell us whether their viewpoint is important or true. If someone makes a poor case when telling you that you should stand against a moral atrocity, it should not leave you free to ignore the moral atrocity. Few vegans want to preach, and maybe if people who eat animal products gave animals their due consideration and respect, they wouldn't have to.

Discussion

Vegan Stereotypes

With millions of vegans around the world, there is not a single typical vegan. Vegans reflect the diversity of humanity, with all its flaws, biases and varying levels of emotional intelligence. There are sweet vegans, sarcastic vegans, nerdy vegans, cool vegans, and grumpy vegans. Actually, many vegans can be any one of these depending on what time and day you happen to meet us. There will inevitably be some vegans who are overly hostile and judgmental, but for the majority of vegans, just like everyone else, we might just come off that way some of the time.

Before judging someone for preaching, think for a second about what they are preaching about. Imagine for a moment that what vegans are saying is true, actually is true. The basic vegan position is that animal farming, especially industrial animal farming, is irreparably cruel. That to take the life, liberty, and pursuit of their natural desires away from billions of animals, all to create luxury ingredients that humans don't really need, is ethically wrong. Surely it doesn't take too much of a stretch to look at the life of a chicken in the average factory farm and think, maybe vegans are right that this is a moral atrocity. If the industrial animal farming system is a moral atrocity, then what duty do we owe the animals in that system? To speak for them, to defend their interests, to encourage other people to boycott the system which is built

on their suffering?

I would argue that vegans have a duty to preach. The caveat to this is that they have a duty to preach effectively. Shouting at people that they should change is only an ethical act if that is an effective strategy. If your tactics create barriers to change, if they make vegans the centre of the discussion rather than animals, if they stoke an instinctive, oppositional defensiveness in people, then your tactics are unethical. The important point in communication is doing it in such a way that you can be heard.

The Vegan Police

Let's focus on the small number of vegans who are hostile and judgmental much of the time. The word "militant" might often be used here. Militant people generally don't restrict themselves to being this way only to non-vegans. They consider themselves the moral arbiters of how everyone should act, especially other vegans. There is even a phrase used within the vegan movement for such people: The Vegan Police.

The Vegan Police believe they have it all figured out. They are hostile to any and all people who don't follow their dictates, and cause conflict wherever they go. They feel that expressing their personal viewpoint is more important than any other duties they owe to people or animals. Their lack of politeness, empathy and consideration sends out the opposite message to the one that is at the core of veganism: compassion for other beings. Of course, for people who crave attention, causing conflict is a surefire way to get it. In making conversations about veganism end up focusing on themselves, however, they do a disservice to the movement and the animals.

Judgmental vegans have a thought-terminating saying to justify being unkind: "All activism is good activism". Clearly this isn't true, and anyone repeating it needs to think harder. People can, by their negative personal example, discourage others from listening to the vegan message or eating fewer animal products. You may object to this, that people should only be influenced by what someone says rather than how they say it, but that would be to display a level of naivety about how most people work. People can very easily "get their backs up", especially around sensitive topics where they feel someone is criticising their ethics. How you say something is as important as what you say. No, of course, not all preaching is good preaching.

Among the many different personality types who are vegans, there will be some who exhibit dark triad qualities. The problem, though, is that people have a habit of placing other people into boxes that they assign qualities to. We call these stereotypes, and we all have them. Vegans are still relatively few in number, and if someone hasn't met many vegans and meets a difficult vegan, they might assume that this is what a vegan is. The box with the word vegan on it is associated with being judgemental or difficult, and they won't look favourably on the concept of veganism. This is unjust towards veganism. Veganism is a philosophy about our relationship with the non-human world. Compassion towards animals is a universal idea that no individual or group owns. Even the Vegan Society of the UK, which gave us both the word vegan and the most widely accepted definition of veganism, doesn't own an idea that long predated their formation.

Anyone who has had bad experiences with a preachy vegan should try this social experiment: tell people you are vegan for a while. You'll quickly find that people on all sides of the topic can

be preachy. You will experience the sort of repetitive conversations and reactions that vegans get all the time, indeed the exact motivations that lead to writing what you are reading right now! Things have generally improved in this regard. Most people are more considerate; a few are even interested in knowing more about veganism. Some people, however, seem to have a major prejudice against veganism, often along with other forms of socially progressive ideas. Disliking vegans is highly correlated with disliking environmentalists and feminists. That said, many social progressives also have a major blind spot when it comes to animal agriculture. In the end, for all the preachy vegans that might exist in the world, there are many more preachy non-vegans who get quite annoyed or angry about the idea of greater compassion towards non-human animals.

Many vegans have been in the situation of being out for a meal and enquiring about vegan options. Another person at your table, usually but not exclusively male, gets triggered by hearing the word vegan and starts upon a series of poorly informed questions and statements. What makes this worse is that in many social situations the hostile person is speaking for the majority around the table. Their poorly informed side of the argument will therefore get a very sympathetic hearing. Arguing against a mob, no matter how irrational and poorly informed they are, is a difficult task. The problem partly stems from the fact that humans tend to be status-seeking animals rather than truth-seeking ones; if someone says something, what matters is not how insightful or true it is, but whether the surrounding people nod their heads in agreement. It may be unfair; you may have the ethical and logical high ground in the conversation, but if you fail in the court of public opinion, you and the animals have not won.

There is another problem: when one person argues against a number of people, they have a smaller percentage of time to present the opposing opinion. We may protest that ideas should be judged by their ethics and logic alone, but we know that is not reality. Studies have shown that in meetings, the people who speak the most often sway the day, not the people who know the most. Non-conformists will always be held to higher standards than the majority, and this is just part of life. Vegans must keep their poise and bring the conversation back to the ethics of our treatment of animals and the philosophy of veganism, not on vegans themselves.

Communicating across the divide

As ethical vegans, most of us will have read the books and watched the videos. Some of us have even heard the cries from within factory farms, and smelt the stench that farmed animals are forced to live in. We know and feel the emotional angst and frustration that preachy vegans are expressing at this unnecessary human-caused suffering. But we must also recognise that non-vegans haven't had these realisations. They may know about the death in meat production, but have precious little knowledge about animal farming beyond that. They live in a different, and partly illusional, emotional and intellectual landscape. They do not think of farmed animals as individual beings with their own hopes, fears and personalities, but rather just a blurry space, lumped in with food, on the edge of their consciousness. They often assume that if what vegans were saying about the way animals are treated on farms was true, then some authority would step in and do something about it. They might reason, if it is so bad, then why isn't everyone upset about their treatment? Why indeed. People resist seeing vegans as advocates for a reduction of violence towards animals, because to acknowledge the truth of this would be to reveal their own complicity in that violence. It is important for their own psychological state to paint vegans as status-seeking people trying to feel superior. This same ad hominem trick is played against environmentalists, feminists, etc. If you cannot pick apart an argument you don't wish to acknowledge the truth of, then you demean the character of anyone making the

argument.

To be fair, people have had to build up resistance to various entities trying to inhabit a piece of their mind, such as religions, politicians, marketers, influencers, salespeople, scammers and charlatans. We must also add ethical people to this, asking people to care about the rainforests, climate change, plastic pollution, air pollution, hunger in the third world, disadvantaged youths, refugees, and the list just goes on. Everyone wants your attention to their issue; some of them are preying on you, some are trying to do good in the world, but it's not always easy to tell the difference. Vegans need to recognise this reality, and consistently behave in a way that makes clear we are not just selfishly promoting our own interests. By carrying ourselves in such a way as to resonate with the compassion in others, rather than their defensiveness or sense of shame, we can most effectively advocate for the animals. This may require many of us to do some internal work, but learning to communicate in a kinder, more empathetic and ethically consistent way is work most people should do at some point in their lives, even for purposes other than vegan advocacy. It doesn't matter what is in our hearts; people can only hear us if we are able to effectively communicate what is within us via our words and demeanour.

Preaching to the converted

While we're on the subject of preaching, among people who consider themselves activists, perhaps no other cliché is more often said after a speech or discussion than "Aren't we just preaching to the converted?" This treats something like veganism as a binary state, where you are vegan and saved, or you are a heathen who needs to come into the light. Veganism may be something close to a moral baseline, but it is not the end of our journey towards a healthy, ethical or fulfilled life. People shouldn't just be converted and left to their own devices; they should be continually educated, inspired, included, energised and re-energised. The converted don't need the same message, though; I've been in a room full of vegans where someone gives some version of the talk "Why you should go vegan". That is the wrong talk for that audience; people need to consider their audience and pass on the information that will best help them further along the ethical path.

I've also heard talks that seemed to rely on you already agreeing with what they said to enjoy them, or even really hear them. If you give a talk encouraging veganism to a mixed audience, it doesn't really matter if all the vegans in the room are nodding when you are saying things that the non-vegans just can't relate to. To the unconverted, you need more basic, targeted, subtle and thoughtful ways of engaging. Vegans may cheer your preaching on from the sidelines; you might even gain a following or some groupies, but it’s probably not effective in achieving what should be your aims: helping animals. We must hold our arguments to a different, more careful standard when talking to people who don't agree with us; we must try to speak in such a way that even the people who want to disagree with your perspective can’t help but acknowledge the merits of what we say.

The psychological disconnect

Whilst discussing perspective, it’s interesting what is considered preaching and what isn't. Generally, what people agree with is the good sort of preaching and what they disagree with is the bad sort.

An example of how subjective ethics can be involved a group called The Coalition for the

Protection of Racehorses, which erected a billboard showing a racehorse that had been injured during a race. The horse was lying down on its side, and although this wasn't made evident on the billboard, people could assume that the horse was awaiting being put to death. The activist group was soon notified by the landowner that the billboard had been taken down because people in the community were disturbed by the image of the injured horse. The whole purpose of the billboard was, of course, to stop this happening to horses. By taking it down, it was making it more likely that this would happen to horses.

Compare this billboard with the billboards, also featuring animals, that litter our suburbs and roadscapes, blights on our urban scenery that are considered commonplace and never questioned. These billboards feature detached parts of animals, usually pigs, cattle and chickens, who have been deliberately killed while still children, then have been dismembered and burnt. Displaying the parts of these animals is apparently fine because it is then labelled “food”, causing people to disassociate from the individual animals involved. These injunctions to consume more animal products, to promote more murder, are apparently socially acceptable. A billboard showing an animal in distress and calling for greater compassion towards them, however, draws complaints and condemnation. People are happy seeing chunks of flesh of murdered farm animals, but they don't like to see a different kind of animal lying, waiting to be murdered. Perhaps nothing could be as clear in showing the disconnect between the food on people's plates, which people see as a disembodied product, and the lives of the animals from which that food comes.

It’s not just what you see that creates your world, but also the story you tell, or choose not to tell, yourself internally about it. Is that a piece of food, or is it the burnt flesh of an intensively bred, malformed animal murdered prematurely after a terrible life? For people who eat meat, it is clearly both, but for some reason, whether it be habit, intellectual self-defence, or self-interested bias, they often only see the former. Our worldview can be so hardened and habitual to us that it can be hard to even comprehend someone if they are saying something that contradicts it. Studies show us that people find it harder to pay attention to and recall images that they find psychologically discomforting. People will subconsciously avoid disturbing elements in images, as if some subconscious or preconscious part of the brain is filtering information before it gets into their conscious attention. People also find it harder to recall images with disturbing aspects to them. A common vegan meme is to say "I can show a video of my food being made without a graphic content warning". Given that what goes on in slaughterhouses and factory farms is so disturbing to normal individuals, it makes sense that psychological mechanisms will come into play. Vegans are therefore not just trying to inform people, but trying to change their current frame of reference, often at least partly against their subconscious will. The task of advocating for animals is not just putting information out into the world about the treatment of animals; we have to help people open themselves to uncomfortable information in a way that doesn’t provoke emotional self-defence mechanisms, and that is considerate of other traumas that people might already be dealing with. None of this is easy, but it is a challenge we must accept to best help the animals.

If I were an animal bred in a factory farm or on my way to slaughter, I’d desperately hope someone would be preaching for me, but more importantly, I would want them to be most effectively helping me. Being right is not enough; shouting at the world in anger is probably counter-productive. The point is to change the world, to make ethical progress. People rarely change from one fact, phrase, sign, t-shirt, interaction or conversation, and will often be especially resistant to this if it is put to them in a hostile or confrontational manner. As much as the thought of billions of animals in factory farms and slaughterhouses burns most vegans,

as urgent as the task before us is in the face of so much suffering, we have to accept that the world is unlikely to suddenly awaken to reality tomorrow. We need to put some thought into long-term, structural strategies that involve a wide range of disciplines, from psychology to philosophy, economics, nutrition, and politics. Emotions are vital in motivating us, but their power needs to be carefully harnessed within a rational framework so that we are most effective.

If you want to be an effective vegan advocate, especially if you want to be a preachy vegan, you need to do the work. Read about psychology and effective behaviour change, the history of our movement and its thinkers, the arguments and justifications of the other side, the lives of farmed animals, the livestock industry's effects on the environment, human rights and our political systems. You don't have to know everything; indeed you should be quick to acknowledge that you don't, but you don't want to come off as either ill-informed or overly emotionally motivated. Like any conversation, it is important to have the facts on your side, to try to listen, seriously consider other points of view, make them feel heard and look for common ground on which to build. Keep in mind, before we judge others, that most of us haven't always been vegan, and try to tap into how you might have felt about the conversation back in your pre-vegan days. Also, being vegan doesn't mean we don't have our own areas to ethically improve upon, so let us remember we are trying to move forward ethically, together.

Open doors

There is also the issue of preaching effectively, of using our emotional resources and time to achieve the best outcome for animals. The random people you meet on a street, who walk past a protest, even your friends and family, might not be the subset of the community most open to change. There are, however, large numbers of people beyond your immediate social interactions who are actively pondering a vegan diet, or could be easily convinced to move in that direction. The main thing these people want or need is a little hand up. Finding these people and helping them, what we call "pushing on open doors", can be a more effective and less confrontational form of activism. You can do this by things like cooking classes, vegan mentoring, introductions to plant-based diets, baketivism, and so on. I've been involved in some amazing programs we called Vegan Pledges, where groups of people were taken through a program to help them try being vegan for a month. The pledge was free for participants, and included food samples, nutrition advice, mentoring, events and group support; it was incredibly effective. You don't have to come up with all the strategies yourself; there have been so many smart activists around the world, and things they have tried, you just need to learn about and familiarise yourself with them.

When it comes to effective activism, not only don't you have to do it yourself, you probably shouldn't. If you want to make a change at a wider level, being part of an activist group, or starting one if you absolutely have to, is a way of multiplying and strengthening our individual efforts. Having a group to think about plans and campaigns with, and to implement them, means you can do more ambitious and well-thought-through things. A group benefits from having a variety of personalities, skills, knowledge, ideas and perspectives; it can also keep going when "life happens", and people drop in and out over time. Also, people can concentrate on the things that they enjoy, and focus on the tasks the group needs that might be better for introverts, extroverts, neurodiverse, and neurotypical people, and so on. I used to help run volunteer inductions for an Animal Liberation organisation, and if there was one thing I found hard to get across to people, it was that activism was much wider than the confrontational "go vegan now" style. Organisations, especially smaller community ones, need lots of different

skills, from various professional services to fundraising, marketing, committee membership, handy work, event preparation, baking and so on. Indeed, just turning up, doing what you say you will do, being nice to everyone, and being reliable is perhaps the best trait any volunteer can have in a group. If you truly have the urge to preach, that's fine, but if you just want to help animals, there are many other ways to do so.

Speaking for them

Sometimes we refer to non-human animals as the voiceless. Many people point out that animals do speak for themselves, as they instinctively cry out against the injustices and pain that are inflicted upon them as standard practices in animal agriculture. Those cries, however, will never be heard by the consumers who pay to have these animals bred, confined and slaughtered on their behalf. We have banished the slaughterhouses and factory farms well out beyond the urban and suburban environments most people live in. The animals people eat are barely real beings to the consumers who have so much power to decide their fate. We must help people to hear the voices of those animals; we have a duty to speak for them, indeed, even to preach for them in the right time and place.

To take it upon ourselves to speak for another being, though, requires a high bar of consideration. If we have to preach, we need to do it thoughtfully. We need to focus on what helps animals, not just what we personally want to do. Just preaching because it makes us feel better to "get it out", especially if we are acting in such a way that it actively discourages people from the cause we are preaching for, is not a good thing in itself. You should be angry about the way animals are treated; other people should also be angry about it, but triggering irrational forces like anger is unpredictable and likely to backfire. I have spent time with cows, pigs, chickens, goats, ducks and other animals at sanctuaries. When I think about how gentle most farmed animals are, how much they appreciate a kind voice and touch, it inspires me to try to embody the peaceful way they generally are in how I communicate on their behalf.

You may not care what other people think of you and your way of being in the world. You may even wear your prickly individualism like a badge of honour, perhaps rejecting the world before it can reject you. This may win you fans in the right social circles, but the world we are trying to change is much more vast. To be a vegan is to be part of the idea of what vegan means for the people we encounter. Like it or not, whatever identity we have, especially if we are in a minority, we will be a representative of that identity in the world. We may not choose the responsibility of defining what veganism is for other people, but it is thrust upon us every time we say we are vegan, wear a vegan shirt, or order a vegan meal. To be an effective advocate for animals, we must understand that our medium and our message are inextricably intertwined. Veganism is about compassion for all animals, humans included, so let us embody that consistently so as not to confuse that simple truth in other people’s minds. Preach, but preach effectively.